

the breakup
journal.

I love this
version of
myself
that you
brought out.

a memoir of a broken heart

poems, thought essays, and journal entries
relating to heartbreak and healing

jaymen chang

I LOVE THIS VERSION OF
MYSELF THAT YOU BROUGHT
OUT.

A memoir exploring poems, thought essays and
journal entries from a heartbreak.

To the versions of myself that needed this, and to the
versions of myself that will need this.

The container with which we use to experience pain is the
very same with which we use to experience joy.

AUTHOR PREFACE

The intention of this book is to share my thoughts and feelings from a personal (and biased) point of view. There may be ideas that don't fit a particular person, and it isn't meant to be a formulaic solution/answer to heartbreak. Heartbreak has infinite complexities and nuances, and my intention with this book is to share my own perspective/experience (which may even be wrong). I am neither an author nor a poet. Some of these chapters can be repetitive, and similar at times, even contradicting, and I recognize this is a part of my writing style.

I am an extremely flawed human being, with red flags I'm sure I could write a book about. This piece of writing isn't meant to discount that or claim that I'm above any of that, but rather an admittance of it. I am continuously learning about my flaws, and trying to improve on them.

Not everything in this book is for everyone, and there needs to be nuance applied to many perspectives. If you were abused (emotionally or physically) or your relationship was "toxic" (however you define this), then maybe it may not be helpful for you to read this book. (I wanna add a nuanced disclaimer here for readers)

Heartbreak like many things in life, is a complex, contradictory, and painful process. Yet, it's quite a universal experience for many people. My intention with this book is to share my different thoughts and explorations of the many

complexities of healing and the letting go process. The book is a collection of my thought essays, journal entries, unsent letters, and poems relating to the most impactful heartbreaks in my life so far. I truly believe that it's these pivotal moments in our lives that can be the most transformative and evolutionary situations we can find ourselves in.

I've found myself in different positions during heartbreak, different situations, and feeling many different ways. But the common denominator is that I always find some lesson at the heart of the experience.

Every heartbreak that we go through is an opportunity. There are endless amounts of energy involved in love/heartbreak, and should we choose to transmute the energy, we can create anything that we desire.

Generally, the preferred term in this book is "significant person" (SP), but the word "ex" is used sometimes as well. This is to capture the fact that heartbreak isn't one dimensional and may not always involve a traditional "ex".

DISCERNMENT: THE COURAGE TO BE WRONG (OR RIGHT)

In the context of healing, discernment is the ability to pick and choose what makes sense in the context of your healing. It's very much the same for heartbreak.

But what if we choose wrong?
Then we accept and learn.

Part of healing and rediscovering yourself is being able to listen to your inner voice and intuition. This is not your mind, but what you know on a spiritual level is right for you. There is no "one size fits all" piece of advice or "one way to live" that aligns with every single person. Humans are not so simplistic.

Part of the reason we fear discernment is because of our fear of being wrong. Be courageous enough to be wrong, because either you discover something people haven't come across or you learn something about yourself. There is no losing. As you read through this book, don't take anything as sacred. Question everything you read, and really ponder why it makes sense (or doesn't). This is the way to heal. Because what makes you happy and what works for you may not work for others. If you completely disagree with anything, awesome! Use that to reaffirm what you already know. If you

agree, that's cool, too. Every one of us is entitled to our own perception. The ultimate testing grounds for discernment is when we speak to friends, family, or are influenced by social media. Perhaps you come across a post about having to "stop caring" to heal and move forward. The question you must ask yourself is:

"Is this right for me?"

"Does this serve me in MY healing?"

As long as you are concerned with other people's "way of doing things" or "what is right" (with nuance here), you will never be able to uncover your own authentic calling. Maybe heartbreak may look different for you. It's up to you to decide. Everyone is affected by everyone. We are constantly evolving and collaborating with others without knowing it. There is a constant flow of external influences, such as societal expectations, family opinions, and most importantly social media. During the healing journey, be aware that someone else will always affect you in one of two ways:

- 1. You disagree with them, reaffirming your own pre-existing beliefs.**
- 2. You agree with them, changing what you have believed or also reaffirming your beliefs.**

Without self awareness and introspection, this can affect us drastically during a heartbreak.

**Do you really feel that way about your ex?
Or did someone just tell you that's how you should feel?**

More often than not, healing is about learning to listen to one's highest self, rather than the mind (which is a collection of so much external stimuli). But sometimes the line between the two is ambiguous. The key here is balance, as external stimuli can also be helpful when you veer off path. This is where the courage to be wrong is needed. Stick with something you believe in, live it, understand it, and be with it. Should you be faced with its fallibility, gracefully accept that you were wrong, and move forward. This is the process of moving on, because you have to be willing to accept that maybe you were wrong about the role they were meant to play in your life. Alright, we need to be more discerning. But what does that even mean? How can we do that?

**“It’s less about doing, and more about being”
- Something my coach would always say to me**

How you are is more important than what you do. This doesn't mean to not do anything, but to embrace the way of doing things rather than just focusing on the action of it. If this sounds a little “woo woo” here are some ways to be more discerning (by doing things). But in the end it really is about **being** a more discerning person.

1. Build self awareness - Regularly journal, film yourself, explore your thoughts and emotions without judgment and just see them for what they are. What does it feel like? Is it physical? Are you making choices at the whim of these physical sensations? Seek feedback from a friend or mentor.

2. Follow your Value system - Spend time with yourself to identify your core values and what matters to you.

When you're faced with a new idea, ask yourself whether it aligns with your value system or not. Use your values as a guide to evaluate ideas or make decisions. Ask yourself whether your priorities align with your values.

3. Test your belief systems - Be willing to be wrong by actively seeking out different opinions and perspectives.

4. Reflect on how your perspectives differ from others, and try to understand why they think the way they do.

5. Embrace Uncertainty - Open yourself up to the idea that you don't know everything, you don't have it all figured out, and you probably are wrong about a lot of things. It's okay to not know what's coming. Allow yourself to embrace the unknown.

THE “WORLDS” INTERPRETATION AND WHY IT SUCKS SO MUCH BEING LEFT BEHIND.

When you fall deeply for someone, you and this person create a world together. You develop an understanding and an expectation. This might look like specific rituals, cute interactions, special things, and sometimes even a shared perception (of the world, things, people, etc). Your shared world is separate from the external reality that everyone else lives in. It's a world that only the two of you know of.

When someone breaks up with you, they essentially leave that world, so you're left behind in that world you've created together. **It feels lonely because you're in a world all by yourself. It's as if, you're the only person in the world.** I see it this way. There are 3 worlds; your world, their world, and the world the two of you create together. We switch between these all the time when we are in a relationship. Whether we take them to our own world, or visit their world, we switch between these worlds all the time. However, during a breakup, it seems like everything is just focused on the shared world with them.

When someone leaves you, they essentially go back into their own world, but have the ability to jump in and out of their world back into your shared world. They may be happy, meeting people and having fun, and then some random late night when they miss you, come back into your

shared world with a “I miss you text” at 3 am. Because you are stuck in your shared world, you will just accept this back and forth. However, part of healing is realizing that you cannot sustain this shared world by yourself. You have to return to your regular world and regular life, eventually.

Part of the reason why many people don't want to do this is because their own world is a place they really don't want to be. If you were unhappy before a relationship, it's quite likely you will be unhappy after as well. This is why many people go through dramatic transformations after a heartbreak, because they finally realize that their own world is something they need to take care of and nourish. These worlds that we have aren't actual “things”, but perceptions of ideas which we hold inside of our minds. The reason many people hold on for years after a breakup is because they are doing anything to keep the shared world alive. They are holding on because the thought of going back to their own world is too dark. Too scary.

But hope is not lost. As hard as it is, you have to be the one to close up shop. You have to be the one to end this story that is no longer a story, to say goodbye, and to let go. You will find it again, you can rebuild, and you can restart. **This is the first step.**

IF YOU ASK FOR SOMETHING, THE UNIVERSE ISN'T GOING TO GIVE IT TO YOU DIRECTLY

You will be tested. You have to go through immense hardship, pay a price to get to where you want to be, to become who you want to be. If you want something, you may have to grow into a different version of yourself to have that thing in the first place. Are you ready to let go of that part of yourself to move forward into the new version of yourself? I think this is the ironic part of life, love, and the universe. We expect things to somehow magically happen without shifting our beliefs to begin with. Someone who doesn't believe they are lovable will never be able to feel loved, no matter how much someone loves them. Someone who does not believe themselves to be wealthy will never have enough money. Yet we fret, and raise our fists to the universe as if we have been wronged in some way.

It takes a tremendous amount of courage and compassion to recognize this. That maybe you have been broken time and time again because you haven't had the courage to walk away when you should have. Maybe you chose someone you **knew** wasn't right for you. If you want to receive something from the universe, know that it will come indirectly. Maybe to experience love, you must first experience the most devastating heartbreak of all. Maybe to truly experience wealth, you must experience a financial

drought. It takes a level of hope and belief to catch yourself in hardships and say:

This is part of the process. This is here to teach me something. This is here to help me grow.

And it will suck. This isn't some argument as to why suffering, pain, and heartbreak will feel good. The bottom line is that it won't, but through that experience, you can find something, learn something, and you can transform. Maybe you have been mistreated time and time again, and you have given up so much love that you have nothing left to give. Perhaps this is a sign now to change, to become someone who is willing to give that love back to themselves, instead of depriving themselves of it to be loved by others. The story, the narrative you have, will define how you move forward. If you believe you are being punished by the universe, that will be your truth. If you believe the universe is giving you something— a lesson, a platform, a springboard, then that is how it will be. Remind yourself of this throughout your healing process: **It will not always seem straightforward, and that what you ask for, you may not receive directly.**

WHY NO CONTACT IS IMPORTANT: ALLOW SILENCE TO SPEAK THE WORDS THAT WERE NEVER SAID.

Silence can give room for nuance and space when another person cannot. More often than not, when you choose to stay in contact with an SP (significant person, maybe your ex or ex situationship etc.), you may end up saying words you end up regretting later. The occurrence of a breakup introduces a wave of emotions, or a “cocktail of hormones”, that doesn’t allow for rational thinking or proper compassionate discussion.

For this reason, it’s important for both parties to spend some time apart to process, feel, and reintegrate themselves before communicating again (should they choose). If you don’t spend time alone, you don’t know whether it’s your emotions speaking or just an emotional reaction/pattern. When you spend time in silence, you can process things in a safe manner and create space and nuance for ideas (obviously, this is hard, but it’s an integral part of healing).

If you want to get back together, no contact allows them to realize they truly want to be with you. If you want to heal, no contact allows the space to heal and let go. No contact will help, regardless of the outcome you seek. If you don’t spend time alone, you won’t really know if you want them to choose you, or if you are just hurt that they didn’t.

Maybe you wanting them to choose you is just a sign you haven't been choosing yourself. If you don't spend time alone, you don't truly know.

Oftentimes, we try to mend the connection just to relieve ourselves of the pain. If we choose to do so, we repeat the same trauma cycles. More often than not, staying in contact leads to more drama, jealousy, and anxieties surrounding the relationship. Most of the damage that is created between exes occurs during contact after the breakup. If you are in no contact, remind yourself that you made the right choice.

CHANGE YOUR RELATIONSHIP WITH DISCOMFORT

If you want to heal, change your life, and break out of patterns, you have to change your relationship with discomfort. Because as toxic as a cycle may be, it's comfortable, it's familiar, and it gives us a sense of control. It allows us to believe that we know what will happen.

"I'm not enough" -> "I can expect relationships to end because I'm not enough" -> I know what is going to happen, so I'm comfortable.

This is such a dangerous mindset to have because it's so subconscious and automatic. The way to break out of this cycle is to change your relationship with discomfort and to allow yourself to be scared of the unknown. It's telling yourself, "I'm scared, but I will do it anyway". Let go of your need for control. That's the only way you can break out of a cycle.

This might mean trying things you "would never do" or doing things that are "cringe" or "weird". If you want to break out of a cycle, you have to be willing to move past the patterns that keep you there. You have to be willing to bet on yourself when no one else will, to be able to see something that doesn't already exist, to imagine beyond what is.

Maybe your type isn't emotionally unavailable people, but rather that's your pattern. You can't recognize this till you make the conscious decision to change your relationship with discomfort. It might not get better before first getting worse. Finding peace and creating a healthy relationship with yourself after being used to the emotional highs and lows of a "toxic" relationship will feel extremely uncomfortable.

The reminder we have to give ourselves is that if we really want to change, it's gonna be hard. It might even feel impossible, but that's only a sign you're on the right path. What you're used to might not always feel good, but it does feel comfortable on some level. Whether it's a certain level of love, reciprocation, or treatment, there is something that is your default. Something you're used to. If you want something more or something better, change your relationship with discomfort.

I THINK PEOPLE OFTEN THINK THAT MOVING ON IS GIVING UP.

That somehow it's not romantic to get over someone, and I think it's this thought that causes people to hold on to something that no longer exists. But I see it differently. To me, moving on is the last thing you will ever do for them. It's your final act of love, before you accept that this isn't your story to live out after all.

It's letting them be the main character and live out their story, even if you're not one of the main characters. Because there's this funny thing that happens after heartbreak. You become okay again. You smile again. Things are exciting again, and you think to yourself:

“maybe they weren't meant to be, anyway”

And it's in these moments you realize that all the fuss, all the energy around trying to convince someone who isn't there anymore to stay, was just betraying yourself in a way. Letting go is the most courageous, most loving thing you could do for them and for yourself. **Love should always include yourself.** Because if you have one last opportunity to love them with everything you've got, wouldn't you want to take that opportunity? Let go, it's your final act of love before they cease to exist in your life. It's not that getting over

someone isn't romantic. I'd argue it's the most romantic thing of all. It's a love for someone so great that you'd be willing to choose yourself again, and that you'd be willing to let them win, even when it's not with you.

If you are stuck holding on because you believe on some level that you are being romantic, realize that freeing them from the burdens of your needs is the most romantic thing you could ever do. Not only are you choosing for them to be free (which takes all of your heart); you are also opening yourself up to the idea that you too, deserve love, just not with this person you have attached to. This is scary. This takes a tremendous amount of courage, and not to mention love. So press forth, take it one step at a time. Be gentle, don't rush, it's the last thing you get to do with them. Letting go is akin to passing a torch, passing the baton, and entrusting the love you once gave to them, to someone else.

WHAT IF MOVING ON WASN'T GIVING UP?

A Journal entry

What if moving on is, in fact, the greatest act of love you could ever perform? Because if you could endure the pain of loss, and STILL choose to love them, wish them happiness and truly be happy yourself too, is that not the greatness of love personified? What if, instead of being regretful, we could be grateful for the role we played in that story, even if that chapter is closed? What if, instead of blaming them for our ability to love, we are grateful for being able to love them, and to let go of them in the end? What if, instead, we could just enjoy those short moments we steal away as a reminder of the love that once was? What if, letting go is your final act of love for the other person? What if saying goodbye just means you get to say hello to love once again?

This journal entry was written to me. I was struggling with the fact that letting go just seemed like I was giving up. That I was throwing in the towel, and on some level, I was betraying the part of myself that said I would never give up. I realized, however, that it's all perspective. How you frame it is how it is. Be willing to reframe it and look at it differently.

MISSING ENDS ONE DAY

A Poem

I think one day I'm not gonna miss you anymore.
and you're not gonna miss me anymore
and I think that's super bittersweet.

So for now, I'll cherish every single moment I miss you.
you've been an amazing reminder of
how much I love myself and I'm so grateful for that :)

MISSING ENDS ONE DAY - A COMING REALIZATION

I think when I wrote “missing ends one day” I was coming to the realization that all things come to an end, even endings. Because as tough as heartbreak and saying goodbye is, that too ends eventually. Being grateful that you are spending your last moments cherishing the memories for what they are is hard, but when you realize it’s your last chance to, it seems like the only thing that you can do.

LETTING GO ISN'T GIVING UP

A Poem

Letting you go
meant realizing I'm not meant for you,
and setting you free.
You are everyone I love, everything love is to me,
and infinitely more.

I'm not giving up on you,
but I'm loving you more than the heartbreak.
Because, for me, letting go isn't giving up,
to me, letting go is choosing love for both of us.
And although we were wrong and weren't
all that we thought, I still love you,
and I always will.

Because truly, you existing will
always be enough for me.
Because, I love you more than my need to talk to you,
and more than my need to be with you.
The love is not contingent upon us being together in any way,
and one day I'll find a love that ours could never be.

Thank you for reminding me that love is never wasted.
I love this version of myself that you brought out.

LETTING GO ISN'T GIVING UP - REFRAMING LOSS

Letting go isn't giving up. That's the thing we struggle with. Because if letting go was giving up, why would we want to do it? Why should we? We are taught from a young age that love is something you should fight for, rally for, and move mountains for. So when things come to an end (and they definitely DO end sometimes) we resist and persist, because that's what we think love is all about. But sometimes loving isn't about making something work, but rather realizing it isn't meant to be. To me, letting go was setting her free and, in turn, myself as well. Loving someone more than what they are to you is hauntingly beautiful, because it means putting aside what you want them to be, and accepting who they are, even if it means letting go of them in the end. You can appreciate their existence for what it is, rather than what you need it to be. Letting go is a conscious act of love. A choice, and a decision to move forward even when it feels like you can't. It's everything we don't want love to be, but everything we need it to be. In the face of heartbreak, love them more than your pain, more than your need to be with them. This is how you move forward. Letting go isn't giving up. It's realizing you have to let go to move forward and to ensure that love is never wasted.

IF YOU'RE LOST, ADMIT TO YOURSELF THAT THERE IS A BETTER WAY, YOU JUST HAVEN'T FOUND IT YET.

When you want something and it seems like an absolute certainty that it's impossible, open yourself up to the idea that there is a better way, you just haven't found it yet. It's very possible that you just don't fully understand it yet. If you think getting over them is impossible, maybe you just haven't found out how to yet. Allow yourself to believe this. You will never find love again? Maybe you're wrong. Be willing to be wrong. It's a gift to be wrong.

This is one of the quintessential experiences of healing. It's a form of surrender that says some of your thought patterns may be wrong, that maybe some of your belief systems don't make sense to begin with. You might be wrong. Remind yourself of this. If all feels lost and moving forward seems impossible, just remind yourself that you may be wrong. Be willing to open your heart to the idea; **you may not see it all**. Assuming you know everything when you're experiencing loss is the worst thing you can do for yourself. We think that because we experience heartbreak a few times, we are destined to be alone. That a pattern is some divine sign from the universe that we are doomed, cursed, and inevitably set up to fail. However valid the feeling may be, this is untrue. But unless you're willing to accept an alternative, you will continue to live in this cycle. Some people choose this cycle willingly, and some are unaware they

are choosing it. The bottom line is that you have to recognize that we are blind when it comes to predicting what will happen next. Catastrophizing your doom is something you do, not something that defines how everything will be. If you are in this position, take a step back for a second. **Just pause. Slow down.** Because you are probably living in your head. The stories, the assumptions, and the beliefs are defining everything for you. You have to recognize you are doing this first, if you want to snap out of it. **Take a moment to just breathe for a second and focus on your breath. That's all you need to do.** Remind yourself that your mind is loud, but if you were your mind, you couldn't be the one listening to it. It's okay to feel as if things are doomed, and that you can never move forward. But choosing to embrace it as the only option is simply settling for something you know you don't want. **There is a better way; you just haven't found it yet.** Here are 5 ways to reframe your perspective.

1. Viewing challenges as adventures.

Whenever you are faced with a challenge, you have a choice to decide what it is to you. You can see obstacles as a roadblock or a stepping stone into something greater. What have you not considered about the challenge or obstacle in front of you? What can you learn from this? How can you grow through this experience?

2. Learning from the brink of impossibility

This is what makes us human. We don't accept defeat, and we are inspired when we give it a shot anyways. In every story we love, there's always a moment where the protagonist is faced with impossible odds — where they are provided the opportunity to throw in the towel and give up. But

something in them decides to reject this opportunity and move forward anyway. These are the moments we love in storytelling because it mirrors what we need most from ourselves. We understand that the comeback story isn't just something in fiction, but something innate in all of us. In the face of uncertainty, you are provided with the opportunity for discovery. Learn what it means to come back, and choose something better for yourself even when it seems impossible.

3. Challenge the story

The belief that you're destined to be alone is a narrative you have the power to rewrite. Humans have the power to dream, imagine, and hope. Challenge that what is happening to you isn't all that there is. You don't know what can change, but be willing to accept that it can.

4. Be willing to perform Emotional Alchemy

Acknowledge the feelings within you, and transmute them into something different. Feelings of despair, loneliness and sadness are forms of energy awaiting your transformation. They are not wrong; they are just like raw materials waiting to be shaped into something else. You can't change what happens, but you can change the way you feel about it. Be willing to accept that what you are feeling is something you have the power to transform.

5. A Pattern is a comfort zone

We crave predictability, so much that, at times, we choose it even when it's the worst option provided to us. We assume that our past dictates an unalterable future because it's more comfortable than accepting that how we move forward is unknown — and entirely up to us.

IF YOU CAN'T GET OVER THEM, THEN CREATE A VERSION OF YOURSELF THAT CAN.

As long as you think you can't, you're right. If you think they are the only person for you, then they are. You get to decide these things. If you've decided that you could never get over them, never let go, and never move on, then create a version of yourself that can. Heal and grow so much that you aren't the same person anymore. Put the version of yourself that could never get over them to rest. Let them know that **"I've got it from here on out, you can rest now, and I'm going to take care of you"**. You don't just have to grieve your SP during a heartbreak; you also have to grieve the parts of yourself that committed everything to them, the parts of yourself that believed they were everything, and the parts of yourself that fell for them in the first place (a lot of times we have resentment towards ourselves for falling in love with someone who eventually breaks our heart).

Creating a version of yourself who can get over them means forgiving all parts of yourself. Trusting, understanding, and seeing why you made certain choices. It's to tell yourself:

If I knew better, I would've done better.

It's forgiving your SP for who they once were, and who they are now. Trusting, understanding, and seeing why they acted

in certain ways. It's telling yourself:

If they knew better, they would've done better.

Let yourself grieve everything. Feel the pain. Allow yourself to be hurt, because you're saying goodbye to a part of yourself as well. You are choosing to heal beyond everything that has ever hurt you. You are choosing to be free from it. You are not punishing yourself; **you're forgiving yourself**. When you can do this, you can really move forward from a past that's already gone. These are 5 things I realized about creating a version of yourself that can.

1. Self growth is metamorphosis

As you grow from them and grow into someone different from who you are, you have to shed the parts of yourself that previously existed. Embracing this change (that you have to let go of parts of yourself) is the hard part of healing and moving on.

2. Reinvention is empowerment

Shedding an old belief system allows for the emergence of a more empowered and self assured you. If you are feeling powerless and hopeless to the whims of everything in front of you, resist giving in; instead, reinvent yourself and reclaim your essence.

3. Acceptance builds resilience

I think we all like to believe that resilience is our ability to tolerate hurtful things, or our ability to not care and be unaffected in the face of challenging things. However, resilience isn't about indifference; rather, it lies in our

capacity to accept things that are seemingly unacceptable. Accepting your past, your choices, and the actions of your SP isn't a resignation, but rather the foundation for your resilience and growth.

4. Grief is nuanced

It isn't just something we go through once; it's an experience that persists throughout our entire lives. It's not something you experience once and move on from once, but a continuous experience. Living with grief means understanding that it is nuanced and it comes in waves. Allowing yourself to experience this is the only way you can live with it.

5. Feeling broken is an opportunity for Self Compassion

Creating a version of yourself that can move on and can get over them is self compassion. It's being kind to yourself even if you feel like you don't deserve it and choosing to take your lowest moment and turn it into an opportunity to love yourself again.

Why?

A Poem

When I told you I always recover,
that wasn't an invitation to break me.

When I shared my deepest fears
and my greatest vulnerabilities,
it wasn't a challenge.

WHY? - BEING HURT IS A REFLECTION OF HOW WILLING YOU WERE TO LOVE

I wrote “why” during my heartbreak because that’s how I felt at the time. It felt as if sharing myself on that deep of a level was as if I was giving them the opportunity to break me in the end. That providing them with my greatest fears was handing them the gun to shoot me with. I think feeling this way is pretty normal during a heartbreak, but I’ve come to reframe it as time has passed. Part of the reason we feel this way is that we had enough safety to get hurt in the first place. Although it seems like we are providing the other person with the means to break us, that is not actually our intention or theirs either. Loving someone is putting it all on the line in hopes that it may work out, knowing that it may not. This isn’t wrong or something we have to fix. I’d argue it’s the only way you truly make love work.

However, if you experience this one too many times, it may feel as if opening yourself up and being vulnerable is not worth it to begin with. I think this is the irony of love because it’s not actually about the other person. Ultimately, our emotional resilience lies in our ability to remain open, regardless of what external circumstances have to say about it. Being hurt isn’t some sign that loving was the wrong choice. It’s an indication of how much you cared and how willing you were to love in the first place. To me, loving is the greatest

gamble of all. It's putting your heart on the line, hoping that the other person will do the same. After a few heartbreaks, many people decide this gamble is not worth the hassle. That caring isn't something you should do if you want to get ahead in life. But choosing not to take this gamble is the greatest gamble of all. Because it's a choice to be complacent with the status quo, with how things are, and to be unwilling to change moving forward. Be willing to be open, not for the other person, but for the experience. **Love is the price we pay for experience, not outcome.** The point of loving isn't necessarily to reach some intended outcome or for it to be successful, but rather to experience what it has to offer, even if it ends one day. **Keep your heart open and never close.** Because the pain of experiencing loss is nothing compared to the pain of not experiencing love.

YOU ONCE SAID TO ME THAT HEARTBREAK DOESN'T JUST HAPPEN ALL AT ONCE.

An unsent journal entry

You once said to me that heartbreak doesn't just happen all at once, that it happens when you relive the memories, when someone mentions their name, when you get a faint smell that reminds you of them, or when you want to send them something that would make them laugh. That heartbreak is something you go through again and again until you can view and relive the memories as bittersweet rather than repress them. That it's never about forgetting them, but creating a life in their absence. It's about finding happiness again, even with the weight of what was lost. And it's about accepting that someone permanently shifted the course of your life and heart forever, but still choosing to continue. It's remembering what you were once a part of with fondness, but coming to the rational conclusion that you could never go back, and that you wouldn't, even if you could. Because that's the thing about heartbreak, right? It's not that the loss is hurtful, but it's that each time we remember, we're given one final opportunity to love. To smile when you relive the memories, to exhale with peace at the mention of their name, or chuckle in surprise when a scent reminds you of them, to laugh at those things that you know they would enjoy. Because that's what letting go is. It's your final opportunity to love. It's the final greatest act of love you could ever perform, and the last act of love you will ever do for them.

This journal entry was me reflecting on the conversations we had before. One of the highlights of our connection was how we discussed deep topics like love and heartbreak. She would always say that heartbreak is something that happens again and again, but only by accepting it — you could move forward. This was one of my favourite lessons from her. The idea is that we are constantly provided with opportunities to love (and let go) during heartbreak, but many of us just ignore these opportunities. It really is the last thing we get to do with them, because once we let go of something, it's gone. I think her teaching me this lesson was invaluable. It's one of the reasons why I even wrote this book to begin with. To me, taking the final opportunity (to love) was the only option I had. **All of me wanted to hold on, yet none of me knew that I could.** When you run into those small moments that remind you of them, that make you smile or maybe even sting a little, rejoice. It's just your heart remembering how great that love once was. **Allow yourself to cherish these moments, because one day, they will be gone too.** Accepting this “transience” was the crucial lesson I had to learn during my time with her. Ironically, when it felt like I couldn't move forward, it was the lessons with her that really reminded me that I could. That despite the weight of everything, and the undeniable truth that my heart had been changed, I could find a way to move forward.

THERE IS NO SUCH THING AS “YOU TOOK ME FOR GRANTED” ONLY “WE TOOK EACH OTHER FOR GRANTED” BECAUSE IT’S A TEAM EFFORT.

When you fall short in a relay, blaming your partner doesn’t really feel good. In fact, you only create more space between the two of you, hindering your progress. If you treat your relationships in this way (and, in turn, your breakups), you will always feel like you are either not good enough for your partner or that your partner is not good enough for you.

Blaming another person for their fault doesn’t actually make us feel better. It only isolates us more. When you recognize that, perhaps as a team, you fell short, you just no longer want to be their teammate anymore (it’s not personal).

This is how you move on. Because you realize you aren’t with “your” partner, anyway. If you want to be able to win as a team, you have to be able to lose as a team as well. It’s not unheard of for people to seek partners who love them more or put them on a pedestal after heartbreak, and while there is nothing inherently “wrong” with this, the question to ask is whether that is something you seek to create or not. Do you want a partner you will never love but only be loved by? If this is for you, that’s valid.

Many will heavily disagree with me, saying that their SP took them for granted — and that they deserve better. There is no wrong here, and that perspective is valid as well.

What if my partner was abusive? What if they ... **There is nuance here.**

The reason why I say “we took each other for granted” (even if it was just 1 person) is because my perspective functions from a teamwork paradigm. To me, their actions are irrelevant because we functioned as a team, their mistakes are mine too.

In a world where individualism, you vs. me, and the zero-sum mentality are often center stage, shifting the focus to “we” instead of “me” feels liberating and revolutionary. Shifting from the winning and losing mindset is humbling. **Because if you’re the one winning in a relationship, your relationship is the one that’s doing the losing.** It’s important that you realize that some relationships are supposed to “lose” so that you can end up in the right one.

To me, love, relationships, and heartbreak are not solo endeavors. In the context of a relationship, when a challenge arises, it’s less a matter of one person taking the other for granted, but rather, it’s an opportunity for **everyone*** involved to come together and communicate as a unit. A heartbreak is the very same. It’s an opportunity to say goodbye with grace, communicate (with yourself), and move apart (together). The outcome of a relationship (to me) is a **collective responsibility**. If I’m going to celebrate the highs with you, I will weather our lows together too. Growth is a shared journey (for all of us), regardless of whether we do it together or do it apart. Everyone is trying to be happier.

To me this form of collaboration and teamwork is what it means to love as a human being. It is beyond a “relationship” or a “heartbreak”, but the very essence of our nature.

YOUR EX PROBABLY ISN'T AS BAD OF A PERSON AS YOU THINK THEY ARE, AND YOU AREN'T EITHER.

**This is a blanket statement and may not apply to everyone.
As a reader, please use your own discernment/nuance to decide
whether this applies to you :)*

Breakups tend to highlight the worst parts of people (and if you're honest with yourself, it brings out the worst in yourself as well). Yet, we often judge people for this fraction of time. In psychology, the self-serving bias is when we:

Attribute positive events and successes to our own character, but blame negative results on external factors unrelated to our character. This bias is flipped around when applying it to others.

**If someone acts crazy because of X reason, they are just
crazy.**

**If we act crazy because of X reason, it's because of X
reason.**

This is a very simplified model, but the reason to point it out is that we only have OUR own perspective. We perceive all of our reality through our own very biased lens, and we can't really be sure that's all there is to the story. It's important to

remind yourself of this fact because you don't actually know the full extent of your SP's traumas. If they're acting out in a hurtful way, it's merely a reflection of the pain that they themselves have experienced, not your value as a person.

Another person's hurtful actions are a testament to the degree to which they have healed and less to do with you.

Context breeds compassion. Remind yourself that they are probably only acting this way because of the way they have been hurt in the past. Most people only act the way they do in breakups because the relationship made them **feel safe enough to be vulnerable** in the first place. Maybe they aren't that bad of a person (this does not justify any hurtful or abusive actions, but just puts them into context). By putting their actions into context, it allows you to let it go more easily.

This is their first time living as well. They are figuring it out too. Understanding that they are probably just figuring it out, trying to be human, and trying to avoid as much pain as possible allows you to stop taking any hurtful words or actions personally.

If a child throws a tantrum, it has nothing to do with the parent (most of the time) and more to do with the child. Take a child who tells their mom that they hate them for not buying them ice cream. The parent should be able to recognize that they are just hurt (not getting ice cream) and throwing a tantrum.

When you realize this is (almost) all the pain in the world, you can recognize it's never personal, and has more to do with the other person than it has to do with yourself. This is how you liberate yourself.

The nuance here is that contextualizing someone's hurtful actions is not saying it's okay. You're not justifying them, or taking responsibility for them, but rather choosing to be above it. Once you can contextualize their actions from a neutral place, you will recognize you don't want to be associated with those actions to begin with.

THERE ARE TWO WAYS YOU CAN ENDURE A LOT OF PAIN:

- 1. You believe on some deep level you deserve it.**
- 2. You are fighting for something greater than yourself and are committed to something beyond yourself.**

If 1 resonates with you, perhaps it's time to heal and tend to your wounds. Maybe your strength is also a trauma response. Not to take away from all that you've endured, because most people would have given up if they went through what you did. But perhaps it's time to put the sword down and start healing. Learn the difference between fighting for yourself and fighting yourself. Part of the reason why a lot of people are stuck in a cycle of pain is because they find themselves trapped in some form of self punishment. Whether it's choosing people they know are unavailable or going for things they know in their heart aren't right, there is a part of themselves that thinks they deserve the situation they find themselves in.

You cannot escape pain, but you shouldn't be in prolonged suffering, either. You need to take an honest audit

of yourself and your belief systems. What do you think about the idea of “enduring a lot of pain”? Maybe you may believe it’s noble, or a confirmation of your personal strength. There is some belief that is hiding your need for it. If you keep getting hurt, you need to ask yourself (honestly) what you’re really getting out of it. Enduring pain for no reason other than to prove you can isn’t noble or strong; it’s **egotistical and pointless**. Sometimes healing means letting go of the pride you have around the pain you carry.

HOW TO GET CLOSURE: WHY DO WE HOLD ON?

A lot of people say “If I could just get an answer from them about..” or “If I could just tell them that..” Essentially, putting the energy of closure on their ex (SP). We do this is because when a connection ends, we’ll find any reason to stay connected to them, even if that connection is pain. **By putting the energy of closure on the other person, it gives us permission to hold on.**

There is nothing wrong with this, as we all do it, but it’s important to recognize that we are doing it in order to move on, eventually. The hard but liberating truth is that closure is found within, not externally. There will always be words left unsaid, thoughts unexpressed or misunderstood. Part of healing is allowing silence to speak the words that need to be said.

If you’re being honest, you could keep talking to your SP forever and will never find closure if you choose not to (this is how patterns begin). Because if you’re in a relationship with someone you love, you don’t just “finish” talking to them. The same is true with a SP. You will not be “finished” in talking to them, unless you decide it is a decision you choose to move forward with. On some level, we hope that if we get the “right” explanation or proper

apology, our pain will miraculously dissipate when we know that (oftentimes) isn't true. The peace we find is in our acceptance that we can't control another person's actions or emotions, but we can control our reactions to them (maybe not instantaneously. There is nuance here).

So how do we actually find closure within ourselves?

Finding closure is about completing an emotional process within ourselves. To some extent, the person that we loved gave us permission for something. They provided us with an opportunity to receive and give love to a part of ourselves we may have otherwise neglected in the past. Love those parts of yourself that you labeled as "unlovable".

On some level, they were giving you something that you weren't giving yourself.

Spend time with your shame, your guilt, your pain, and accept those parts of yourself you hid away to "be more lovable" or "to be enough". You have always been enough, and you have always been lovable. You just forgot somewhere along the way. Let go of your expectations of who you "should be" and just be who you are. Meet all parts of yourself and reclaim them. Declare that you are reclaiming those parts of yourself and own it.

We all want "unconditional love" But how many of us actually give that to ourselves?

If you discard parts of yourself, you will always seek those missing parts of yourself in others. When you were the one

who discarded those parts to begin with. It's not that they completed you; they just helped you rediscover parts of yourself you had previously discarded.

This isn't meant to shift any blame or point any fingers, but to recognize that it is in our own personal power to love ourselves again. What did they give you permission to feel? **This is what you need most from yourself.**

It's important to note that this isn't the only reason we hold on. Sometimes it's out of fear; we hold on because of the unknown. The more peace you create within yourself by accepting that you cannot control them, the more you allow space for them to be, and in turn, yourself as well. Finding closure means coming to terms with this fear. A fear that we can't actually control anyone, own anyone, or fully know anyone (again, there is a lot of nuance here).

This "unknown" is the driving force behind many fears, and in the context of love and heartbreak, it's an obstacle we need to face to become who we are meant to be on our most authentic level. It's not about forgetting what was done to us, what happened, but about making peace with it so that we can move forward.

The terrifying thing is that heartbreak can happen again. Betrayal can happen again. We have to overcome this fear if we want to move forward.

It's funny.

A Poem

It's funny because, you taught me how to love myself
so well, that even
when you couldn't accept me,
I couldn't stop loving myself.

IT'S FUNNY - WHAT LOVE IS ABOUT SOMETIMES

I made this piece to highlight the irony of love sometimes. That sometimes you may just love another person so that you can learn to love yourself. Someone may teach you how to love, even if they aren't the one to give it to you in the end. The lesson sometimes is not about how it turns out or whether you end up together, but whether you can choose to accept the lessons, regardless. Even if they don't accept you or love you back, the question is whether you can continue to love yourself or not.

To me, that was the important lesson. From that experience, I could love something from it, and eventually move from it too. It was never about the other person. In the end, as it almost always is, it was an opportunity to accept myself on a deeper level. Sometimes we need to love another person so that we can really learn to love ourselves. If you are struggling because your "love" has ended with another person, maybe it's not about them. Maybe the story ends with you loving yourself — rather than them loving you back.

REMINDERS WHEN GOING THROUGH A BREAKUP

1. Healing isn't linear. You might be over them one second, and then missing them the next.
2. "Healing is really just letting yourself feel." -**Brianna Wiest**
3. Letting go isn't giving up. It's choosing love and realizing that love includes yourself.
4. You're allowed to miss them. But just because you miss them doesn't mean they are good for you. Smokers miss cigarettes when they try to quit.
5. It's not about hating them, or taking revenge, but finally choosing yourself.
6. Keep your heart open and never close it. Because the risk of getting hurt is nothing compared to the pain of not experiencing love.

REMEMBER WHEN YOU TOLD ME, RELATIONSHIPS ARE LIKE A BATON RELAY RACE? THIS IS HOW I TOOK IT:

So something you taught me was the way you described relationships as being like a baton relay race. You run your leg, giving everything you've got, expecting your teammate to do the same. It's never you vs. them, but rather the both of you versus everyone else. I love this metaphor you set up because it helped me realize that if I loved someone, why would I ever fight them to begin with? If we are both seeking the same outcome, how could it ever make sense that we would be against each other? It was a great reminder that we are on the same team. I took this lesson to heart, and will always remember that everyone wants to win together. We all want the same thing.

It's quite common that people talk about winning or losing in breakups, and this "competition" oftentimes dictates how we will feel about the breakup for years to come (some people never escape this framework). It's as if love is this competition where one person will emerge victorious while the other loses. This framework (to me) is a sign that we have closed ourselves off from the idea that love is all around us. That love is limited to the certain people who win. When this isn't the case at all.

This, to me, is such a grounding realization:

We all want to be happy, and we all want to find love.
(with nuance, remember that love looks different for
everyone)

We have always been on the same team. All of us. We all want liberation, and we all want happiness. If you look at a close friend's relationship, you would want their relationship to succeed, right? Would you want their love to fail? When you realize that **EVERYONE** is trying to find their own happy ending (including yourself) you can easily recognize that there are **A LOT** of people who are **not** your happy ending as well. It's only when you attach that ending to a specific person that you begin to fight against what is.

The poem "**Pass the Baton**" is meant to make people think about "loss" and "competition" in the context of a heartbreak, and convey this idea that just because someone doesn't work out with us doesn't really mean they "lost" or we "lost", it's just a different story.

Pass the Baton

A Poem

Just because we didn't work out
doesn't mean it's your loss
or my loss either.

Our chapter is over
and I want you to win
as bad as I want to win too.

I'm not gonna try and make
you regret it
or make you jealous
because there's enough room
for all of us to win.

I'm not gonna find someone
better than you, but I'll find
someone better for me.

Just as you have.

We were on the same team
then and we're on the same
team now.

Just headed for *different directions*.

PASS THE BATON - WHAT IT MEANS TO LET GO

The act of letting go is not just about the other person. It's about yourself as well. Perhaps one of the most misinterpreted lines of this poem is "I'm not gonna find someone better than you, but I'll find someone better for me" to which the response is often

"Of course I will find someone better than them"

Or

"I could never find someone better than them"

The intention of the stanza is to let go of even trying to "beat them" because you are no longer competing for their love. You need to prove nothing, as they are not right for you in the first place.

When you realize someone for all that they are, it is liberating. It's a love that needs nothing in return, but it's also a love that isn't right for you. This is what it means to open your heart. When you choose to let go of your need to beat them, this is when you can truly "win". Some might argue that they could find a hotter, better, or more successful partner, yet they're still tied to the energy of "beating their ex" or "winning the breakup". Some people are run by this energy years after heartbreak and still continue to tie their

energy to their SP even when they're in a new relationship (ironically, this is actually why some people don't move on from their SP's).

Learning to let go means realizing that should you want to win, you have to be willing to make space for others to win as well. Wishing the best for someone else is wishing the best for yourself. Especially when you love someone; it's the most caring thing you could do. If you choose to hate someone (long-term - I get there's nuance here and hating them for a period is actually healthy sometimes) **you essentially tell your heart it doesn't deserve to be open.** That somehow it was stupid for even choosing to love. That it should never open again. This is how you become jaded. Love doesn't become hate; we just close our hearts off from feeling anything, and then think we have transmuted our love into hate.

The reality is different. When your "love" turns to hate, it is actually your attachment turning into hate. Not your love. Think about it for a second. If love is detachment itself, how could it ever be attached? (Hate is a form of attachment.)

Moments before a heartbreak, and moments after a heartbreak, nothing is really different. The world still runs exactly the same, and your life is exactly the same. The difference is a label/switch in your mind that has changed. A person to whom you have attached expectations, imagined futures, and labels to now doesn't conform to the idea you hold in your mind.

"They are not MY partner anymore"

"They don't love ME anymore"

"I was never enough for them in the first place"

Recognize that your love for them is still the same. It's unaffected, and it's just there. Over time, however, your attachment tells you that you must close yourself off. Your attachment is your pain, not your love, yet you choose to close off your love rather than let go of your attachment. This only hurts you and prevents you from feeling love.

The best way to illustrate this idea is with death. For the people who have experienced death, they often love continuously throughout their lives, while diminishing their attachment over time. If someone you loved died, would you think:

"They aren't my parent/sibling/friend/lover anymore"

"They don't love me anymore"

"I was never enough for them, so that's why they died"

It sounds almost ridiculous when you frame it that way, but this is the same paradigm from which we function during heartbreak. A version/idea of who you thought they were is starting to die. But the difference between heartbreak and death is at least with heartbreak, a part of them still exists, and you can be glad that they do. Appreciate that you still love them, and that if you are being honest with yourself, some part of you always will. That's actually really beautiful. Once you let go of all the attachment to them, only love for them will remain. Letting go means loving them, and eventually, letting them fall in love with someone else.

***It's an important distinction that you may always love them, but not be IN love with them.**

LET THEM LOSE YOU - NO ONE DESERVES THE BURDEN OF YOUR IDEAL

If you stop for a second and ask yourself what has caused you heartache in your life, you may come to realize the burden of expectation is a large pain point. In the pursuit of approval from our parents, our partners, and even the world, we often find ourselves caught up in our own desire to prove our worth. Ironically, this is how we often treat others (especially during heartbreak), inadvertently reinforcing our own insecurities.

Whether you're chasing after approval from your parents, achieving to show those who doubted you, a part of yourself is burdened by the ideals of others. The actions we take and the way we treat others directly affect our world and how we perceive ourselves (and vice versa).

When you're going through a breakup, there is always a version of your significant person (SP) that you want them to be. Whether it's a version of them that chooses to change, grow, or a version that chooses you back, it's a hypothetical ideal that isn't truly who they are.

**Let go of them and love them for who they are, not who
you want them to be.**

If who they are is someone who doesn't love you back, set them free.

If they are someone who is going to lose you? Let them.

You don't need them to be who you need them to be. You just need to accept them for who they are. The faster you realize this, the faster you realize that you are everything that you need to be as well. When you expect someone to be some "ideal" and not who they authentically are, you also, in turn, expect this of yourself (this is really exhausting).

You are hurt not because you love them, but because your heart is closing off. The heart's nature is to be open. It is accepting of what is, and is open to possibility. When someone doesn't feel the same about us, or the external does not align with our internal, it hurts because of our attachment to our expectations of what we need it to be.

Choosing to open your heart means loving something for what it is, or more precisely, loving someone for all that they are. The reason it hurts is that your mind wants to change them. That is; the ideal you have of them, not who they are themselves. Because when you open yourself up to loving just who they are, you will realize you no longer need them to be anyone else. With the very same energy, you can also recognize that you are lovable, just as you are.

You don't need to be anyone else, either.

Your heart cannot close off to certain emotions; it cannot pick and choose what it wants to feel. This is an illusion in your mind. You either love it all, or you love none of it at all (this includes yourself). When you choose love from your

heart, you choose love for all. “Being better than someone” or having someone “not deserve” you is not actually liberating, it only feeds the ego. Because if you rationalize it hard enough, no other being on this planet deserves you. All that you have experienced and all that you have endured — how could they? They haven’t experienced life as you have. They don’t understand your pain like you do, and they don’t get what you had to go through to still be standing. As long as you have this idea of “deserving”, you will find yourself being more and more lonely. Everyone deserves to be happy. If someone “doesn’t deserve you”, what it REALLY means, is that they deserve someone else;

someone who is better suited for them.

Realizing that someone is the way they are and that they may just not be for you, is truly liberating. Because from this place, you can understand you, too, are not meant for them. It becomes easy then to walk away, heal, because you realize: why would you want to convince someone who is not meant for you to love you to begin with?

If you find yourself trapped in the loop of trying to “make them” into what you want, think for a second about how it feels when other people do that to you.

How would it land if someone said you had to do X to be enough?

Or that you had to be X way to be lovable?

When you choose to judge someone, you choose to judge yourself as well. There’s a great quote by Wayne Dyer that

goes:

When you judge another, you do not define them; you define yourself.

When you choose to judge your SP for being a certain way, you are also opening yourself up to being judged. By picking on their flaws, you subconsciously tell yourself that there is a standard for someone to be lovable, and that you operate under that standard as well. But by accepting that some people are meant to come into our lives to find something (that perhaps isn't us) and we are meant to do the same, we eliminate this burden.

It's no longer us vs. them, it becomes all of us working together to finish our own individual stories. If someone is a certain way that causes them to lose you? Let them. Love them for it even. If someone is being hurtful in the end? Allow them the space to be. Ultimately, they are only hurting themselves.

There is nothing about them you need to change, only to accept them as is. End the cycle of burden and allow them to be everything that they are, even if that "thing" is not "yours" but "someone else's" (figuratively, no one actually owns anyone).

This is how we (all) free ourselves.

Trust

A Poem

Trust you? I always have.
Not just then, but right now too.

That you see things I don't,
that you know things I don't.
I trust you didn't pick me back,
not for some lack,

but that it's just not meant to be.

I know you didn't hurt me on purpose,
and I trust that too.

Our paths no longer intertwine,
simply not meant to be, paths misaligned.

TRUST - AN ACCEPTANCE THAT THEIR CHOICE IS CORRECT.

This poem was written as an act of rebellion against my mind at the time. I had felt as if the only reason things hadn't worked out was because I wasn't enough. I felt as if I couldn't trust their decision. That on some level, they were wrong. But upon reflecting, I realized that trusting a person meant trusting their decision as well. This means not trying to get them to go back on their word and to respect that they have chosen what they have chosen. I was willingly accepting that she didn't choose me back, not as a comment on my character, but rather just a misalignment of paths. When someone we love willingly chooses not to choose us back, it's not some universal decree that we aren't worth loving (even if it feels that way), but rather just a misalignment of fates. Something we want is misaligned with something that is.

Trust is something woven into all relationships, even one that has shifted in its course. You don't just trust a person once, but continue to do so as time persists. This acceptance implies that a relationship not going your way isn't a comment on your inadequacy, but rather due to the complex workings of fate or circumstance. Moving forward is about trusting their decision that they probably understand something you are going to understand as well one day.

Because one day when you move on, you're gonna understand why they chose what they chose. Sometimes the people we love hurt us without trying to, and if we are being honest, we tend to do the same. This acceptance is our forgiveness and a trust that goes beyond the tangible actions of a relationship. It's accepting that the relationship you had is no longer meant to be.

LESSONS IN LOVE - THE THREE HEARTBREAKS THAT TAUGHT ME THE MOST

Part 1. To love and lose and still be kind.

-Warsan Shire

A story of the kindest human I've ever met:

Years ago, I met someone who was unconditionally kind. She wasn't kind because she wanted something in return, and she wasn't loving because she needed anything. She just was. At the time, I couldn't understand how anyone could love so hard, try so hard, get hurt, and still remain so loving.

But I learned something from that experience. No one can ever take away your kindness or your love. Only you have the power to take this away from yourself (this is actually what hurts during heartbreak).

She taught me something different. That kindness isn't weak, but really only what the strongest people are capable of. You can never love someone into loving you back. You can only love with everything you've got, and if it doesn't work out, have the courage to walk away (she did).

I guess she taught me that love is something that's never outside of ourselves. She was loving, and I could never take that away from her. If I'm being completely honest,

back then I resented her for that because I didn't have the space to recognize what an amazing human being she is (I was too unhealed). I think (this is my interpretation, not her own thoughts) that she realized as loving as she was, and as amazing of a person as she was, there was no convincing to be done. I was unconvincible, and she knew there was nothing she could "do" to get me to love her. Looking back with open honesty, I think this was true. My own wounds were too great, and I didn't even think I was worthy of love, so how could I ever accept it? So if you have just left someone because you realized you could no longer try to convince them to love you;

You did the right thing, and you did the most loving thing you could do. No one can be "forced" to love you back. This doesn't mean you're unlovable or not enough, but maybe it just means you're not meant to be with them.

It's funny because now (years later), I recognize how loving she actually was, and how hard it was for her to walk away, yet still what she chose. I may not be "in love" with her, but I will always love her for that.

When you're stuck loving someone, the best thing you can do is to just let them be and not try to make them love you back. The best thing you can do is just love them with everything you've got. The pain isn't the love itself, but the resistance to what the outcome is. **Love is not something we receive outside of ourselves, and she was the paragon of this idea.** Because eventually she realized that because I didn't love her back, the most loving act she could do was to let go and walk away. Her making that choice was the reason why she could find her happy ending.

She obviously moved on, met her husband, and even had a daughter. The reason I wrote about this is as a reminder that being loving and giving it your all doesn't make you wrong, but maybe you're just giving it to the wrong person. No one can take your love away from you.

As hurtful as I was as a person, there was nothing I could say or do to take that spark away from her. To this day, it's still a humbling reminder for me. She really is the best of us, and that there is no such thing as caring too much (when that care also includes yourself). What I realize now (that I couldn't realize back then), is how badly I needed that love. She really taught me that "the ones who are hardest to love, sometimes need it the most". With her, it wasn't about being kind to someone who "deserved it"; she was just kind.

If you can relate to her, genuinely and authentically, the world thanks you. We need more people like you in the world. However, your kindness should never take away from yourself.

To those who try to make the world better at their own expense:

You are part of the world, too. By adding misery to yourself, you add misery to this world as well. No amount of happiness should be traded for pain.

Lessons in love: to the one I hurt

A Poem

You taught me that loving someone
doesn't mean that you have to be with them.
You taught me that even with all of my flaws,
and how fucked up I was back then,
I was still lovable.

You're one of the kindest, purest souls
I've ever met in this world.
Thank you for showing me that kindness is a strength.
You are the best of us.

You taught me how to show compassion to those who hurt us
and realize that the ones who are hardest to love,
sometimes need it the most.

You taught me that there's no such thing as caring too much
because I've never met anyone who cares more than you do.

You taught me how strong the human heart truly is,
and how much it hurts to hurt someone you love.
But even through all that, how love can truly survive.

You taught me that love is never wasted
and that when someone shatters our heart,
even when we are broken into a billion pieces,
we can understand, because that's the power of love.

Now more than ever,
I understand that you walking away
was the greatest act of love you could ever perform.

Thank you for being my first love.

Love is often explored from the perspective of the heartbroken, but not the heartbreaker, and I think understanding the other perspective actually allows us to move on and reintegrate our ideas of love. The idea of this poem is to recognize (from the perspective of the heartbreaker) what it means to be human. Years later, I've learned that you can never love someone into loving you back, no matter how much you love them. And that's not a comment on your love, but rather their ability to love. For me, I was too injured — too wounded, to have ever loved this person back. It didn't really matter if they changed the entire world for me, because it was a problem I had with myself.

This was a humbling experience for me. Because it was my first love, I had no idea what it meant to be on the receiving end of a heartbreak (as I was the one causing the heartbreak). This meant I was quite insensitive, and unaware of the complexity of the situation.

As a result, once it was my turn to be on the receiving end of heartbreak, I began to question how I could ever treat someone in such a way.

Part 2. To be on the receiving end of heartbreak. A story of the person who equalized heartbreak for me:

Writing about this person has less to do with them but rather, the impact they had on me. This was a person whom I put on a pedestal and believed, on some level, I didn't deserve. It's only when they broke my heart that I could contextualize so much of what heartbreak was (the other side of it).

This was the type of heartbreak that was world shattering, appetite destroying, sleep depriving and stomach turning.

Here's what I learned from it.

At this point in my journey, I had only broken someone else's heart (not that I wasn't hurt too, but that's just how it was framed), so this was my first experience "being on the receiving end" of heartbreak. I'd love to tell you I handled it with the utmost grace and acceptance, but I did not. I spiraled, victimized, and trapped myself in suffering for many years after. I saw her as the villain of my life and constantly felt cheated, slighted, and that she had taken everything from me. To me, she stole everything about me that I loved.

But amidst this pain and anger, I found something that I didn't even know I was missing. I would constantly tell myself "how bad of a person she was" and how "evil" she was, and it really helped me frame myself in the context of my first heartbreak. I was constantly jealous that she loved someone else and that her hurting me was some universal statement on her morality.

I was wrong.

Years later, I realized how I felt about her, was really how I felt about myself. I had framed heartbreakers as the villain, because to me, that's who I was in my first love story. I realized that it was in fact, my traumas that had projected onto her, not who she was objectively. I finally came to terms with the fact that her happy ending wasn't my sad ending, it was just a different ending.

In a sense, I believed that I was deserving of the heartbreak (because I had broken someone else's heart before). What I realized was that the cycle would never end if

I didn't choose to stop it.

The important lesson being: Pain, like any other entity or energy in this world, just wants space to exist, to be. When we close ourselves off to it, we essentially tell pain that it isn't allowed to be. Like any other entity that wants to stay alive, it will fight. This fight is often what causes us suffering, not the actual pain itself.

It was only when I welcomed this pain, treated it with space, love, and compassion that I could contextualize it, love it for what it was, and transmute it into something different.

Perhaps you haven't thought of it this way (I definitely didn't), but **pain wants to be loved as well**. It wants to be accepted, to be nurtured, and to change. It is only our labeling of it, our judgment of it, that causes it to act out. The nuance here is that loving your pain isn't holding onto it (remember, love is unattachment itself); it is allowing it to be, not judging it, and accepting it for how it is.

It's only when I recognized this, and was finally accepting how broken I actually was, that I could break free from my own trauma. The moment I accepted that she wasn't a bad person but simply another human, was the moment I realized I was one too.

I didn't need her to find closure. I just had to realize how I was speaking to myself, and what I was resisting within myself. In the end, it really was about me.

Lessons in love: to the one that hurt me

A Poem

You taught me how it feels
to be on the receiving end of heartbreak
and truly understand the weight of my actions.

You taught me that sometimes villains aren't really villains,
and that just because someone hurts us;
it doesn't make them a bad person.

You taught me that all the anger we hold on to
isn't worth it, and that holding onto it
does more harm than good.

You taught me forgiveness is choosing myself,
and that I could just let it go.

You taught me that your happy ending isn't my sad ending.
You taught me that as humans sometimes we can hurt others,
with or without mal-intentions, and that doesn't make us bad
people but rather, just means we're in pain.

You taught me to let go of my pain, let go of my anger,
let go of my failure, and to accept that:
Some people are just not meant for each other.

you taught me that the ego when truly hurt
can really vilify someone, when perhaps they're just human.

You taught me that pain can end with you,
and that we have the power to end pain where we receive it.
And in the most liberating way, end the cycle of pain in this world.

Part 3.

A story of the human who was the embodiment of reciprocity. (The most expensive lesson my heart has ever had to pay for)

Funnily enough, this isn't actually a love story. It's a story about friendship. But as ironic as it is, I learned more about love through this friendship than any of my other "romantic" connections.

The reason I call her the embodiment of reciprocity is because if you could describe her, that's how she was. She would always be open, excited, and interested in matching your energy. She was ready to rally, and face the world with you, regardless of the circumstances you found yourselves in. This is the story of one of the most loving friendships I've ever experienced, and what I learned from it.

Years of struggling with self worth, and working through my trauma paled in comparison to moments with her. As much as I could do, achieve, and accomplish "trying to be enough", it never actually was. It was only when I met this person that I could finally stop fighting. I didn't have to prove my worth anymore because, for the first time since childhood, I finally felt like I was. It's ironic because she taught me how to love a version of myself that she brought out (that's the title of the book!).

That even as traumatized as I was, I could still be loved. And most humbling of all, she taught me that sometimes two people are not meant to be together, and that's okay. She was the kind of person who was competitive by nature, but held enough space to be caring for those around her at the same time. She was the best, and she expected you to be the best as well.

She would constantly work on herself, striving to improve, whilst pushing others in her life to improve as well. She gave everything she had, always. She worked hard for what she wanted, and wouldn't settle for anything less. If I could describe her, it would be playful, matching my energy at every turn, and competing in a friendly way.

She would never let any action go unnoticed, no matter how small, and was always grateful for everything small that I did. She always paid attention to how others around her behaved, and would always approach others with care and compassion, but she never put others above herself (this was an entirely new concept to me because prior to meeting her, I thought it was one or the other).

She always knew her value, what she was capable of, and her sense of direction was inspiring. She is the type of person who always comes out on top, she always ends up happy in the end. She never hid how wild she was and wasn't afraid to own it (she owned it like a BOSS). Yet, she always reflected upon herself, her mistakes/actions pondering about how they affected others around her. She was extremely self aware and emotionally intelligent. But she would take shit from no one, and would always "fight" to stand up for herself. She always got what she deserved. She would always look on the bright side, and was literally sunshine personified as a person. She would never be afraid to express herself and speak her mind, yet would constantly listen attentively and was always present in conversation. She was constantly adventurous, willing to try everything and push herself to try things outside her comfort zone. She had this crazy fierceness, but also was soft and gentle. It was amazing to see this switch. The way she directed her own energy was nothing short of beautiful.

Part of coming to terms with letting this person go was realizing that everything I just listed were things within myself I had either discarded or hidden away. Everything that she embodied, was everything that I myself wanted to be. I had to understand this to realize why I was so connected to her to begin with.

Because the lesson here was that, by loving her, I had to realize all the things about myself I actually loved. I had to answer the question:

What was she giving me that I wasn't giving to myself?

This friendship was a mirror for me. It showed me the parts of myself I wouldn't accept, the parts of myself I yearned to be, and everything about myself I needed to see. It was falling in love with her that I realized:

I really just had to love myself.

As amazing as she was (and is, not to take away from her) as a person, the lesson wasn't about her in the first place. She gave me permission to love myself, so obviously, I love(d) her for that.

But that's the hard part to accept sometimes. Some people might come into our lives to teach us how to love, even if they aren't the people we end up loving in the end. How ironic that the greatest love I learned wasn't in love.

Lessons in love: The one that wasn't meant to be

A Poem

You reminded me how to fall in love again,
and you reminded me that your happy ending
doesn't necessarily have to be mine.
You give me hope above all else.

You taught me how to be on the same team,
and that coming from a place of genuine love,
I will never lose; because if you truly love someone,
you're both winning.

You taught me to truly love someone fully in every moment,
knowing that it could end one day.

You taught me that it's okay to say goodbye,
and that it's okay to love again.
You taught me that my love is far greater than my pain.
You freed me from my trauma, and for that,
I will love you forever and never forget that gift.

You taught me to trust the process
and that it is what it is, no matter what it is.
You taught me that I don't need to have you in my life,
or even talk to you, because genuinely: you existing is enough.

You taught me that if we start with love, we should end with it too.
And above all else, you taught me everything I love,
from myself to others, from my flaws to my strengths,
you are everyone I love, everything love is to me,
and infinitely more.

I love this version of myself that you brought out.

LOVE CAN OVERCOME ANYTHING, INCLUDING AND ESPECIALLY HEARTBREAK.

To love someone so much that you can no longer be hurt by them is the most contradictory human experience of all. When you open yourself up to the idea that you are choosing love, you are choosing yourself, and that self love and love are the same things, you shift into a collaborative frame.

We can all win. It's not me vs. you, but rather that we're all going to make it in the end. Choosing the best for someone is also admitting that you are choosing yourself. This is the irony of love and heartbreak. We often think that love and heartbreak are opposites when they are, in fact, so closely tied to one another. The way you really get over someone is by loving them more than the heartbreak itself. Because in this love, you will find yourself again, and you will realize that love never comes at the expense of yourself. You recognize that if you loved them more than you loved yourself, it wouldn't truly be love to begin with. So we come to the shocking conclusion that **the only way to love someone in a heartbreak, is to let go of them.**

This is the paradoxical nature of love, letting go, and heartbreak. They're all interconnected. The old saying is that love conquers all. To us, we wish to believe that it transcends all, that it always works out in the end. But with a

quick examination, this is far from reality. In fact, love from one perspective almost never works out. It doesn't seem to conquer anything at all. In fact, it always seems to fail. When you define love in a vacuum, this is the case.

But when you come to accept that love is beyond a single human experience, you can recognize that a person finding love after multiple heartbreaks is love working out in the end. That it does, in fact, always conquer all. That in spite of all the betrayal, heartbreak, and pain, people do find love again. People smile again. There are many people with every right to turn their back on love, to go cold, and to never care again. Yet somehow, they seem to open themselves up again, and care again. It doesn't make sense, yet it happens.

Love can overcome anything, including and especially heartbreak.

The Greatest Challenge

A Poem

Losing you was the hardest thing I had to experience,
because losing you meant realizing,
I never had you in the first place.

Because the person who taught me how to love,
was never meant to love me in the first place.

Ironically, you taught me the type of love,
that you could never give me in the end.

THE GREATEST CHALLENGE - LOVE IS A LESSON SOMETIMES.

Sometimes you meet someone who isn't meant to play a lasting role in your life. They come in as a lesson, and that's why you're supposed to meet them. This happens to us regularly, but we only really feel it when we're in love with the lessons and can't let them go. Moving on is sometimes realizing as amazing as another person may be, they may be just a lesson you need to move forward, to love yourself more, to understand the world deeper. To me, this is the greatest challenge. I think the challenge was in accepting something that had already come to be long before. Our relationships with the ones we love are often already a certain way long before they end, yet we are surprised when they inevitably turn out the way they had always been. Love is humbling because it reminds us that we never really "own" people in the first place. **Love is an experience to be shared, not a feeling to possess.** Sometimes we need a little help to realize this. Meeting this person for me was also realizing they could never share that love with me in the way that I wanted. Sometimes recognizing that a love is unrequited adds to the challenge of letting go. Because we want to change it as if it belonged to us from the start. Losing a person is just realizing they were never yours to begin with. This is the

paradoxical nature of loss. That the teacher of love sometimes becomes, in essence, a symbol of unattainable affection. If you want to move on, you have to be willing to realize that the lesson is greater than them. The truth that emerges in loss is greater than the person who imparted it. Your heart will find its liberation — not solely in letting go of the person, but in embracing the power of the lesson they were to you.

THE METRICS WHICH YOU USE TO MEASURE YOUR LOVE/HEARTBREAK: HOW TO REFRAME

When you go through life, you constantly measure yourself. During a heartbreak, this value system is challenged even further. You measure your love with how much pain you feel, and your heartbreak with how much happiness you feel.

How are you measuring your heartbreak?

If you choose to define your hurt as the same thing as your love, then being hurt will only cause you to hold on even tighter.

“The reason why I’m so hurt is that I love them so much”

Reframe: The reason I’m so hurt is that I’m so attached to the future idea of what I wanted them to be for me.

“I’m healing from this breakup well because I’m happy and feeling good when I’m out with friends”

“but once I’m home alone, I feel lonely -> being alone is bad for my healing”

Reframe: The most important thing to me during healing is to feel, and to understand what it means to be human. Whether I'm feeling happy or I'm feeling sad, it's all part of the healing process. Healing isn't linear, and I have accepted there will be many ups and downs. This doesn't mean there's something wrong, but rather that I am going through the healing process.

Being patient with yourself means letting go of your judgments about your love and your healing process. Missing them isn't a sign you're doing something wrong. Being happy isn't a sign your love wasn't enough. Feeling guilty isn't a sign you were a bad person. Hold space for yourself to feel with an open heart without judging yourself.

The lesson in healing from heartbreak always comes back to you in the end. How you treat yourself and how you frame it is everything. Because how you choose to define it is also how you choose to move forward. **Allowing yourself to feel is allowing yourself to heal.** Rather than measuring your love or your heartbreak, permit yourself to just "go through the motions". Reframe your heartbreak to something that better serves you, rather than something that just hurts you more.

If you catch yourself measuring your heartbreak, it may be helpful to remind yourself that healing doesn't have to make sense. You can be happy one second, and then missing them the next. Be open to this, allow it to flow. That is how you move past it. You can never change what has already happened, but you can always choose to move forward from it.

WE CAN ONLY TAKE PICTURES OF THINGS WE LOVE, NOT THE ACTUAL THING ITSELF. WHY YOU CAN'T ACTUALLY "LOSE" LOVE

If you come across a sunset, a flower, or a breathtaking view, it may be in your instincts to take a photo of it. To preserve its beauty, revisit it sometime in the future to admire it again. But if I asked you "Did you lose your sunset?" How would that question land? Would it not make sense? If you lost the photo of the sunset, would the sunset be gone forever? The truth is, love, beauty, all the great human experiences for that matter, are just that; experiences. They are transient and non possessive by nature, yet we sometimes forget this fact and convince ourselves that we have the ability to own them. No one has ever gotten out of this life with more than they came in with. The same is true with love. A person's presence is like a sunset, a flower, or a breathtaking view. It can never be owned, but we do have the ability to take a photo of it. This is what memories are to us.

A lot of people say "I will never love again" or "I lost the love" as if love was something that they owned to begin with. If you lose someone (in the context of a heartbreak) you didn't really lose them, your illusion of ownership was just broken. You can never truly own anyone in this world, but you can admire their existence, which, to me, is even better. Leave it be, let it exist. This is how you really love

something. You don't love someone/something because it's yours. You love it because it is. When you accept this fact, you understand that love is beautiful because we can never truly own it. We can take pictures of it (these are our memories of love), but they are only representations of the true experience. The same is true of relationships. No matter how hard you try, no human has ever exited life owning another person. This feeling should be liberating, as you no longer need to "have love" it always just is. The reason why heartbreak hurts so much is because of our reluctance to keep our heart open. We impose ownership and expectation upon it. Of course, trying to contain something infinite hurts. It isn't meant to be limited.

As long as you decide a sunrise needs to be green (something it isn't), you will never be able to appreciate it for what it is (yellow and red). What if loving someone meant loving everything about them, including the fact that they don't love you back? (and in turn, letting them go). What if letting go of our "expectations" of them really meant allowing space for us to experience love with someone else?

Love is not something any of us can ever own, have, or even lose. It is infinite in its beauty, and something we all have the ability to experience. Keep your heart open, never close it. The heart is meant to be open, and when we close our hearts, it causes great suffering. We become disconnected from the beauty and vulnerability of love, isolating us from the thing that can heal us in the first place. In doing so, we miss the ability to transform, embrace, and hold ourselves with courage and compassion. The heart "break" is never the problem. It's the choice to close ourselves off with no intention of ever opening again that hurts.

WE WANT OUR PARTNERS TO CHANGE BUT ARE WE WILLING TO CHANGE OURSELVES?

An unsent letter

This was a hard learned lesson for me. Because I realized if you couldn't love me at my best, then there was no way you could ever love me. I guess I realized that the most loving thing I could do was to walk away, and through that act, end things with love. I will say this though: I really cherished what we had. It was so cute and I'll always hold a special place in my heart for what it was, but also always understand what it was never meant to be. We gratefully paid the price for the lessons we learned and I won't let any of the love go wasted by carrying these lessons forward. I guess we both realized neither of us could ever settle; I could never give you what you wanted, and you could never give me what I wanted. Choosing to walk away from each other was so hard when the only thing separating us was just how we felt about each other. I knew you would never ask me to settle for you, and I'm sure you knew I would never ask you to settle for me. Ironically, we brought out so much love with each other we couldn't even hurt each other in the end. Choosing to be strangers rather than choosing to hurt each other is one of the most bittersweet sentiments of our story. I guess I realized the only way I could really love you was to let you go, even if it was goodbye. But there is hope. I know that one day we will both move on and look back on this, laughing about the time things were so serious. It's funny because when we told each other about all the previous chapters we had closed, I never imagined that you too, would become one as well. I know I don't see it right now, but I know we both will find a love that ours could never be.

To me, this letter was about accepting love for all that it is and was. Sometimes in life, you're going to love someone who it's not going to work out with, and that's okay. It took me getting my heart shattered multiple times to finally realize this fact. That sometimes people just aren't meant to be, and from that, you can truly find love.

This person I had met had brought out so much love in me (not given me so much love because that's an important distinction) that we both realized we just could never be. What I wanted was diametrically opposed to what she wanted, and this wasn't a bad thing. This was probably one of the most expensive lessons I've ever had to pay for in my entire life, but it was worth it. Because I realized, If you truly love someone, or something, you can never truly change them. There's this quote from **David Bell** that has always stuck with me: **"Trying to change someone else is an act of aggression. Trying to change yourself is an act of love."** Even if our intentions come from a good place (it definitely does sometimes), it involves imposing our will onto another person. In the case of love/heartbreak, it means imposing our wants/needs (of them reciprocating, changing, etc.) onto who they already are.

Sometimes walking away from something, leaving something as it is, is the most loving thing you could do. To some, they may view this as giving up, or not "fighting" for love. But to me, love isn't something you fight for, it's something you fight together with. When you are in love with another person, the "fight" is to not allow your patterns to knock you out of love. When you are separating from another person, the "fight" is in your ability to allow them to be (even if who they are is someone who does not reciprocate your feelings).

Illogical.

A Poem

We never made sense,
but some part of me wanted
to believe anyways.

ILLOGICAL - LOVE IS

I think this is how it feels to love someone sometimes. It's a leap of faith, a hope that something will turn out differently from what we already know it to be. This is the part of love that really stings us when it doesn't work out in the end. Because that's all we have to go on when we decide to fall in love with someone. It isn't bad that we make this choice. Love is inherently illogical, yet we continue to choose it. Some may argue this is stupidity. But to me, this is an indication that we are courageous and hopeful creatures. That even among the mountain of evidence against love, we continue to choose it. There has to be a reason. For me, the reason is that we can find it in ourselves to hope for something better. Because if love is anything, it's our ability to be hopeful regardless of where we may end up.

Choosing to take the leap of faith isn't stupid, but something you may have to end up choosing for the sake of yourself one day. Healing is about making the courageous choice to walk away from something that isn't meant for you. If you have the capacity to believe in someone who wasn't meant for you, you also have the ability to believe you can move from it. Don't beat yourself up for trying or hoping for something better. This is the best part of being human. But

remind yourself that it was never about the outcome to start out with, it was about trying in spite of the odds. Because, amidst your heartbreak, this is what you need the most. You need the version of yourself that can rally and hope for a better future (without them) regardless of where you find yourself. Believing love could work out and then having it not is disappointing. But more disappointing than that is never picking yourself back up. Choose to believe again, and to try again. Do this for yourself.

We didn't make sense

A Poem

The more I look at it,
the more we just didn't really make sense.
I feel like we were everything we would want,
yet everything held us apart.
It's hard to come to terms with the fact that we were never
meant to last.
Not as lovers, not as friends, we were fated to end this way.

*(which is kinda sad but also kinda sweet because it makes me
cherish what we had so much more while it lasted.)*

WE DIDN'T MAKE SENSE - AN ACCEPTANCE OF EVERYTHING THAT ISN'T

Accepting that someone doesn't make sense is coming to terms with the fact that it's over. It doesn't have to make sense. That despite your undeniable connection and shared desires, sometimes things just don't work out. It's ironic and paradoxical in nature. Sometimes our collisions with others are just that: brief collisions leading to the inevitable divergence of each other. Accepting that you and your SP never made sense is coming to the harsh truth that the expiration of your connection was inevitable. Connections are meant to be transient, yet we fret when they inevitably conclude. You can either be mad at this, or come to terms with it. Accept everything that isn't, so that you can revel in the beauty of everything that is while it's in front of you. Love people as if you are going to lose them, because inevitably, and eventually, you will. This isn't an argument to be sad about love, but rather to find gratitude in the moments that defy logic and somehow leave a permanent impression on the heart. When you accept the inevitable end of something, there is a blend of sorrow and sweetness. Just like the connection you shared with this person, despite not making perfect sense, it had a profound impact on your life.

LEARN HOW TO DEAL WITH IT WHEN IT HAPPENS

One of the biggest mistakes we make is convincing ourselves that we can predict the future. This is an illusion created by our ego. So instead of trying to avoid getting heartbroken, or avoiding this feeling, cultivate the skills, create the space, embody the love, to deal with it when it does come (if it does). Part of the journey of healing from heartbreak is understanding that you can't actually know what's far in front of you. This is terrifying, but once you accept it, you can begin to hold yourself in this fear and create peace within. The end goal of healing from heartbreak is not never being broken ever again (as much as I use this statement, it's not literal). I personally think this is unrealistic and, even (to me) not very fun. Part of the range of human experience is feeling heartbreak.

However, I think that prolonged suffering is not necessarily a required human experience (suffering is, just not prolonged). As a result, I think once we can choose discomfort (consciously), and hold ourselves in it, this is truly where we heal. Where we can face what's to come regardless of what has already happened. It's courageous to keep loving in the face of loss. To remain unjaded in a world where being jaded seems like the greatest advantage of all. If there's one

thing to take away from your healing, it's that you can deal with it all. Some wounds may be harder to heal, but they can still be healed from.

This is also how you begin to trust again. You are not trusting because you know you won't be hurt again. You are accepting it wholly as a possibility, yet still choosing to trust. Because when you've healed, you know that you can pick yourself back up. That regardless of what happens, you will heal yourself. One day, you will understand why it's worth it not to be jaded and to continue to believe. Trust the process. If we could sum up what it means to humans, I think it would be just that. Finding it in ourselves to believe when everything tells us not to. Some of us may use this as an excuse to hold on to something that's already gone. But that's not the fight I'm talking about. Choosing to hold onto something that's already gone isn't romantic, it's just being cynical in a different way. It's choosing to accept that you won't find anything in front of you, and choosing to look backwards as a response.

Healing isn't an excuse to never find it in yourself to try again, or to avoid the whole process as a whole, but rather it's an argument as to why you should (eventually) try again. That despite all the odds, and how excruciating the experience may be, you can deal with it. You don't have to avoid heartbreak to heal from it. You just have to trust that you can deal with it. If you can't? Then learn. This is what people mean when they say to fall in love with yourself. It's not taking yourself out on dates or buying yourself flowers (although you may do this), but telling yourself that no matter what happens, you will pick yourself back up in the end. **Healing is in your ability to get back up, not how well you can avoid being hurt.**

I understand

A Poem

I understand that you never wanted to hurt me,
but that didn't make it any less painful.

I UNDERSTAND - AN ACCEPTANCE OF HURT

Sometimes people don't mean to hurt us. This doesn't really mean it hurts any less, but at least it gives us the opportunity to understand why it happened. That despite all the good intentions, it's often the people closest to us that we hurt the most. When you are experiencing the receiving end of this, it sucks. Being hurt isn't magically fixed, knowing that the other person didn't mean to hurt us, but it does serve a purpose. It's an acknowledgement and a choice to take a compassionate stance, rather than a vindictive one. Despite how you were hurt, you can recognize that the pain wasn't a deliberate choice. You do this not for the other person, but for yourself. The truth is, intention often doesn't really do much for the receiver of pain. But choosing to understand intention when we receive pain is an act of self compassion. It's a choice we make, rather than a justification of their actions from the other person. The deliberate choice makes all the difference. Empathy can coexist with your aching heart. Context breeds compassion, and compassion is the thing you need most during heartbreak.

FLIP THE SCRIPT. TAKE YOUR GREATEST WEAKNESSES AND LOVE THEM.

When you feel insecure about something (especially during a heartbreak), it's telling you there's a part of yourself that you need to love. This is how you flip the script. If someone says something that hurts us, it's often because we want them to accept that part of ourselves.

**You are too much, too extra. I can't handle your energy
sometimes -> I need to love myself and hold space for
myself to be me.**

The nuance here is that there isn't anything "wrong" with you, but there may be an imbalance, for example:

Needing love and affection is normal, but if you've been starved from it for too long, you may be labeled by others as clingy. The solution is to love those parts of yourself that are "clingy", that need love and affection, and to stop chasing someone else's approval to fix the broken parts of yourself. To just face the fact you threw those parts of yourself away from the get go. If someone makes us feel inadequate, it's not an indication of our worth, but a mirror reflecting something about them or ourselves. Hold space for yourself to accept all

of you, flaws and all.

If someone hurts you, criticizes you, and it really affects you, it's more a sign that you need to love yourself, rather than change their opinion. It's especially hard when it's an SP or partner, because we put so much weight on their opinion. But if you dig a little deeper, you might recognize the reason we put so much weight on their opinion in the first place is because of our own belief systems.

**“I don't believe I am enough” -> If I can love my partner/
SP enough, they will think I am lovable and love me ->
This will prove I am enough**

This framework sets us up to be completely at the mercy of their opinion. Our entire self-worth and belief system is based on whether they accept us or not. There is nothing wrong with wanting to feel loved or accepted, but when it serves as our entire framework, it may be beneficial to examine why that is the case.

If there's anything you should learn from a heartbreak, it's that you NEED* (I don't like this word, but I need to use it to emphasize my point) to love yourself. It is the greatest act of disservice and self-betrayal to not love yourself in the face of a heartbreak.

HOW ARE YOU FRAMING THE RELATIONSHIP?

As long as you frame a relationship as the end, the destination, then when it ends, you will always find yourself missing something. Partnership is a journey, not a destination. It's never about finding someone else, but finding yourself. Going deeper within who you are and loving yourself on another level. As long as you make relationships about the other person, you will always be at the mercy of what happens. Creating a strong relationship with yourself is understanding that it's about the process, not the destination. The reason why we go into relationships is to meet ourselves and, in the process, maybe grow with someone else along the way. But even this growth may be transient. It may be a stepping stone into something greater, this we cannot truly know till the very end.

If you truly want liberation from heartbreak, remind yourself that it was never about the outcome of the relationship to begin with. If, on some level, you needed it to be a certain way, ask yourself why. What was driving this belief in the first place? Perhaps subconsciously, you felt that if you found a loving relationship, that it would indicate that you are inherently lovable. What this feeling is actually revealing is that there is some part of yourself that cannot

fully accept you until you find a relationship. But this belief is self-destructive. There is nothing wrong with yearning for love, yearning for a relationship, but if it comes at the cost of your self worth, then perhaps it's worth evaluating why you hold that belief to begin with.

If a relationship doesn't work out, at the very least, don't punish yourself a second time. Loss is painful enough as it is. You don't need to create these stories to harm yourself even further. When you say things happened a certain way, you claim to know everything that is beyond yourself. Maybe you don't. Maybe things just aren't meant to be. Maybe things are beyond what you can perceive. If you want to heal, allow yourself this liberty. Allow yourself to say, **"this sucks, and I feel terrible, and maybe that's just how things are right now"**. There is no need to fix anything, psychoanalyze yourself, or come up with a solution. Maybe in this current moment, things just suck. Hold space for that, breathe into that, and allow yourself to be.

This is the important realization when we are first shaken by heartbreak. Our first reaction may be to deeply analyze and audit everything that we've done, or our SPs actions leading up to this, but know that such analysis will only break you further. Be with yourself in this moment. Remind yourself that it was never about the outcome. Slow down, and breathe. Pay attention to what you're saying to yourself, and what you're saying about the relationship.

LETTING GO OF SUCCESS AND FAILURE

As long as you are governed by “success” and “failure”, life will always be black and white, a dichotomy of preconceived notions of being. As with all things in healing, it’s important to discern whether something is serving you or holding you back. The mind incessantly labels things as failure or success, and that judgment leads to a lot of pain during heartbreak.

Your mind says the ending of a relationship means it’s a failure -> the relationship failed, so that must mean you or your partner is a failure.

The dichotomy of right and wrong, success and failure, is often a burden when it’s meant to be a tool. When you constantly judge your thoughts, you also become them. By letting them pass, you allow them to be without having to engage with every single one. Coming from a more nuanced place, **what would a breakup look like?** Maybe the fact that it ended isn’t a comment on anyone’s worth, but rather a comment on circumstances. Sometimes things don’t work out, and that’s okay. **Kobe Bryant** talked about success and failure as being two sides of the same coin. If you’re attached to success, you will always be governed by the fear of “what

if I don't?" and if you're attached to failure, you will be ruled by the pressure of not failing. When you allow yourself to learn, regardless of the outcome, you can come into balance and allow yourself to stay present and in tune with what's in front of you. Yes, the relationship didn't work out, but that doesn't mean it was a failure. It may be a stepping stone into something greater, the start of something you can't even see yet. The only way a relationship is a failure is if you choose not to progress from it. **Be courageous enough to start all over.** We are always going to be faced with moments and circumstances where we have to start over. It's scary exploring what's unknown, but we have to be willing to find ourselves in this place. The end of a relationship with someone else may be the start of the relationship with yourself.

The idea that healing or being broken are two sides of a dichotomy is limiting. You have not "failed" healing by spending time crying. You have not "failed" no contact by contacting them. You are not "broken" for **feeling** heartbroken. Understand that it is in your imperative as a human being to experience. You will not find yourself at the bottom of a stack of self help books, and you can't "become" healed enough. (The nuance here is that books can be helpful tools but not the "solution" to you)

**It's important to remind yourself that healing is a process,
not an outcome.**

MY SP MADE ME HAPPY?

People don't make us happy. Rather, they bring out a version of ourselves we truly love. With that love, we can accept and have trust in ourselves. Just because someone is gone doesn't mean that version of yourself is gone. You don't NEED them to have that happiness, they just reminded you of how happy you actually are. You just need to remind yourself that you can remember. That self acceptance is accessible to you at any moment. All you have to do is open yourself up to it. This means not discarding the love you have for them, but reintegrating it into who you are as a person. This is the ultimate act of self love.

It's going beyond your attachment to them, beyond what they mean(t) to you and the place they held in your life. **Take your time with this.** Realize that you do have it in you to love yourself. If you really want to remember happiness again, you have to stop attaching your worth to your SP. They did not make you happy, just as they did not "make you love them". You chose willingly, and openly, to do so. Recognizing that people cannot "make us love them" is simultaneously accepting we cannot make others love us. Remind yourself of this. They didn't make you happy. They may have given you permission to be happy, which raises the

question: why didn't you give yourself that permission in the first place?

If you have been stuck in this pattern for a long time, believing that other people, other things, or other circumstances are the only things that can make you happy, what you are really doing is limiting yourself from being happy without these things. It's a form of self parenting, a self restriction that is self abusive. Maybe you learned this from a parent, an adult, or some other thing in this world. But an honest audit will reveal to you that this restriction only puts you at the mercy of everything outside of yourself. Recognizing this, however, isn't enough to "just be happy". You have to be willing to let go of the part of yourself that is restricting you to begin with. You may have to let go of belief systems that you have been holding onto for many years.

The bottom line is no one makes us happy. They just quiet the parts of ourselves that say we don't deserve to be happy in the first place. Beyond depending on someone to quiet this part of ourselves, it's our responsibility to let go of it altogether.

Extra is my middle name.

A Poem

I know we're never going to share a last name,
but I do know, we will always share a middle name.

EXTRA IS MY MIDDLE NAME - A GRATITUDE OF A SHARED EXPERIENCE.

The poem “extra is my middle name” is an optimistic declaration in the face of a loss. Sharing a last name with someone is often the happy ending we imagine when it comes to love. Yet we often find ourselves falling short of this. Sharing a connection often transcends what we need it to be. The statement “I know we’re never going to share a last name” is an acceptance of the loss and that we will never be bound by the happy ending most of us usually wish for. Yet it ends with “we will always share a middle name”. This was a little inside joke between us, because when we first met, we would always say that our middle name was “extra”. It’s accepting that, however similar me and her were, we will ultimately never end up together. But there will always be a shared element, or a middle ground, that I could be glad we once shared — a middle name. The play on the word “extra” is an acknowledgement of humor and celebration of what our connection used to be. It’s an acknowledgement of the uniqueness and eccentricity we had, and celebrating that being a little “extra” is an inherent and perhaps endearing part of who we both are. To me, this is a poem acknowledging a shared experience with another person. It’s about finding a joy in a connection (even though it won’t end the way you want to) and blends humour with a touch of sentiment.

WISH I COULD TELL YOU.

A Journal entry

You helped me fall back in love with myself. You helped me let go of the past, and actually love myself again. I wish I could tell you how great things are, but this entry will suffice.

I would often write journal entries addressed to her. This was my way of coping with the fact that she was gone, and we could not contact each other. For me, the heartbreak was the opportunity to fix the relationship with myself. She really did help me fall back in love with myself. She had such a profound impact on my self perception that all I wanted to do back then was let her know how much she had affected me. The phrase “you helped me let go of the past” was to emphasize what that relationship was to me. It was a catalyst for me to heal emotionally and let go of everything that had happened to me prior. The truth is, meeting this person had a profound impact on me. It shifted the course of my life, and my heart forever. An egotistical part of myself would claim that I never think of going back and gracefully accept that this is the path I’m on now. But truthfully, part of me always looks back. “I wish I could tell you how great things are” is an acknowledgement of this part of myself. It’s a bittersweet acknowledgement of the desire

to share the positive changes directly with the person who played such a critical role in my journey, but not being able to because we are no longer in the past. The concluding line, “but this entry will suffice” is the final acceptance of this. It acknowledges the limitations and complexities of expressing these emotions directly. Despite my desire to convey my depth of appreciation, it would never be just that. The act of journaling is powerful in this way, because we create a medium for self expression, without having to actually involve another person. If you truly love someone, you have to be willing to leave them in the past (when it’s over), and part of that willingness is being able to leave things unsaid, or for me, leave them in a journal entry.

THE DEPTH TO WHICH YOU FEEL IS A GIFT THAT YOU ARE GIVEN PARTICULARLY.

If you are able to feel this deeply about someone else, this just means you are able to feel this way. It's not about them, or what happened, but it is a proof of your capacity to feel. If a heartbreak really hurts, this just means you cared on a very deep level, and you were very attached to the outcomes you had set in your mind. This doesn't mean that how you feel is wrong, or something that you should be ashamed of. How you feel is how you feel. This is the greatest gift you have been given. No one in this world can love the way you do, see things the way you do, and understand things the way you do. They can't overcome your experiences the way you can, because they're YOUR experiences. When you recognize that loving deeply is not a problem, you also realize that you can give yourself that very same love. The very container with which we experience pain and loss is the very same with which we use to experience love and joy. As bad as it is, it is only testament to how great you can actually feel. Should you close your heart off, you are essentially closing yourself off to the good that life has to offer as well. The reason why your love for them was so great to begin with is because you had the freedom to love. The ability to take a leap of faith, regardless of the fear, is what it means to be in love.

“Loving others gives us courage and being loved gives us strength.” - Lao Tzu (Paraphrased) Once you make an effort to love yourself on this level, you can open yourself up to all of it. The love, the pain, the joy, the agony, and you realize holding space for yourself is to experience what it means to truly be human. **It takes courage to be this way.** To allow yourself to feel. To allow yourself to be broken, to allow yourself to be healed. It's all outside of comfort.

Your individual human experience is your gift. No other being in this existence has ever, or will ever, experience things the way that you do exactly. It's also your choice how you wish to use this gift. Whether you choose to cherish this and experience life to its fullest potential, or close yourself off from it, is your responsibility. Rather than throw away your gift because you find someone who isn't willing to accept it, accept that you may have just chosen wrong. Your ability to love wasn't something that came from them. It's a gift that you were given the moment you were born. Choosing to take this away from yourself because they are gone is only punishing yourself. You have it in you to choose yourself again. Choosing love and having it not work out is one of the hardest human experiences of all, yet it's also one of the bravest things we do. **Don't let someone else take credit for your act of bravery.** Your ability to love is never contingent on another person, but you can choose “wrong”. Sometimes, things might not work out in the way, or with the person we desired, and it's really in these moments that we have to pick ourselves back up again. Once you are willing to embrace this gift for what it is, you can truly allow your individual experience to be. The depth to which you can feel isn't some curse or universal decree that you are doomed to fail. It's a gift and something you've always had within you.

Loving together, and loving apart.

A Poem

With us

there was no your love vs my love it was
always our love.

So no, this isn't me loving myself,
but me loving us

I choose to walk away from what we could've been because
I truly love us.

LOVING TOGETHER AND LOVING APART - CHOOSING TO SAY GOODBYE TOGETHER

If there's one thing I learned from her, it was that love is a team effort. It's a collective experience, a joint force, rather than a separate entity for each person. I think we often lose sight of this in heartbreak. Love is something we share, it's not something that's divided. Shifting from "our love" to "me loving us" is an acknowledgment of the shift from a shared identity to a personal love within the context of our relationship. It's loving the connection for everything that it was, but also realizing that it was coming to an end. When the only way to continue loving someone is to walk away from them, it's an extremely hard thing to do. But you are willingly forgoing everything that you want, because you love everyone involved. It's choosing the best for both parties, even if that means the end of the connection itself. For me, it meant choosing the well-being of both of us, even if it meant letting go of a potential future that didn't align with both of us (together). It was a difficult choice, but ultimately, the only one there was. If you want to love someone, sometimes that means saying goodbye as well. At the very least, it's the last thing you can do together. The decision to part ways with someone you love is an act of love itself. It's a recognition that sometimes the health of the relationship, and by extension, both individuals, should be prioritized over a romanticized potential future. It's choosing a love that transcends your immediate desires for the well-being and shared entity of "us".

EVERYTHING YOU WANT FROM THEM IS REALLY SOMETHING YOU NEED FROM YOURSELF.

To be loved, we constantly throw parts of ourselves away, discard complete versions of ourselves to be protected, to be accepted. This is the most painful experience of all. Telling ourselves that the world isn't big enough for us. When you believe you are not good enough, you think that you can disprove this if you just got someone to love you, but then you self sabotage when you actually meet someone who does love you anyway. Humans want homeostasis, we avoid change, and choose comfort. Recognize that if you want to move forward, you have to allow yourself to be uncomfortable. This might mean confronting the fact that everything you seek from them is actually something you have disowned within yourself. You don't heal by discarding more of yourself, but by reclaiming those parts of yourself you abandoned in the beginning.

As cliché as it may be, it really is never outside of us. Some part of us always knows this, but yet we keep trying to change the external. If you want them to love you back so desperately, what it's really telling you is how badly you need to attend to yourself. The more you try to get something from the external, the more you actually reinforce the belief system internally. For example, the harder you try to be

loved, the more you feel unlovable. This is because you would only work for love if you felt unlovable in the first place. The nuance here is that you can take this too far, and balance is always important. But oftentimes, in heartbreak, we find ourselves begging, pleading with everything we have for the other person to stay. We want them to give us a chance because we think it will mean we have proven we are worth loving, that we are worth staying for, or that we don't get abandoned in the end. But you need to question why you need to prove it to begin with. **You are already worth loving, worth staying for, and you don't deserve to be abandoned.** But if you try to prove it, you are really only abandoning yourself because of your own self doubt. Don't get me wrong, wanting someone to stay when a relationship ends is normal. But when we need to convince them of something *more*, it's more often about something within us. You don't need anything from them. What do you need from yourself? This is the real question you have to answer.

WHY BECOMING COLD (WITHOUT MOVING PAST IT) IS ABANDONING YOUR INNER CHILD

Experiencing apathy, and an overall uncaring attitude towards things, people, and even life, is a normal and healthy part of heartbreak. However, if you choose to stay in this state for a prolonged period, what you are really telling yourself is that there is a part of you not worth holding space for. You are telling yourself that this part of yourself has no space in your being and that you must discard it. This is why you feel “nothing” — because you’re opting to discard the part of yourself capable of feeling, right from the start.

Oftentimes, this part we throw away is our very care and love for the other person. When we have been in prolonged suffering for too long, we decide that caring and loving is no longer worth it. It’s too much to feel, so we discard this part of ourselves. What you will quickly realize is that you cannot selectively care, or selectively love. Choosing not to love is cutting yourself off from it entirely. This is why it is a form of self betrayal. It is telling yourself you’re not worth healing, not worth loving again, and not worth being vulnerable again. When you are stuck in this apathy, it can feel impossible to get out of. Think of your inner child for a second: When we are young and have a dream (like becoming an astronaut, for example), eventually something tells us

otherwise. Whether it's the world, our parents, culture, or some other voice, something tells us that we can't do this thing, that it's impossible, and that we should just "grow up".

When you become "cold" you are essentially telling this part of yourself that it's not allowed to exist. It's a form of self restriction and self betrayal. It's the equivalent of throwing a child away out of fear of what parenthood entails. It's saying I will not allow a part of myself to love because I cannot handle what happens if it ends. If becoming cold and closing your heart off is discarding yourself, what then is the solution? Becoming overly emotional and having no emotional temperament doesn't seem like an option either. This is where the concept of holding space is really important.

When you hold space for yourself, you open your heart to feel what you need to feel, without letting the feeling define who you are. This might mean just breathing into your emotions, allowing it to flow through your body, and accepting it without judgment. Just as you should not judge a child for crying, you should not judge the part of yourself that cries as well. You must remind yourself that you are more than just that part of yourself. You are not choosing to abandon yourself, but you're not choosing to give up in the emotions either. This is balance. Hold space for yourself to feel, but also stand up for that part of yourself and never let yourself be hurt in the same way ever again.

Holding space for yourself to feel, to be, and to exist without judgment is the ultimate form of self love. This isn't an argument for complacency. It's an argument for emotional temperance. It's saying, Yes, it's okay to be broken, but it's not okay to stay broken.

It's saying that yes, healing and finding yourself again will be difficult, but it's the kind of work you are willing to do for the sake of yourself. Choosing to care when you really don't want to means caring about the parts of yourself you deem unworthy of care from the beginning. Once you recognize this, it becomes a balancing act between caring about the parts of yourself that have been hurt, and moving forward as well.

When we struggle to break our patterns, it's often because we identify strongly with the circumstances we find ourselves in. Perhaps deep down, we believe we deserve our current situation, or that we are destined to be this way. The reason why it's helpful to frame these things in terms of our "inner child" is because it can put things into perspective. If you think you are unlovable, think back to the child version of yourself.

Are they unlovable? Do they deserve misery and suffering? Sometimes it's only when we frame things this way that we can recognize that we are really being emotionally self abusive. So if you choose to stay cold, just remember what you are really telling yourself. Find it in yourself to be someone who you needed. Be the person you've been waiting for. Move past the things that hurt you, because you don't deserve to stay waiting in the pain.

WE'RE ALL ON THE SAME TEAM. IT'S ABOUT WINNING AGAINST OURSELVES. IT'S NEVER BEEN ABOUT BEATING EACH OTHER.

We live in a hypercompetitive world where competition and conflict are our defining interactions. In a “kill or be killed” world, we often find ourselves engaged in struggles against each other, but for what? I think when we can recognize that the most significant competition is the one we face within, we can truly find peace. In the context of a heartbreak, the answer is the same. It's never about your SP and what they did to you, but rather how you act and behave in the face of their actions. When you decide it's about tempering your wounds and emotions so that you can act with intention, the burden no longer lies on your SP. Use your heartbreak as a forge to temper your heart to be open, to stand for your values, regardless of what situation you face. Our success lies not in defeating others, but in a world where we can all relinquish our enemies.

Fighting, whether in a relationship with your partner or on a global scale, inevitability, leads to war. If you repress how you feel to please your partner, you will eventually build enough resentment to fight back. If you are adamant that they are wrong, you will act in conflict until either party resigns. This perpetual conflict will be found in your relationship, your life, and everything else that you do.

Sustained conflict only breeds an environment of division, resentment, and broken connections. Every instance of pain, no matter the source, tends to set off a chain reaction when it is expressed without self-temperance. It snowballs, and grows, eventually affecting people who were not there to begin with. New partners have to deal with a SP's baggage, and future partners (FPs) have to deal with current partner conflicts. This cycle of pain is something that we all experience and something that affects us all, especially in relationships. The only way for us to break free from this is by choosing not to exert dominance over others.

Power over others is weakness disguised as strength.

-Eckhart Tolle

(with some nuance here)

As long as we try to control our partners, make them feel a certain way, love us a certain way, or behave in a way that "doesn't hurt us", we will always find ourselves stuck in this cycle of pain. **The only path to freedom is through mastering ourselves, tempering our emotions, reactions, and actions.** This is necessary for our strength and resilience. When we temper our wounds and our pain, we no longer have any enemies to go against. We are free from the limitations that we put on ourselves.

If our partner is being hurtful, we no longer take it personally. It's not about us. It's about them. Maybe they have been hurt before, and they are merely acting out and projecting their pain. Once you make the commitment to not having enemies, someone being hurtful doesn't define you in the end. Coming from a place of temperance and self love, you can decide to hold your heart open for them, or to walk

away if you choose. You act beyond reactivity and begin to act with conscious intention. It is not fear you are choosing, but love on the highest level.

This, of course, is easier said than done, and takes a lifetime of practice (it's best to start now), but each time you decide to not take someone as your enemy, the closer to freedom you get. If you want to get over your SP, it may be in your best interests to realize that grudges, animosities, and conflicts are merely forms of energy that tie you to them — limiting your potential for growth and happiness. Never forget that you always have the opportunity to ground yourself in the fact that they are imperfect, they are flawed, and they are human, too.

Choose a world where we can all win, where we can create a better future for ourselves and for those who will succeed us. When you choose to let go of your SP, you are choosing to create an environment where collective success is the goal. You create a positive feedback loop that you will bring into your next relationship with your FP.

Teamwork

A Poem

Because when we started,
we agreed we'd lose together,
or win together too.
So if you're winning,
that means I'm going to be
winning too.

TEAMWORK - AN AGREEMENT THAT LASTS LONGER THAN THE RELATIONSHIP ITSELF

Any relationship, regardless of its affiliation, requires some level of mutual understanding and shared values. "We agreed we'd lose together" is a statement acknowledging this fact. Oftentimes people refer to breakups with SPs in this way: "he lost you" or "she lost you", as if the loss isn't mutual to begin with. When you love someone, you commit to facing both successes and challenges together. The end of your relationship is the same. You both lose each other, and you both lose something as well. This idea of unity sets the expectation that whatever challenges or triumphs come your way, you will face them as a cohesive team. The idea of this poem is to challenge the notion of individual success within the context of a relationship, and as an extension, the breakup/separation. If you truly love someone, you are both winning. This idea for me was really tested when I experienced how happy she was in the love that she found. The lines "so if you're winning, that means I'm going to be winning too." was an acceptance of this. That her finding happiness with someone else wasn't gonna be a reason for me to lose, but rather an indication of the love that is meant for me, too. It's like I always say: when you accept they aren't the love for you, you accept a love that is. The underlying sentiment is that the success of someone you love is not cause for jealousy or competition but an argument for shared joy, especially when you understand you can find a different love as well.

I WOULD GLADLY LOSE YOU.

A Journal entry

Because where I'm at, I realize that if I had to choose between lying to you or losing you, I'd choose losing you every time. I'm sure you could say our connection was too good to be true, or that it just wasn't a good connection, but I choose to believe otherwise. I think you outgrew me and I outgrew you, and that doesn't have to be a sad thing. I played the role I was meant to play in your life, and you did in mine. Our connection no longer served you, or served me, but continues to serve us. I know you're living your best life and so am I, and it's funny because the more time we spend apart, the more I find myself loving you and just rallying for you. We're better apart, and better together, and that's the most ironic truth of us. Because I am happier with you, without you, and my love for you transcends any need to be with you or to have you in my life, because you existing is enough for me. Your very being is my love for you. So when I say I'd choose losing you, what I really mean is that I'd choose both of us being happier :)

I think this journal entry was about accepting the nature of our changing connection. That in the grand scheme of things, we were evolving in a way. The only way we could stay in each other's lives was if we had chosen to lie to each other. Because once two people realize they outgrow each

other, there isn't a possibility of going back. We both realized we had moved forward and that neither of us could ever go back to the way things were. "I would gladly lose you" is a line that challenges the idea of attachment and possessiveness we usually have in love. It's about our willingness to prioritize accepting what is (however uncomfortable it may be), over clinging to a relationship that's already ended. Some connections are meant to end, or in a better framing, some connections are meant to evolve. Rather than seeing this evolution as something bad, I realized the connection could still serve us (by choosing to let it end). Sometimes we have to say goodbye to the people we love, for everyone involved to be happier. We have to accept that a person played a role, and that even amidst loss, will still serve a purpose to our heart. Love for a person that transcends any need to be with them is an admission that love is an essence that exists independently of the external circumstances you find yourself in. The irony of being "better apart" and "better together" is an acknowledgement that happiness can coexist with physical separation and is meant to challenge the idea that love requires constant togetherness. Sometimes, choosing love means telling the truth, even if that truth means losing each other in the end. Because it's in this choice that you choose for everyone to find happiness. Rather than framing "losing" as a negative outcome, it's an acceptance that is positive and that both parties can thrive independently.

WHY YOU SHOULD SAY GOODBYE WITH GRACE AND HONOR. YOU'RE SAYING GOODBYE TO SOMEONE ELSE'S FUTURE ENDING.

When you say goodbye to someone who is not meant to be in your life, you are actually saying goodbye to someone who is meant to be in someone else's life. This also means there is a high likelihood that someone has to say goodbye to your future ending as well. If we all inflict trauma on the people we say goodbye to, we are essentially doing the same to our future partners as well.

If someone causes trauma to your future partner (FP), you will have to deal with it in the end. If you cause trauma to someone else's future partner, they will have to deal with it in the end. As long as we choose pain, we will all feel more of it.

Choose grace and honor, because it's what you would want for yourself and your future partner. You're admitting to yourself that your SP wasn't meant for you to begin with. The only reason why you would hurt them is because, to some extent, you still want them to be right for you. And if they are, hurting them doesn't make sense either. When you're ready to accept that your SP wasn't meant for you, you will regret the hurtful things and energy you attached to them. When you choose grace and honor, you are also reducing the amount of work and trauma for yourself (and your future partner). The amount of space you hold for hate

(towards your SP) is space that takes up the love you could give to your FP and yourself.

To me, choosing hatred and aggression as a goodbye is the equivalent of getting in a last word before someone dies. If this really is the last moment you have with them, why not make it a good one? Put aside your hurt for a second, along with how they treated you and what they did. This is all irrelevant. They are about to die in your life.

If someone is going to die, I'd like to send them off with grace and honor. To remember them for the good, rather than the bad. To prepare myself to create a life without them. This is a choice for me, not for them. It's so that I can move on, create a happy life without them, and not be tied to the past. Making this choice is the only way to make peace. Saying goodbye is hard, and often our reluctance to accept it in the end prevents us from being able to cherish the final moments we have with this person. Be gentle, and be kind, because it's your **last moment** with them.

MISSING IN A DIFFERENT WAY

A Journal entry

Today I missed you in a different way. not because I was sad it's over, but because of how happy I am. I'm doing so great, I wish you could be here to see it. Because I know me being happy is something that would truly make you happy too. I love life and all it has to offer and you were always an amazing reminder of that.

The idea of “missing in a different way” was how I felt when I realized that a part of myself had shifted. The moment happens when you're missing them, not as a result of sadness or longing for the past, but as present state of happiness. I think it's these moments that are really hard because you remember a time where the first thing you would do is share how you felt with them. Missing them isn't always going to be during moments of melancholy. It can happen when you're happy and living your best life, too. Understanding you were once on a team, and once shared a mutual connection, is an acknowledgement of the past. That you once shared an investment in each other's well-being, even if the physical presence is no longer part of the equation. **It's a love despite the distance.** The purpose of this journal entry was an exploration of this experience that we don't talk about as often. It's an understanding that missing someone doesn't have to be linked to sorrow, but it can also be an act of gratitude. It's an appreciation of the positive impact a person had on your life.

RELATIONSHIPS ARE MEANT TO CHANGE. A THOUGHT THAT CAN SHIFT YOUR PERSPECTIVE AND ENERGY

One of the reasons why the end of a relationship can be so difficult is because, to some degree, we hold the belief that it will last forever. We measure the worth of a relationship by how permanent it can be, when life, in fact, is impermanent. Relationships, romantic or otherwise, are not static entities. Some people may come into our lives to teach us how to love better, what we don't want, or who we need to be, never to be seen again.

As we start to age, we recognize that any conversation with a person may be our last, and when we reach the finality of life, this recognition becomes even more expected. This isn't an argument towards being cold, bitter, and unattached, but rather to recognize that just because something doesn't last the way you wanted it to doesn't mean it holds no value. You could have loved or been loved with all of your heart, and it could still end. The ending of it doesn't define the value of it. However, refusing to accept that it's over holds yourself back, and even if they don't realize it, it holds them back as well.

This is why letting go is so important. You are allowing the connection with this person to dissolve, as it has served its purpose. You are opening yourself up to connection with others and not closing any part of yourself off to love.

Letting go with grace and honor means understanding that every person in our lives has a last day with us. It's opening yourself up to the idea that perhaps their absence will be the reason you can love as deeply as you can. There is the paradoxical idea that absence can deepen one's capacity to love. As the saying goes, "absence only makes the heart grow fonder", and although this is true, we also are able to transmute this growth towards ourselves, away from the SP we are so attached to. This is the irony of letting go, because it's only when we let go of one thing that we can really open ourselves up to receiving another.

Embracing change is one of the most important things you can do for yourself as you heal. It's allowing yourself to return someone back to the universe, and understand that you never owned them to begin with. Once we embrace that change is inevitable, we can truly cherish everything in front of us to the best of our ability. **Love people as if you are going to lose them, because eventually, and inevitably, you will.** The human heart is resilient. It will grow and expand, but only if you let it. At times, it may hurt because we resist the change it's going through — we restrict its expansion. We believe that trying to hold on to something that's already gone will somehow change everything that undeniably is.

This is what we all have to do. Embrace it, accept it. The only constant is change. This is the essence of our journey, and the reason we're here on this earth. Every relationship in your life serves a purpose. Some people come as teachers, imparting us with wisdom we will carry forward for the rest of our lives. Others may leave a mark on our heart that changes the way we experience love. Each collision with another person, regardless of its duration, is meant to teach us something, or contribute to our experiences.

Let go of the story that a relationship is only successful if it doesn't end, because they all end eventually. Life isn't permanent. Embracing change is an act of strength, a conscious decision to return someone back to the universe. It's accepting that the end of one thing is inevitably the start of another. As we release the grip on what once was, we come to accept that every person in our lives has a last day with us. It is a form of surrender that will finally allow you to move forward.

Our Finish Line

A Poem

I hope you know that..
Even though we don't talk,
or may seem distant,
I'm still rallying for you.
As any teammate should.

I'm not choosing you,
I'm not choosing me,
but I'm choosing us.
Even if us means being strangers.

Just because we aren't in each other's lives anymore,
does not mean for one second that I want you to lose.
Because hey, if we started with love,
Why not end with it too?

OUR FINISH LINE - EXPLORING LOSS AS A TEAM

One of the recurring themes in our time together was the idea of teamwork and relationships being like a baton relay race. It's an understanding that the finish line for us has come to pass. When you're in separation, there is an irony to it. You still support, love, and care for the other person, yet you don't talk and seem more distant than you've ever been. The opening stanza is an acknowledgement of this. That you can still care for and understand the other person despite the distance. The idea that you can choose an "us" beyond an individual, is a liberating thought, because it indicates that sometimes the most loving thing you can do is to let go. Embracing this reality sometimes means embracing the evolving nature of a relationship, whatever that evolution may be. Despite changing and growing in different directions, there is a commitment to the positive aspects of the connection you once shared. Sometimes this isn't the best choice to make, but the only choice you can make. If you choose to try to hold on to something that is already gone, you may end up hating the other person, or vice versa. Choosing happiness for everyone involved means ending with love. The closing question "If we started with love, why not end with it too?", suggests that love, having been a foundational element of your connection, can persist as a guiding force even as the nature of your connection evolves. You can always make this choice to choose love again, even when it really doesn't seem like an option.

WHAT'S THE STORY GONNA BE?

Maybe this isn't the story of how you're left broken. Maybe it's the story of how you reconnect with yourself, reconnect with your inner child, and integrate your shadow. Maybe you finally realize all those times you didn't trust yourself, ignored the signs, and didn't speak up was because you needed so badly to be loved. People always ask: **"Why didn't they choose me"** — and to them I ask; **"When did you choose you?"** We all want unconditional love, but how many of us actually choose that for ourselves? We constantly discard parts of ourselves, then look for the missing pieces of ourselves in others, when we were the ones who discarded those parts in the first place. Maybe this is the story of you finally realizing that everything you've done has been a cry for help from your inner child, begging you to accept them.

Maybe this is the story of how you finally start loving yourself.

When love was our choice.

A Poem

I didn't lose you,
and you didn't lose me either.
We never needed each other, we just chose to be
in each other's lives.
And for that time we did choose,
I'll always be grateful.

WHEN LOVE WAS OUR CHOICE - GRATITUDE IN THE FACE OF LOSS

Grief isn't something that we choose, yet how we react to it is. The common narrative is that a separation is some loss and that each heartbreak has a winner or loser. The idea of this piece was to challenge that despite the evolution of a connection, neither person has been lost. It's meant to be a collaborative frame that assumes connection is something we choose, even if separation is something we don't. The line "we never needed each other, we just chose to be in each other's lives" seeks to challenge the traditional notion that dependency defines love, and highlights the voluntary nature of connection. We are always provided with a choice to choose, and whether we are grateful for that choice or not — defines how we persist over time. The title "when love was our choice" is a nod to the fact that although we may choose love, we don't often have a choice when it ends. This harrowing fact is complemented by the concluding line of gratitude. The truth is, every connection ends one day. We never really get to choose when it ends. The choice we do have, however, is whether we can appreciate it when it's in front of us. Transience is something inherent in every relationship we face in our lives. Gratitude is the response we have when we understand that a chosen connection may be unique to a certain phase of life.

THE “CAMPSITE RULE” - WE CREATE THE LOVE AND PAIN WE EXPERIENCE IN THE WORLD.

The campsite rule states “Leave the campsite better than when you found it”. In the context of relationships, I think of it as “try to leave people better than when you found them”. Regardless of whether you’re broken/breaking up with someone, your actions will affect yourself in the end.

There’s the saying that healed people heal people, and that hurt people hurt people. If we don’t break the cycle, we will receive the pain we put out into the world at some point. If everyone “has a villain arc” or everyone’s ex is “evil” we are all doomed. Although the campsite rule is annoying and frustrating (especially when someone else makes the mess), it’s our world we choose to live in.

By choosing the best for your ex, you are really choosing happiness for yourself. If you choose to wish them misery, just know you are also wishing misery for yourself (the nuance here is that misery can actually be healthy during the emotional process of moving on. Just don’t get stuck in this misery).

Everyone deserves to be happy, even if they don’t deserve to be in your life.

The solution to pain isn’t more hurt. This only makes it

worse for everyone. If you decide that you want to close your heart off so that you can avoid ever being hurt again, you are more than justified in doing so. If you are even considering such a thing, you have probably gone through more pain than anyone should have to experience. But just know that if you become the very thing that destroyed you, you will end up hating yourself. We can't wish for misery upon others and then complain about how miserable the world is. If we want to break the cycle, we have to do it together. This is the only way.

Applying the campsite rule means adopting a non-zero sum mentality, or in other words: **"we have no enemies"**. If everyone wants their ex to be miserable (and they get their wish), what would the world look like? We constantly complain about how bad the dating pool is and how hard it is to find love.. Yet we constantly pollute the dating pool ourselves. We believe that we need to hurt or be hurt, leading to more pain for all of us.

In a zero-sum mentality, there will always be winners and losers. If this guarantees us anything, it's that we will not find love in such a scarce mindset. When you let go of someone, let go of them with love. Not for them, but for yourself. You deserve to be happy, too. The world we live in is a direct reflection of how we all collectively decide to treat each other.

THE STORY WE TELL OURSELVES

We all have some stories we tell ourselves about love, heartbreak, and how we live our lives. For me, my story is that everyone I fall in love with whom it doesn't work out with — ends up with their husband as their next partner. And without fail, this has always been the case. My **headcanon** (it's important to highlight this because it is in my head) is that although things didn't work out with me, they are guaranteed to work out with their next partner. It is a way for me to send them off with peace and acceptance.

They find their happy ending. To me, this is a self admission. It's a promise to myself that they were never my happy ending to begin with. Admitting that they have found their happy ending (and it isn't me) is an admission that I have yet to find mine. It's closing my mind off to some imagined future. It's the ultimate form of surrender. It is accepting everything that is and forgoing everything that is not. **I am everyone's second last love. After me, they will never face heartbreak ever again.** They will always end up happy in the end. Which also means my happy ending is on the way as well. To me, the faster I let go of someone who is not meant for me, the faster I run towards someone who is. The reason why I chose to share this "story" I have in my head is because it is a reframe of the belief system I used to

have under a victim paradigm. I used to believe that I was never lovable, which is the reason why people seemingly only fall in love after I fall in love with them. I cursed the skies at this injustice and felt as if I was the most unlucky person in the world. But what I came to realize is that what I was really saying was that I was unwilling to imagine a better future for myself. It was never about them in the first place. I just made it that way. Everyone of us decides what these stories and belief systems mean to us. Part of healing is taking an honest audit of why we hold on to these stories, and whether it's something that serves our highest purpose.

If the answer to that question is no, perhaps it may be important to reframe the story, or to let go of it entirely. The current **headcanon** I have laid out above is merely a tool to help me accept that someone isn't really meant for me from the get go, because in the end, that's all it is — just a story.

CAN'T DECIDE WHETHER YOU WANT TO MOVE ON? THE WAR WE FIGHT WITHIN OURSELVES.

If your heart and mind are at war, you can find out what you truly align with by flipping a coin. If the coin lands on tails, you move on. If it lands on heads, you hold on. The beauty of this is the moment when the coin is in the air. You already know what you truly want (whichever you are hoping for). There is no need to fight what is. If you truly wish to hold on, allow yourself to do so.

Allow yourself the space to heal. The reason you are at war with yourself is because of your expectations of what you “need” to do. Maybe this stage of your healing process isn’t “getting over them”. This is your permission to hold space for yourself. You cannot let go unless you truly want to. Healing is many things, but it is not forced.

If you are still thinking you “have to move on” or “need to get over them”, it’s important to realize that what you resist, persists. The point isn’t to force yourself to feel a certain way, or to repress a certain feeling. It’s allowing the emotion to flow through you, to allow it to be. Surrender to it, accept it, and show it love and compassion. You can never truly move forward until you are willing to. It doesn’t matter what self-help books you read or what rituals you do, letting go is a process that you will self sabotage if you don’t truly want to let go. Take time to truly figure out if you want to let

go of them or not, because the truth is, sometimes you don't.

It is only once you end this war within that you can truly heal and find peace again. As long as you are conflicted between moving on and holding on, you will be torn apart. Make it a priority to be in harmony before you choose to let go, to move on. Because this isn't a simple decision, it's something that will require all of yourself. You can't go at it without giving it everything you've got.

So if you're not ready to let go and move on, **don't**. Take your time. Enjoy your last moments holding on to this person, embrace your memories with love, and cherish everything you held sacred because you will let go of it, eventually.

WHAT IF I NEVER FIND SOMEONE ELSE TO LOVE ME EVER AGAIN? YEAH, WHAT IF?

This question only really reveals one thing to yourself. If the entire world was against you, if the odds were never in your favor, and everything was going to fail, how would you treat yourself in the face of that? The actual outcome is not actually important. Regardless of whether someone loves you or someone doesn't, the qualifying statement will be how you treat yourself and love yourself irregardless of this outside reality. Can you tell yourself you're lovable, when there's seemingly no proof (there is)? Are you willing to rally for yourself and your heart when no one else will? (others will) Can you love yourself unconditionally even if no one will? (someone will). You can survive the world abandoning you, but you will never survive abandoning yourself. The question I always ask myself is: *Why would I ever need to doubt myself when everyone else is going to do it for me? Why should I stop believing in my dreams if everyone else discards theirs?*

The response we have is always the opposite of what we really need. We need love, so we call ourselves unlovable rather than giving that love to ourselves. We need people to believe in us, but we never give ourselves that trust. We need to be accepted, but discard parts of ourselves that we wish to be accepted. Breaking cycles is pretty much impossible, that's why they've been carried for generations. All the

heartbreak and pain that exists in the world is just passed on, compounded, and carried on. You have to understand what you're facing. The amount of courage and relentlessness you will need to break yourself out of a cycle is basically insurmountable. So you need to make sure that, at the very least, you love yourself; you trust yourself, and you are your greatest ally. There will always be an opposition, in whatever you do, whether it's healing and breaking cycles, getting over someone, or finally being lovable or enough, you have to make sure that

you are not that opposition.

When you have a thought like "what if I never find love" or "what if I die alone", the response you have is not actually about the question. What you are really asking is the implication of the question. What you are really asking is if you can be alone. **Can you love yourself anyway?** The purpose of this isn't some argument to devolve into self destruction or hyper independence. You aren't accepting these questions as reality or your chosen paradigm, but rather you are choosing to act regardless of what the external has to say. That even if you are to be alone, you will still choose peace. That even among the hardest of circumstances, you will choose to be open. If you really believe you're meant to be alone, choose to love yourself anyway. If you are destined to live out some tragedy (you're not) then why would you berate yourself in the process? I think many of us (myself included) punish ourselves for being alone or being lonely. Yet if this really was the case, that we were destined to be alone and spend all of life by ourselves, why would we make ourselves our own enemy as a response? If there's one thing to take

away, it's this: At the very least, you have to be there for yourself. You have to be the one willing to save yourself, when all you want is for someone else to save you. As you go through life, you will have a list of people who don't believe in you and are against you. Make sure you aren't at the top of that list, or even on that list at all.

This is what I learned.

A Poem

I guess you taught me to
be the love I needed from you.
That the only person who could love me
the way I needed, was me.

THIS IS WHAT I LEARNED - YOU HAVE TO BE YOUR GREATEST ALLY

The highlight of this connection was the idea that we could not love each other without first loving ourselves. This was everything she was to me. That love always includes yourself. She would never fail to remind me of this. The title is an acknowledgement of a significant lesson I learned from this particular person. She taught me how to love myself, and how to be the love that I needed so badly. I realized, amidst the loss of this connection that what I was really seeking was an acceptance from myself. I think it's an ironic truth to why we seek out love sometimes — we search for something beyond ourselves, while simultaneously discarding that very same part. If you never really accept and love yourself, some part of you will always believe you are inherently unlovable. This is why some people say that love begins with yourself. Relying solely on an external source of love will always lead to unmet needs. If this guarantees one thing, it's that we will end up abandoning ourselves for the love that we crave so deeply. The only way we can truly prevent this is to recognize that love should always include ourselves. Self love isn't just something we need to do, it's the most important thing we can do. It's not about the other person (although sometimes another person may teach you this lesson), but how you can choose to be your own greatest ally.

THE MOST HEARTBREAKING THING DURING HEARTBREAK: HOW WE TREAT OURSELVES IN THE FACE OF HEARTBREAK.

The Buddhist Sallatha Sutta offers a metaphor for how we deal with pain. It describes the two arrows we receive. The first is the pain caused by the loss, heartbreak, or rejection. The second is the pain we choose to inflict upon ourselves after the fact. More often than not, most of the hurt during heartbreak is inflicted by the second arrow, not the first.

If you were shot by an arrow, would you get mad at yourself for bleeding or for being hurt? We can understand this sentiment so easily when it comes to physical pain, yet we never apply it to ourselves emotionally. After a breakup, many react by telling themselves they were never enough, never lovable, or that they deserve the pain. They might say to themselves:

“Im so f*cking stupid for falling in love anyway”

It is normal, human even, to feel broken, yet we judge ourselves for it. Instead of allowing ourselves to be human, we judge, label, and attack ourselves for being hurt. Sometimes healing just means stopping yourself from causing yourself more pain.

It's truly heartbreaking because most people punish only themselves for being hurt. They decide that love is not

worth it and close themselves off, swearing to never open their hearts ever again. They punish their own hearts for loving and rob the world of themselves.

Maybe the reason you are struggling to heal is that you are hurting yourself (for being hurt). Let go of the judgment and hold space for yourself to be. Your thoughts, expectations, negative self-talk, replaying of painful memories, and self-blame are all weapons you choose to attack yourself with. If you are already hurt, allow yourself to heal. **Don't cause yourself more pain.**

DON'T HEAL TO GET BACK AT THEM, HEAL TO LET GO OF THEM. IT'S A GIFT TO YOURSELF.

Vengeance and pain are powerful forces. When pain engulfs the world, and everyone becomes consumed with revenge, pain, and vengeance, we weaponize everything we have, even the parts of ourselves that wish to do no harm. This can become extremely self destructive (think about forcing a child to fight in a war), but choosing to let go is creating space for those parts of yourself to be in pain.

If you choose to weaponize your healing against your SP, you should know you are only attaching yourself to them even further. **Healing is the greatest gift you can give yourself.** It's not about your SP. It's completely understandable why this idea is alluring, though. Healing to show them what they lost allows us to feel self righteous. It's as if we have to show them what they lost, because we feel like we have lost everything. But perhaps healing is realizing that you have not actually lost everything, and that maybe they were just another person in your life.

If they were never right in the first place, you would never have to prove them wrong.

Choosing vengeance means being consumed by it, perpetuating the cycle (which we inevitably will feel the

effects of whether we like it or not) and perhaps even hurting someone who never hurt you to begin with.

Healing has nothing to do with who your SP is. It's an act of reclamation, re-loving, and rediscovery. You find out what you're made of, how strong you really are. Choosing vengeance means unwittingly tying your progress to them. This is a self betrayal, because you surrender your own control of your emotions to them. Deciding to heal, however, is relinquishing the control they have over you, choosing to no longer have them as your enemy. This is not an act of war, but an act of liberation.

When we heal, we break free from the chains that bind us to the past and escape the cycle of pain. It allows us to open ourselves up to the beauty of the present and the opportunity of the future. You learn the resilience of your spirit and your ability to transcend everything that hurts you. **It is the ultimate form of self empowerment.** Healing to let go of someone is a gift to yourself. Healing to get back at them is only tying yourself to the other person more. When you refuse to let the past define who you are, you are free. When you choose to break the cycle of revenge, pain, and vengeance, you are at peace.

GIVING YOUR SP A HAPPY ENDING, IS IN TURN GIVING YOURSELF A HAPPY ENDING.

When you look at your friends or celebrities getting happily married, why is this not painful? (if you have trapped yourself in a loneliness paradigm, it may be painful). The reason being is that you have no attachment to their story. You never convinced yourself that you were meant to end up with them. You can rationalize that their happy ending is disconnected from your ending.

When you realize this, you can also realize that the thing that is hurting you during heartbreak is your attachment to the story with your SP, not the situation itself. To some degree, you still believe, you still hope that one day, maybe, you could end up with them too. Part of moving on is eventually letting go of this story, letting go of the idea that they're your soulmate, letting go of the idea that they complete you, letting go of everything you want them to be, and accepting them for everything that they are. Obviously, this is easier said than done, and if it were easy, everyone would do it. But to me, this is the **ONLY** way you can truly come back into freedom. It's the only way you can truly set yourself free. Because when you accept that they are meant for someone else, you are also telling yourself that they are not meant for you and, in turn, that you are meant for someone else. The fireplace exercise is something I came up

with to illustrate what this feeling is like.

You think into the future, and imagine a happy ending with your FP (not your SP). Maybe you have kids, but you're surrounding a fireplace. There's laughter, joy, and the moment is perfect. And in this moment, you remember the time you were heartbroken (right now) over someone who wasn't meant for you. You remember how real the pain felt, and how monumental it was. That it felt like you were losing the entire world. You smile. Because you know in this moment that everything was meant to happen for you to arrive at your current moment. If you didn't lose your SP in the past, you couldn't be here in this moment enjoying the love and joy of your family. You smile in gratitude for having met your SP as it got you to this moment. You send love back to that version of yourself, reminding yourself that it's all part of the process, that it's all going to be happy in the end.

The reason why I love this exercise so much is because it reminds me that we can all be happy in the end. It's admitting that your SP can also have a happy ending. But if you choose to hold on to something that isn't meant for you, what you are really saying is that you are refusing the happy ending, which is yours. You are telling yourself that you don't deserve to be happy to begin with. It is a disservice to attach yourself to an ending that isn't yours in the first place. You will only create resentment and regret within yourself if you choose this. Let them go, let them have their happy ending. You're not doing it for them, you're doing it for yourself.

Acceptance

A Poem

He's better than me.

Not because hes **better** than me,
but because hes **better** for you.

He fits you better.

You guys are cuter than we could
ever be.

This isn't me giving up.

This is me admitting we are both,
meant for better things.

Because I too, will find someone,
better for me.

ACCEPTANCE - THE REALITY OF AN ENDING CONNECTION

I wrote acceptance when I had come to realize the new love she had found was greater than anything we could have ended up creating together. When we find out someone we used to love has found a different love, it's often in our instincts to claim we're better or more special. This is our ego's last attempt to hold on to something that is already gone. How could we be better than something that actually exists? (implying that the past is no longer here anyway). The idea of the opening line is an acceptance of this reality. "he's better than me" isn't meant to be literal. For a long time (for me), it was. One of my greatest traumas was never being enough, so the thought of someone being better than me was always me falling short. However, this poem is an acknowledgment, that isn't the case. It's an acceptance that the other person is better, not in an absolute sense, but that they may be better suited for the person you once shared your connection with. The emphasis on this poem challenges the idea of perceived superiority we often have when it comes to heartbreak. We claim to be better, yet we are not together. This is not based on anything other than reasons our mind puts up as a defensive response. The acknowledgement that "he fits you better" is meant to suggest that something that exists only in my mind could never hold a flame to something that exists

in reality. The admission that the new relationship the other person has found is “cuter than we could ever be” is meant to let go of the bitterness and resentment we often hold for the ones we used to be connected to and often their new partners as well. It really is a form of surrender. “this isn’t me giving up” is a response to the idea that we often see letting go as giving up. It’s being willing to accept what’s in front of you, even if it’s not what you want in the moment. This acceptance isn’t a one way street. It’s not wishing someone else’s happiness and yourself misery as a result (it’s important to highlight this because a lot of people do this). “Admitting we are both meant for better things” is a recognition that both individuals and all of us, for that matter, have the capacity to find relationships that better align with what we need out of life. I end the poem on a hopeful note, expressing that I, too, will find someone better suited for me. It’s a declaration of optimism. That me accepting a love that isn’t mine isn’t an acceptance I won’t find one in the end. It’s meant to imply that the end of this particular connection, doesn’t indicate the end of meaningful connections as a whole. The idea of this poem was to express how it feels to see someone you love fall in love with someone else, but to still continue to choose something better. It’s to surrender and accept what’s in front of you, even if your ego says otherwise. It is only once we accept that they’re meant to be with someone else, that we can also accept someone else is meant to be with us.

WHEN YOU'RE SAYING GOODBYE, GIVE EVERYTHING YOU HAVE, ALL OF YOUR HEART. YOU ALWAYS HAVE MORE TO GIVE.

When you're saying goodbye to someone you love, you are performing your final act of love for them. You are defining how your heart chooses to say hello again. If they are leaving you, love with everything you've got. Open your heart to all of its tenderness and vulnerability — and be willing to be stupid. When you do this, you are telling yourself that you will never run out of love. That even in the face of unshakable odds, you will choose to be open. You will overcome it. This is the greatest thing you can do for yourself. You are loving them and letting them go, because you know with absolute certainty if this is goodbye, at the very least, you should say goodbye with love. You will always have more love to give if you're willing to give everything you have, but if you spend it sparingly, you will always find yourself running short. This isn't an excuse to chase after something that isn't meant for you — **loving always includes yourself.** Therefore, loving them also means letting go of them if they aren't willing to choose you as well. If this seems impossible, recognize that the only thing that can overcome it is love. You have to love them more than your attachment to them, and more than your need to have them in your life. When you choose to say goodbye with love, you are really choosing to love yourself. Loving them also means loving

yourself enough to recognize **when it's time to let go**. If the love you hold is not mutual, then the love you have becomes the guiding force you need to let go of your attachment to them. It's a recognition that love is not just an emotion confined to the time you spend together. It's a force that continues to shape your relationship even in separation. Love has the power to transform a goodbye into a story of growth and evolution. It transforms into a bridge between what was and what can be.

This isn't goodbye

A Poem

We were not meant to be,
but the love is not gone.

I will find you again
In the next person I love,
and embody the love
that always was,
and always will be.

In every beautiful moment
that we could have shared,
and in every one that we did.

Our chapter may be over,
But you taught me to be
love itself, and share that
with others.

So even though we won't
be in each others lives anymore,
I know I'll find you once again.

Because you are everyone I love,
everything love is to me,
and infinitely more.

Love is never wasted.

THIS ISN'T GOODBYE - LOVE IS CONTINUOUS

The opening lines of this poem are meant to convey that love is something more than an immediate connection, and something that transcends a simple physical existence. It acknowledges that although our particular chapter has come to an end, that the love is not gone. It's meant to suggest a belief that love is transformative and enduring, and transcends the context of one relationship. It's meant to explore the idea that love isn't attached to one particular person. "I will find you again in the next person I love" isn't an excuse to hold on to the past, but rather a metaphor for the continuity of love. That loving one person isn't just about them. Maybe it's the way they make you smile, or the way they see the world. The essence of love is continuous and will carry forward. The commitment to embody the love that "always was, and always will be" is a statement to describe that the love we experience is a constant, regardless of the specific individuals involved. The third stanza is to embrace the idea that we can cherish something even when it is gone or even if we had just wished for it to happen. To me, this is embracing love for what it is. It is to be "love itself" and recognize that it's never about one particular person. It's a recognition that love is more than just the person we attach it to. The fifth stanza is really reassuring

me. It's an admission that although we won't be present in each other's lives, I will find the person once again. It's an expression of my optimism and my belief that love transcends a singular person. To clarify this idea, the sixth stanza universalizes the concept of love. That when you love someone deeply, they transcend a singular individual. It's to reinforce and emphasize that loving a person isn't just about them. It's limitless and all-encompassing. The final line of the poem, "love is never wasted" is an idea that love itself is not something that ends. A singular relationship may come to an end. But love itself is never wasted. Loving is a choice we make, a beautiful one at that. When we recognize that we can separate it from a particular person, we can recognize that we aren't really saying "goodbye". It's a testament to the enduring nature of love, and how we learn from it, carry it forward, and the optimism that love transcends a specific individual and a specific moment.

DON'T FORGET HOW IT FELT WHEN YOU STARTED.

When it started, it felt like you had no care in the world, that you were willing to try, regardless of the outcome. That no matter what happened, you were all hands in and you were willing to take a leap of faith. This is the tragedy of us as human beings, we always forget. We need to remind ourselves of things, or we will be sure to forget them.

Remind yourself how it felt to fall in love, how courageous you were, and how willing you were to experience the joy of being. Use that feeling to remind yourself that you chose this, that it was better to have loved and lost than to have never loved in the first place.

Transmute this love and courage back into yourself. Love yourself for everything you've done, everything you did, and everything you are to do. Hold yourself in all of your acceptance, and realize there is no person in this world worth forgoing your love for. This is your gift. No one in the world can take this away from you. You can always decide to pick yourself back up, to open your heart again, and to love yourself on a deeper level. If you're stuck in a state of being closed, remind yourself of your inner child, the version of yourself that wasn't scared of love, that was willing to take a leap of faith, and that wasn't traumatized by experience. Connect with that part of yourself, and realize that being closed is just punishing that part of yourself.

Freeing yourself from the past or your SP doesn't mean forgetting them. It isn't forgoing your love for apathy. It isn't becoming better than them or finding someone better than them. It's finally realizing how much you've been abandoning yourself by choosing someone who is not willing to choose the same. This may mean apologizing to yourself for chasing after something that wasn't meant to be chosen to begin with. We constantly abandon parts of ourselves and blame others when we are hurt in the end. I'm not saying your SP didn't do anything wrong, or that they treated you perfectly, but the question to ask is why you put up with all the things you don't agree with in the first place.

It was a form of self abandonment. You told yourself it was okay, because if it wasn't, you would "lose the love" from them. This form of self abandonment is so insidious because we often can't recognize that we are doing it. Recognize this and choose to never abandon yourself ever again. This might mean building the inner strength and space so that you can love without self abandonment, or that you can trust without doubt, because you know that you will love yourself in the end. The solution isn't to depend on others to make ourselves feel whole and accepted. We accept ourselves and become whole so that we can trust others and keep our hearts open. Becoming outcome independent is the greatest gift you could ever give yourself. You are essentially telling yourself that you love yourself unconditionally. That no matter what happens, no matter the outcome, you will always have your own back. It is the ultimate form of courage, and is having no enemies personified. It is truly what it means to be a beautiful human. No one can ever hurt you anymore because you have chosen to love yourself irregardless of what happens. Be willing to love yourself this way. It is in your imperative.

FOR WHEN YOU MISS THEM: WHEN THEIR EXISTENCE IS ENOUGH FOR YOU

An unsent message

Sometimes you meet someone whom you love so much that even their existence is enough for you. To me, the lesson I learned was that although we were just never meant to be, I will always be glad you exist. At the very least, I have that. I can move forward knowing that every experience, every memory, was beautiful, but also that I had to honor the past by moving forward into the future. I didn't want to hold you back, and in turn, hold myself back as well.

This piece was pondering the idea that perhaps some people are just meant to exist. That even if we can't have them in our lives, we can still appreciate their existence. Sometimes you find a connection that deep, that it goes beyond the need for any participation in each other's lives. Coming to terms with this is hard, but sometimes it's all you have left of them. If you want to move forward from a connection like this, the point isn't to forget everything that happened. Because if the connection was that deep, how could you? Yet, you can't stay in the past, holding on either. You have to honor what was, by moving forward. In this way, letting go isn't giving up or throwing in the towel; it's the greatest act of love you could ever perform. Letting go isn't a singular act, because you choose to free yourself as well. It's a choice that

loving actually does include yourself. To me, it's a liberation, a choice of freedom for everyone involved. This piece was to contemplate the idea that some people are meant to be transient, and allows for a connection to be significant, regardless of the specific form it takes.

I'm just so glad you exist.

A Poem

When I say I miss you, I don't mean it in some sad miserable way, but in a way that honors that connection we had. Not in some regretful way, or not even in some way that says I wanna see you again, but I just truly miss you.

This isn't coming from a negative place, and you aren't the only thing in my mind anymore, But there are moments which I steal away and think, wow.. You would have loved to see this.

This isn't a: I wanna be friends again..
Or even a: I want you in my life again..
Because I know that we both know deep in our hearts That we aren't meant to be, and that's okay.

And as tragic as our story was,
I hope you know that; every memory of us has infinite value to me, and couldn't be replaced for the world.
I will love and cherish every single experience we had, but also honor that memory, by moving forward with acceptance.

I know there's an infinite amount of words that have gone unsaid, but I know that no words could say more than the silence between us.

That being said,
I'm just so glad you exist.

I'M JUST SO GLAD YOU EXIST - AN APPRECIATION BEYOND AN ENDING CONNECTION

I'm just so glad you exist is a poem written to acknowledge the complexities involved in accepting the end of a connection. The opening line challenges the idea that missing someone is a sad or regretful thing, but rather a genuine acknowledgment of the connection that was shared. Sometimes you care for someone so deeply that you may still miss them, even if your intention is not a desire to relive the past. Sometimes missing someone means honoring the connection that once existed and recognizing the impact it had on your life. The second stanza is meant to emphasize that you can move on from someone, that you can live in such a way that they no longer occupy all the space in your mind. Yet, this doesn't entail forgetting the past. If you really loved someone, it's entirely possible you may find fragments of them or echoes of a love that once used to be. You might find them in the sunsets you deem necessary to share with others, or in the smiles that bring you joy. Missing someone isn't a bad thing. But you can realize that sometimes it's just about appreciation. The third stanza is a full acknowledgement that although you miss someone, it isn't cause to reconnect. Missing someone is normal, but not some divine intervention telling you that you are meant to be. Accepting gracefully that you aren't meant to be is coming

to peace with the fact that it's over. That despite sharing the connection you did, you can truly understand it's gone. The fourth stanza is meant to highlight how goodbyes can sometimes be tragic, that amidst all the love, we can still find ourselves in agony, yet it is counterbalanced by the assertion that every memory has an infinite value. The stanza seeks to recognize that goodbyes, and relationships, for that matter, are complex and contradictory in that way. You can never replace the past. That's what I meant with the line "couldn't be replaced for the world." As long as you try to, you're looking back and not moving forward. Cherishing it for what it was is accepting what happened with a healthy approach to closure, yet you have to move on to honor what it once was to you. The fifth stanza illustrates the complexity of goodbyes and closure. The truth is, you will always have more to say. There will always be one more thing that you need closure from. The only way you can move from this is to allow the silence to speak the words you never could. It's meant to emphasize the depth of connection, transcending any need for verbal expression to begin with. Finally, the final lines of the poem are meant to convey the acceptance of the end. The gratitude you can find in the memories, and the appreciation you can have for someone beyond their ongoing interaction in your life. Missing someone is complex, and nuanced. **Sometimes you may find yourself smiling at the past, even if you know it's no longer real.** There is a bittersweet nature to deep connections with others, that despite not enduring, they can remain cherished and valuable to our hearts.

I'M JUST SO GLAD YOU EXIST - CHOOSING TO BE PROACTIVE INSTEAD

Once you say something, it's said. Regardless of whether you meant it or if it wasn't intentional, it will always have a lasting effect. During a heartbreak, it's almost always the case that people say something that they don't truly mean. Recognize that this is the case for your SP as well. The purpose of no contact is to heal, and to prevent further damage from both sides. You may end up saying something that hurts them, or vice versa. So given the choice, you should always opt to leave words unsaid rather than saying too much (*there is nuance here, you can still say certain things, I just mean dragging on contact over a prolonged period). One day, when you move on, you will be glad that you chose to break contact because it allowed you to think clearly and act in a way that aligns with your highest self rather than your most wounded self.

It is choosing to be proactive, rather than reactive (to the best of your ability). In this sense, you are literally "creating space" for you and your SP to heal individually. It's a proactive choice, rather than a reactive one. It's choosing to shield both parties from further harm and choosing to heal. Choosing to leave certain things unsaid is a gesture of compassion, not just for them, but for yourself. Sometimes this means leaving that "I miss you" to be unsaid, sometimes it means leaving that "this reminded me of you" text unsent.

The reason why there's the saying "**if you love someone, let them go**" is not meant to test their love in any way (although it's often portrayed this way). It's there to ensure you can embody a commitment to your wellbeing and the wellbeing of your SP. It's a consideration on the highest level, beyond what you need from them. The art of saying too little is a conscious effort, a compassionate act of understanding, and most importantly, **love**. It provides the necessary distance for emotional wounds to heal.

WHEN MOVING ON FEELS IMPOSSIBLE.

No matter what you try, it seems like your connection to this person is unbreakable. You've tried over and over again, trying your hardest to move on from this person, but nothing seems to work. You keep finding yourself connected to them. If this has happened to you, maybe you've just met someone who is so much of a mirror to you that you can no longer deny yourself. When we love someone, what we are really seeing is a reflection of ourselves. If you are lucky enough, you can meet someone who compliments you so much that their spirit is almost akin to yours. It's as if they are, on some level, the same being as you.

When you meet someone who "completes" you in this way, what really occurs is a self realization. When you fall in love with them, you really permit yourself to fall in love with you. Breaking the connection with them is the equivalent of breaking the connection with yourself. It's the same as discarding the parts of yourself you have now discovered you actually love.

Some people succeed in this, only to find themselves as a shell of the person they once were. But if you're finding it impossible to get over this person, maybe it's because you're not trying to get over them, you're trying to go back to how you once were. Unawakened, unconscious, and unaware of

your true essence. When you met this person, something in you permanently changed. Going back is no longer an option. Trying to force your way back is painful, and I'd argue impossible (although some people "succeed", I don't think they really do, I think they are just denying themselves). So rather than trying to disconnect from them, accept that your connection is there to begin with, and transmute it back to yourself, because your connection with them has been about you in the first place.

There is no need to "forget" them, as it would be akin to forgetting a part of yourself. This is the reality of loving with all of your being. When you fall deeply for someone, you integrate a part of their being into your very own soul. Their impact and their presence will last with you for a lifetime. This isn't something you can just "forget" or "move on" from. I'd argue that it isn't something you should strive for in the first place. Because they came into your life for a reason, maybe you need to love yourself the way you love them, and that's the point. Maybe it's loving more than how much you can be broken. Maybe it's caring for them enough to realize that care doesn't come at your own expense. On some level, they revealed to you the missing parts of yourself. They weren't the missing pieces themselves.

This has two significant meanings. One: You don't actually need them to be "complete" you just need to remember the experience, love it for what it was, and accept everything that it couldn't be. Two: you don't actually want to forget them, because forgetting them would also mean forgetting a part of yourself. To me, this is the greatest self betrayal we could ever do. We decide to discard a part of ourselves just because the person who revealed it to us is no longer in our lives. It seems like a futile effort to "get back"

at them, when we are really just punishing ourselves. We tell ourselves stories of how we were “stupid to love”, when love was never about the outcome. So when moving on feels impossible, it really is about ourselves. Because people move on from other people all the time. This is normal, and even what is to be expected. But when we struggle to let go of “someone”, it’s because they are beyond a person. They are a form of permission, an idea, or a belief system. If you truly want to let go and move on, you have to be honest with yourself and realize that this is what they are to you. How could they be a person in your life if they are no longer present in your life?

The only way they exist to you is by persisting through an idea, a belief, or something within you. You have to make the decision to separate these nonphysical constructs from the actual person. Humanize them. They aren’t perfect, and they aren’t the villain or hero of your life. They too, like everyone else, are a flawed human being who, for a moment, had an encounter with love. You only remember them in that context, because maybe to some degree — you need that version of them in your life.

But this is just our desperate attempt to go back to something that’s already gone. Humanize them because you need to, and because you’re choosing to set them free. Remember that they aren’t special. You just made them that way (the nuance here isn’t saying that they aren’t special as a person, but their relative value to you was given by you). Moving on is only impossible because of one person, and it’s never them (your SP). Whether it’s because of your own reluctance to let go, or your resistance to the life in front of you, the only person holding you back from freeing yourself is you. This isn’t some directive to blame and berate yourself

for this. You're aware, to some extent, that you choose to hold on. See this part of yourself for what it is — its desperate attempts to hold on to something that no longer exists. Its last ditch effort to preserve something already gone. Love this part of yourself, be patient with it, and let it go. The only way you truly move on is if you first accept that this part of you exists to begin with. You can't escape struggle till you admit you are struggling. You can't let go unless you admit that you are holding on.

THE SCARY MOMENT IN HEARTBREAK

There comes a moment in your heartbreak that's scary. Not when things end and you're emotional, but the scary part is when you no longer have to prove to them you're worthy, because when you don't have to prove anything to them, that's when you're really letting go. When you don't have to concern yourself with what they're doing, who they're with, and you just accept that they are a separate entity from yourself, this is scary.

Because this signifies the end. Of course, it's scary.

It means something new is coming, and that the thing that has been occupying you for so long is finally ending. Even if it was painful, even if the heartbreak made you feel like throwing up, endings are scary. It takes a tremendous amount of courage to accept this. To love it for what it is and accept that it's finally over. Maybe you were at war with your heart, and you have to be willing to leave the front lines and come home. It's terrifying. **When all you've known is war, peace can be scary.** How are you supposed to trust again? How could you ever let your guard down after that?

This is what really scares us, and scars us. Because when we are heartbroken, in a way, we are fighting, whether we're fighting what is, what they've chosen, or who they are, we are fighting. But what comes next? What happens when the war is over, when we have to hang up the gloves, pack up, and go home? When we no longer have an enemy to face? I think the reason why we tend to get stuck on people is because, on some deep level, we aren't ready to let go of them. That's the only reason. We might come up with many reasons like it's because of this and that, but it's all noise. We choose to keep the fight going because **what happens if we stop being mad at them? Stop being sad about them? They disappear.** They are removed from our lives. The moment we let go, they're gone, so we hold on to anything that keeps us connected to them, whether it's anxiety, sadness, or even pain. We choose to hold on because we aren't ready to let go of them. So rest assured, letting go is the scariest part of healing. It's choosing to start over, to begin again, to become vulnerable again — to choose peace because the war is over. And if you're not there? Don't worry, because you will be, eventually.

So just take a deep breath and accept that wherever you are, there you are.

PICK YOURSELF BACK UP WITH COMPASSION. PUSH YOURSELF WITH EMPATHY.

When you are heartbroken, there is a lot of pressure to “get over them” or to “move on” and sometimes, this pressure can lead to forms of emotional self abuse. Adversity is not just an opportunity to rise again, but to do so in a way without self harm. Too often, we find ourselves grappling with self criticism, negative self talk, and harsh judgements, making it even harder to move forward.

Beating yourself up, calling yourself stupid, or berating yourself in any matter doesn't help the healing process at all. Although, it may help you to be more apathetic towards the situation (which only pushes the work to a later date). If you are to fall down, make mistakes, and relapse, pick yourself back up with compassion.

Understand why you “made a mistake” or why you treated yourself in such a manner, and commit to not doing it again. When you stumble and fall, tell yourself:

“It's alright, you're human, that's okay.”

Compassion doesn't belittle or berate; it offers an open hand, rather than a closed fist, to guide us through the hardest of times. **Mistakes are only failures if it ends where it occurs.** More often than not, people “fail” because of their own

emotional self abuse.

If compassion helps us mend our broken spirits, empathy then becomes the driving force that keeps us moving forward. Never forget how broken you were, and how it felt to struggle. Understand it, love it, and push yourself because you wish to fight for that version of you that needed it. Too often during heartbreaks, hearts go cold due to this lack of empathy, and we become the very thing that hurt us at the beginning. It's easy to forget that we all deserve empathy, especially the parts of ourselves that were hurt in the first place. When we come from this place, we relinquish our greatest enemy: **ourselves**. When you are your own greatest ally, this is when you can truly heal.

There are two types of change in this world. Change through domination, and change through willingness. If we approach the former (i.e. changing when you really don't want to) like we always have, we are headed in a direction of war. As long as there is a "winner" and a "loser", we will never find peace. If we force change, it only leads to resentment, eventually repeating the cycle of rebellion. But if we approach from the latter, encouraging change (but not forcing it) we can actually reach sustainable change. The same is true of our innermost world. If you become "better" without considering the parts of yourself that are hurt, you will be at constant war. If you improve and change from willingness and love, you will have no enemies within.

Understanding why the parts of yourself are the way they are, and then holding space for them to change, is the greatest act of service you can do for yourself. Locking parts of yourself away will only lead to more internal conflict in the future.

Empathy urges us to acknowledge our emotions, granting space for them to be felt without judgment. Compassion allows us to pick ourselves up when we inevitably fall back down. This combination is a transformative journey that allows us to live in ways we could never imagine. It's the ultimate form of self love, nurturing, and empowerment. **We build resilience because we aren't concerned with the outcome, but rather focus on how we act in the face of the outcome.** Slowly, we build a greater capacity to love ourselves, and in doing so, love life and everything around us.

IT WAS US AGAINST THE WORLD

An unsent message

It felt like nobody was like us, that we were different, we were elite. The way we bounced energy off each other was like a competitive match where both opponents love their competition. Finding someone who is so kindred to myself really helped me finally accept myself fully. Because accepting all of you, flaws and all, was accepting me. Our connection was sacred, and it felt like all of me was all of you. I know how crazy that makes me sound, but I felt as if I knew you in every life prior to the one we're living now. I never felt that "on the same team" ever before, and you truly taught me what teamwork means. It's crazy to think that such a devastating heartbreak could have such a positive impact on me. Because with you, nothing could ever go wrong. Somehow, I always find myself loving this version of myself that you brought out. Because if your love taught anything to me, it's that I need to love myself. Loving you is impossible without loving myself, and that is one of the most esoterically beautiful gifts I have ever been given. Losing you taught me how to find myself. Thanks for teaching me how to love me. There was no your love vs my love, it was always our love. So no, this isn't me just loving myself, but me loving us. I choose to walk away from what we could've been because I truly love us. If I have to lose (temporarily) for us to win, then I'll choose that every single time.

This piece was written to express how I felt. It was a declaration that although the connection I had cherished so much had come to an end, there was a lesson that I could find in its ending. Sometimes you might meet a person who feels like *everything* — *unparalleled, elite, rare, and unique*. Yet, as great as it is, sometimes it still comes to an end. I think it's in these connections that we are really provided with the opportunity to love ourselves. That losing something so great is really learning that there is something to be found. Describing the ultimate lesson I gained from this person as the "most esoterically beautiful gifts I have ever been given" is meant to emphasize the interconnectedness of self love and love for a partner: they are the same thing. You can't really love someone without including yourself (she never failed to remind me of this). When you truly and deeply love someone, you're both involved. It's not just about an individual but the collective "us". Sometimes, to win, you have to commit to losing (temporarily). It's an acknowledgement that love is a shared, collective experience rather than an individual possession. Connection happens as a unit, not as a sole individual. When we can recognize this, it becomes not about you vs. the other person, but how the two of you can transcend a singular love. The connections we make are profound and define us as individuals, yet they always function as a unit. Our willingness to embrace loss for the greater good is meant to serve as an understanding that love always works out in the end, and that love is never really wasted.

SOULMATES AND TWINFLAMES AREN'T REAL (KIND OF): THE "ONE" IS THE ONE YOU END UP WITH.

As beautiful as the idea of "soulmate", "twin flames", and intense soul connections are, it's important to have the discernment to understand when this idea is actually serving you or holding you back. It's important to identify when this belief system can actually become problematic. Especially during a heartbreak, this idea of the "one" causes a lot of suffering. If your belief system is that you have one person "meant for you" and you're not with them, your entire reality will be focused on doom and catastrophization. It's important to note that the person who is the "one" or "your soulmate" is just the person you choose to make it work with, and the person you end up with. The narrative that you are half of something, or incomplete without another person, is self destructive and emotionally abusive. **The "one" is the one that chooses you back, and the one that you end up with.**

1. Intensity doesn't define romance. Passion isn't a good metric.

One of the main reasons we hold on to people is because of how intense the connection may be. It feels as if they were perfectly made for us, and the connection with them feels intensely romantic and passionate. As exhilarating as a connection like this is, it doesn't actually

speaking to romantic compatibility or safety. The body cannot differentiate between anxiety and attraction. This isn't to say that passion is bad, but rather, if passion is one of the reasons you're holding on, it may be beneficial to look into why that's the case. This is probably one of the hardest things to let go of (because we often only find passion/intensity in one context: romantic relationships).

2. Understanding is awesome, but how much time have you spent understanding yourself?

Another way we define soulmates is by our understanding of each other. Everything they say makes sense to you, and everything you say makes sense to them. There is an understanding that goes beyond words that transcends all other forms of communication. It just feels like you "get" them. As beautiful as being understood is, it more often points towards a neglect that we can find within ourselves. Perhaps our SP can see a part of ourselves we have hidden away, or they can contextualize actions we classified as "wrong", or they can accommodate for a perspective that we have always wanted to be true (but were never fully committed to). You have to be honest enough to recognize why you crave this understanding so deeply in the first place. Wanting to be understood isn't wrong, but to some degree, if we need it, it can cause us to suffer.

3. Similarity is connection, Familiarity is safety.

You know this person. It's almost as if you have been together before, that you've met each other previously, and it's almost fateful that you met this person. When you

hear about their story, you draw similarities to yours, and their being is kindred to yours. It's almost freaky how many similarities you have with them without having had to talk about it. This feeling can feel irreplaceable. It might feel like you may never meet someone like this ever again. But the truth is, a big part of this feeling is our willingness to feel it. We are a lot more similar than we let out to be. But on the surface, many of us are very different. When someone is familiar, it's because we are safe enough to reveal the deepest parts of ourselves.

4. Synchronicity/Compatibility

You think about the same things. You have the same ideas. The "coincidences" almost seem planned. It's a compatibility you believe is once in a lifetime. The odds of this seem almost impossible. It's almost as if you have been passing by each other your whole lives, only to finally meet. When you do, it's almost exact. They come into your life at the exact moment they need to. Not a second late, not a second early. It's important to realize what this framing or belief system actually entails (and how it is perceptual).

5. Growth/personal realization

You experience tremendous growth and learn extremely quickly once you meet them. It's as if you've discovered something new, but yet something so familiar.

If you've had to get over someone like this (or you're in the process of it) you're probably aware of how impossibly hard it may seem to untangle this connection. The belief

system often arises from the innermost core belief that this connection is sacred, that they are the (only) “one”, and that the two of you are *meant to be together*. As “beautiful” as this idea may seem, sometimes we use it as an excuse to hold on to someone who is already gone. You have to recognize that intensity, understanding, similarity, familiarity, synchronicity, and growth are actually all reflections of what you need to heal most within yourself.

If we are deeply attached to someone, it's because they have given us the permission to love ourselves the way that we want to be loved.

Rather than focusing on how “special” they are, it's important to recognize what it is that they are actually giving to us, or, more importantly, what we aren't giving to ourselves.

The most special thing about a “soulmate” is that they reflect back to us what we most need to be healed. Every flaw about them that triggers us is something within ourselves that needs to be healed. Every trauma that we receive from our separation is an indication of our own self abandonment (there is a LOT of nuance here, so use discernment at your own discretion).

When you realize you have multiple soulmates, and that the “one” is just the one you end up with, it becomes easier to take a particular “soulmate” as a lesson rather than a destination. Because the “one” is the one you end up with, you can never truly claim someone is your “soulmate” or the “one” till the very end. This means understanding the limited place someone may have in your life, and eventually letting go. Soulmates are real in the sense that they do exist, but the idea that there is “one” person for you isn't.

HEARTBREAK/ RELATIONSHIPS/LOVE IS ALL A MIRROR THAT CAN BREAK THE CYCLE

At one point, I had to realize that how I treated her, how I saw her, and how I spoke about her, was really how I was treating a part of myself, how I saw a part of myself, and how I spoke about myself.

I think the reason we fall in love with people is that there is a part of them that triggers something within us. Whether this is something we yearn for (our inner child) or something that we have discarded (our shadows), our feelings for another person will always tell us something about ourselves.

I met someone who was such a strong mirror that I realized, through loving them — how to love myself. Once you realize that what you like about them is really something you wish you didn't have to throw away, or that what triggers you is something you inherently have as well, it is no longer about them. This is the greatest realization and epiphany you can make from heartbreak, because it finally reveals to you what you have been looking for this whole time. Finding your soulmate, your "other half", and the person who completes you has always just been about looking in the mirror. Without sounding too spiritual and philosophical, it basically means, **often what we seek from others, we are truly depriving ourselves of.** Maybe this is an unconditional

acceptance of who we are, or maybe it's about sufficiency, or maybe even abandonment. The bottom line is that we think if we could convince someone else to love us, that we have beaten this form of emotional self abuse;

I.e. if someone just loved me back, I would finally be enough.

Not recognizing the core of it all which is our own decision of unworthiness. Rather than letting go of our own limiting beliefs, we chase after an external validation against it. This often leads us to more self betrayal, more heartbreak, and even a loss of ourselves.

If you have fallen deeply for someone else, pay attention to what this is saying about yourself. How you love them really is how you expect to be loved, and what you need most from yourself. Heartbreak is an agonizing experience because it often reveals to us our most painful patterns. Maybe after a heartbreak we choose to attack ourselves;

**I'm not lovable, anyway
I can't find love
I'm always meant to be broken.**

Making this realization is a good first step. But changing it is another thing. When you recognize the self attack, self abandonment, and self sabotage, it's easy to point to past experiences, other people, or external circumstances. Know that you are valid in doing so. But if you continue to do so, you are also choosing to remain the same.

To break out of your patterns, you need to imagine a version of yourself who can save you. Not someone else, not some knight in shining armor, but a version of yourself

who is able to decide enough is enough. You have to move forward. Yes, it's hard, and yes, it feels like it's impossible. You are not discounting or invalidating any of these feelings, but you're just choosing to move forward, anyway.

HOW YOU TREAT OTHERS (ESPECIALLY YOUR SP) IS HOW YOU TREAT YOURSELF.

A lot of people are unaware of this fact, but your brain actually processes emotions as a two-way street. **Andrea Miller** talks about this in her book, **“Radical Acceptance: The Secret to Happy, Lasting Love”**. When you are kind to another person, your lower brain (which processes hormones and pleasure) is unable to differentiate between the giver and the receiver and processes the experience as positive regardless. This is true for “negative” emotions as well. If you think back to a time you have shouted at a partner (or anyone, for that matter), you may realize how it actually caused your nervous system disarray as well.

When you recognize that how you treat other people (especially those closest to you) is how you treat yourself, you will recognize how important it is to let go with kindness. Part of the reason why heartbreak can hurt so much more (than it already does) is because people will end up “hating”^{*} their SP, which I’ve explained is the equivalent of hating some part of yourself.

***I should emphasize that during your healing process, it’s important to feel what you need to feel, and hating them is a completely valid and normal part of the process. I was referring to people who stay stuck in this stage and act out their emotions unhealthily.**

If you can let go of them with peace (eventually) and kindness, what you are really telling yourself is that it's okay to love again — for everyone involved. You can forgive the parts of yourself that fell in love with them.

There is a past version of you that loved everything that they are. This is always going to be a part of “you”. When you choose to attack your SP, or hurt them, you also hurt that part of you that you once were. Oftentimes, this energy is what causes people to go cold and close off their own hearts. They punish themselves for falling in love when loving was never the issue. **The only person you are really punishing if you choose to hate your SP is yourself.**

When you open yourself up to just loving them without attachment, to letting them go, you admit to yourself that it, in fact, was okay that you loved them, that you got hurt, and that you are okay with being human. As a result, you open yourself up to receiving love in another context. This is (to me) a huge step in really letting go and moving on. **Without being kind to yourself, you may never fully heal from a broken heart.** There will always be a part of you that is bitter, regretful, and resentful. Self compassion is the only weapon we have against this. The journey of healing and rediscovering yourself is not actually about them. Love is a continuous and dynamic force that evolves over time, regardless of what you want it to be. The reason why I heavily emphasize sending them off with love is because it's not really about them. It's about the part of yourself that still cares. When you choose to say goodbye to them with patience, you are really putting the part of yourself that is attached to them, to rest.

THE CYCLE OF PAIN IN THIS WORLD. THE REAL REASON WE DON'T HAVE ANY ENEMIES.

As long as we have enemies, someone to fight, pain will always cycle and repeat. Breakups are (unfortunately) such a powerful example of this. People are hurt, so they close themselves off, only to repeat the cycle and cause more of it. **Pain is like the ultimate pyramid scheme, promising love if you just close yourself off enough.** We convince ourselves that closing ourselves off is what it means to be resilient. This form of “self empowerment” is basically adopting pain as our “own” to enact some level of control over it. Holding onto the things that hurt us doesn’t give us control over it, we just end up perpetuating the thing that started us down that path to begin with.

The hardest thing you can ever do after you’ve been hurt is to let go, to forgive. Ironically, this choice isn’t actually about the person who hurt you, but rather yourself. Because forgiving them and moving on means healing, and healing means having a heart to be broken again. As long as you have enemies, you have an excuse to fight, to close your heart off, and to shut yourself off from the possibility of love.

It doesn’t take courage to become the very thing that destroyed you. It takes courage to be vulnerable, to let go of it, to transcend it, and to move past it. It’s terrifying to admit that there is so much pain in this world, and that

perhaps you were a victim of it. It's more terrifying to just lay down and accept that it's the status quo and that you can't do anything about it.

When we commit to having no enemies, this does not mean discarding our feelings. It doesn't mean that we no longer feel. Quite the opposite, in fact — it means we are accepting pain and letting it pass through us, never allowing it to destroy our ideals and values. It's saying **"The world will hurt me as much as it pleases, and I will still be me"**. It's the ultimate form of self empowerment and trust.

As long as you have an enemy to fight, you will always be on the side of pain. Whether you're dealing it, or receiving it, it is never ending and self destructive. If you want to find peace, you have to be willing to put your sword down. You have to be willing to stop fighting.

When you're vulnerable and authentic to who you are, you are taking on a huge burden. You are choosing to break the cycle. You're choosing to elevate yourself beyond the thing that hurt you. It's saying **"damn that sucked, but I'm not going to let that happen to myself or anyone else again"**. Don't embrace the pain as yours. Elevate yourself beyond it, let it go, and choose for it to not have a lasting place in your life.

AS YOU'RE HEALING, YOU NEED TO ASK YOURSELF:

Are you open to it being different?

Are you ready to let go of your pain?

Are you ready to accept that you deserve love?

Are you ready to stop chasing something that is not for you?

Can you start making things different?

Can you let go of your pain?

Can you accept that you deserve love?

Can you stop chasing something that is not for you?

Will you start making things different?

Will you let go of your pain?

Will you accept that you deserve love?

Will you stop chasing something that is not for you?

IF THEY WANTED TO, THEY WOULD(?)

As funny as this phrase has become, if you believe it to some degree, what you are essentially saying is that you are not willing to show up for yourself. We tell ourselves **“If they wanted to buy me flowers they would have”**, to which you can ask, did you buy yourself flowers the last time you wanted flowers? How many times have you wanted to do something, have something, or experience something only to stop yourself from fear, reasoning, or some other story that your mind came up with? *“but taking myself out on a date is uncomfortable”*. What happened to if they wanted to, they would? **Don’t you want to be loved, accepted and shown up for?**

There is nothing wrong with wanting your partner to love you, show you off, and show up for you. That is beautiful. But if you were showing up for yourself the way that you needed, then you wouldn’t be with someone who couldn’t show up for you in the first place. **If you wanted to, you would (right?)**. Well, not really, because we all have fears, anxieties, traumas, and other things holding us back from really loving ourselves (and others). Once we recognize this, and stop making it about the other person, we come into our power of loving ourselves and actually showing up for ourselves.

Be willing to show up for yourself, so that if someone else does not, you can decide whether you want them to be in your life or not. Give yourself the blessing of being loved by you.

If you wanted to, you would. It's time to stop waiting around, hoping, and praying that someone will fall out of the skies and save us, change our lives, heal our hearts and make us happy again. The person we've been waiting for has been here the whole time. We just have to finally accept it. That we are who we have been waiting for, and that even if the world abandons us, at the very least, we have to be willing to show up for ourselves.

WHAT IT MEANS TO LET GO:

I think letting go isn't just about letting go of the other person, that's only a small part of what the healing process is actually about. You have to be willing to let go of the stories you tell yourself, the character you think you are, and the belief systems that you have. You have to let go of the need to make it about everyone else, to make it about them, and to let go of self abandonment.

Regardless of who you are, everyone has a story they tell themselves. Whether it's that they always love more than the other person (this only happens because they believe that), or that they are just meant to be alone (if you believe this, you will create this). Healing is taking an honest audit of the belief systems that you have held onto this whole time. It is scary because you have never done it before. People think they're scared of falling in love, but that actually isn't the case. When people are so used to patterns, they are actually afraid of anything outside of that pattern. Speak out loud to yourself, *"I am lovable, and I deserve healthy, reciprocated love"*, and see what comes up. Are you in full agreement with that statement? Or are there parts of yourself that resist this statement? What comes up for you? Without judgment, view these parts of yourself and recognize that you have to let go of the stories you tell yourself.

If you convince yourself that love will never work out, you are **“taking control”** by assuming the worst will happen. On some level, if you believe everything will go wrong, then you don’t have to face the discomfort of uncertainty. It’s scary to admit that if you fall in love, it may work out, or it may not. Surrendering control means allowing whatever happens to happen, and holding yourself in the face of any outcome. Be willing to be scared, be willing to not understand it all, and figure it all out, anyway. Reassure yourself with your own presence. When you’re scared, or uncomfortable, really pay attention to which part of yourself is feeling this way. Why are you so scared? What assumption are you making due to/ because of this fear?

Maybe you’re scared of being broken, because, deep down, you believe you are inherently unlovable. But that fear is actually a comfort zone in a way because it allows you to know what happens. **What if you just found everything you were looking for? What if it did work out?** That’s what’s scary for most people, because they have conditioned themselves to be stuck in a certain cycle. Be willing to face this fear for the sake of yourself; stand up for that part of you that doesn’t believe, that was told by the world otherwise. Do it for them (the version of yourself). Do it for all the parts of yourself that believed they couldn’t. Heal beyond everything that has ever hurt you and be willing to be there for yourself, no matter what happens. No matter how you feel, irregardless of what others say — rally for yourself.

Not meant to be, and that's okay.

A Poem

I know you tried your best to keep me in your life
and I know I did too.

We really just weren't meant to be, and that's okay.

NOT MEANT TO BE, AND THAT'S OKAY - JUST ACCEPTING IT

Sometimes moving on is just accepting it. I think by this point in my healing journey; I was coming to terms with the fact that it was really over. That's part of healing. One day, the reality of what's in front of you becomes so undeniable that all you can do in the face of it — is accept it. The purpose of this piece was to reflect on the reality of the relationship. That both people can try their hardest, and it could still not work out; despite the greatest efforts and the best intentions, it can still unfold in an unwanted way. Accepting this is crucial to moving forward. Because as long as we try to argue about what we could have done differently, we will always find ourselves trapped in the past. The final line, "and that's okay" is me coming to terms with the acceptance of the situation. It's meant to embrace the uncertainties of relationships and to convey a sense of peace when you finally choose to embrace the outcome, even if it differs from what you wanted in the first place. By claiming to know the relationship wasn't meant to be, you indicate a sense of closure. It's quenching the lingering doubts and regrets, so that you can move forward. Instead of dwelling on what could have been or blaming a person, it becomes a choice to accept what has happened as a natural course of events. The piece is meant to imply a closure that is free from regret. By framing a conclusion with compassion and understanding, it allows us to carry the lessons we learn into our respective futures.

THE BEAUTY IN IMPERMANENCE.

The only truly permanent thing in this world is impermanence. Accept this, live this, and embrace it for its beauty. We can only cherish things because we know they won't truly last forever. **Our experiences are the memos we use to record the beauty of living.** Come to accept the transient quality of our connections, and that each passing moment is a gift, regardless of whether it's a "positive" or "negative" one.

Mark Manson wrote: "The desire for a more positive experience is itself a negative experience, and paradoxically, the acceptance of one's negative experience is itself a positive experience."

When examining this quote, you realize it's not just about experience, but can be applied to many things in life as well. Perhaps the idea of impermanence is the same. Maybe it's not about trying to find permanence but about accepting impermanence for all of its beauty. Losing someone is painful. You're not discounting this fact. You're accepting it. It's an admission that the pain you feel is a result of the depth to which you loved. It is accepting that heartbreak does suck. Love with another person doesn't last forever. Accept that, too. Because that's accepting it for its beauty.

Being in love isn't great because it's perfect (although it's portrayed that way sometimes). Being in love is one of the most fallible things we do as humans. It constantly fails. It constantly breaks people, yet we seem to always choose it. This is the greatest acceptance of a "negative" experience there is. It's permitting someone the opportunity to rip your heart out and stomp on it. Love will end one day. Whether it's an ending you expect, or even your so-called "happy ending". Accepting impermanence is the most positive thing you can experience. It's not being jaded because you are still choosing love, still choosing to be open. In the context of heartbreak, this means seeing their place in your life as something that provides you the opportunity to let go. Maybe they were never meant to last, anyway. **Who really is?** Accepting that being "in love" with them was impermanent all along is one of the most liberating and ironically loving things you could do.

Surrender.

A Poem

I hate that you're right.
I know in my heart that you're right.
But I'm just stubborn.
I hate that you're right about us.
That we aren't meant to be,
that we aren't supposed to end up together.

SURRENDER - AN ACCEPTANCE OF A DIFFICULT TRUTH.

The poem *Surrender* is meant to convey the struggle between personal feelings and the acknowledgement of a difficult truth. If someone we love claims we aren't meant to be, we struggle because some part of us wants them to be wrong or to be lying. Healing and moving on sometimes means choosing to accept this difficult truth for what it is. "I hate that you're right" is a conflicted statement. It expresses a hate for something that conflicts with your very own desires. Whenever we are faced with the end of a connection, we want it to be wrong. We so deeply need it to be. We are stubborn to accept the truth in front of us, even when we know it's true. Sometimes this means letting go of the part of ourselves that needs to prove them wrong. The line "you're right about us" is an agreement with their decision. An acknowledgement of our incompatibility and a surrender to the undeniable truth. This admission is one of the hardest things we can do when we heal. It's an honesty that doesn't want to be seen. The idea that we have to surrender to an outcome that goes against our own personal desires is one of the challenges we face when it comes to letting go. This complexity is an internal struggle we all know too well when it comes to saying goodbye.

WHY WISHING THEM A HAPPY ENDING IS WISHING YOURSELF A HAPPY ENDING

My ego was humbled. I realized it wasn't my story; it was yours. Letting you have your happy ending means liberating myself from being your ending as well. It's admitting to myself that I was wrong, and that there is something else better for me. Not better than you, but better for me.

Letting go is the greatest act of love you could ever perform. Not because you're choosing for the other person, but because for once, finally, you're also choosing yourself. You're walking away from something that is not meant for you, and admitting to yourself that you deserve something better for you.

Because that's really the hard part about letting go. It's letting go of your ego, your attachment, and that little voice in your head that says you are MEANT to be together. The part of you that is hurt that they didn't choose you back, and the part of you that is still suffering by holding on. Holding on is hurting yourself more, and should you continue to do so, you will continue to suffer. There is no urgency, no rule, or obligation to let go of them. Should you choose, you can hold on for as long as you want. Some people do.

But the question you have to ask yourself is: **How long will you continue to suffer and abandon yourself?** You don't have to let go of them, but you do have to love yourself. Once you decide to choose the latter, the former will come naturally. This is why, ironically, deciding that they, in fact, can be happy is also freeing yourself, because you admit that you are no longer holding onto the idea that you are their happy ending.

As long as we believe we are destined, fated, and meant to be with someone else, we will continue to suffer. We will curse the skies at the discrepancy between what we believe should be and what undeniably is. How aligned can you be with this statement?

**I was wrong, and they are not meant for me, anyway.
There is something else better for me.**

Does something come up for you? Are you resistant to such a statement? If so, why? Be open and honest with yourself about this. Maybe you believe they are your soulmate, your one and only, or maybe, on some level, you think they complete you as a person. There is an idea, a story, or belief system you are holding onto which is causing you to suffer. Choosing yourself means surrendering this story, letting go of the fairy tale in your head. It also means wishing them a happy ending. Because when you accept that you are no longer meant to play a role in their story, you can finally live yours.

THE ART OF GOODBYE, THE VALUES WE FORGET IN OUR FAREWELLS.

Dignity, Grace, Honor, these are values which will define how you go into your next experience with love. If you choose to end things with aggression and malice, you only wish yourself more pain. You attack a part of yourself, the part of you that loved them to begin with. Consciously ending a chapter means respecting that this person possesses a part of your heart, and saying goodbye is treating them with the kindness you yourself would need, because you do.

And obviously this is easier said than done. The reason I have written this isn't some instruction to be better because I am. It's a reminder to myself for all the times I've been worse, and there have been so many times.

Often, the person we hurt the most is actually ourselves. We care about another person so much that we attempt any desperate play we can to make everything like how it used to be. It's an illusion that gives us comfort in the moment — that we could go back. When in reality, it's already gone.

That's the tricky part of goodbyes. It often happens before we can even accept that it has happened. The challenge is in our ability to quickly shift, to quickly accept

that this is the situation that we're in, and that we could never go back. It's hard to remember sometimes, and even harder is remembering that saying goodbye with dignity means accepting that we can't go back. That saying goodbye with grace means allowing them to disappear from your life with acceptance. Remember that saying goodbye with honor means holding love for them as if you were grieving the loss of a loved one, because you are.

Choosing not to do this, however, is just discarding the part of yourself that cares. The part of yourself that's hurt. It is functioning from shame, telling yourself that you shouldn't feel love. This process, however, only hinders you in the future. Because if you choose to find love again, you will have to reclaim this part of yourself that you throw away. So rather than discarding, re-integrate, and release. This isn't forcing yourself to stop caring, but to say goodbye with grace with regards to the space they once held in your life.

Saying goodbye isn't really for them, because they're already gone. It's for yourself. It's allowing the hurt part of yourself to be hurt, and to be open when all you want to do is to be cold. This is the fear you have to overcome as you say farewell. You have to let go of the need to make it about them, and allow yourself to be broken, vulnerable. You might even have to let yourself "lose". Saying goodbye is the opposite of being a sore loser, it is being a graceful "loser" (I use this charged word to emphasize a point, use nuance to apply it to yourself. You are not actually a loser). Because it's accepting this isn't your battle, or your story to play out in the first place.

When we can remember this, we can say farewell the way we want to. Without creating a fuss or throwing a tantrum because things aren't going the way we wanted. It

201 | I love this version of myself that you brought out

is a peaceful act, a calm acceptance of what's in front of us,
without fussing over what's coming.

The Love ours could never be

A Poem

In the realm of love, not together we're found,
but rather love's truth, unbound.

We found our place.
I see now a love that's beyond compare,
not one that we will share.

A love you've built, with someone new,
a love so different, yet so true.

Yet, I find my peace.
This is love's journey, at ease.
Your heart found its rightful place.
With someone else, the right embrace.

Although bittersweet, I release all pain.
For in letting go, my heart finds its gain.
For the love ours was never meant to be,
I cherish the memories, and set you free.

THE LOVE OURS COULD NEVER BE - LETTING GO OF WHAT YOU WANTED

The love ours could never be is an exploration of love beyond a singular possession, acceptance, and letting go. The first stanza is meant to come to terms with the ending of the connection. That even though we may not be connected in the traditional sense, love itself is meant to be free. It's meant to be a departure from our conventional expectations of love that goes beyond the possessive idea that love is something we can own. The second stanza is about coming to terms with the fact that she has found love with someone else. A love that's "beyond compare" was my way of surrendering and implying that a love of the past could never hold a flame to a love that currently exists. The acknowledgment that we find our own individual places is to emphasize that love looks different for everyone. A happy ending for a person doesn't have to be a sad ending for someone else. The third stanza introduces a further acceptance of this fact. That although she has found a love in a different place and it's different, it's as valid as ever. The fourth stanza challenges the idea that this is a sad thing. We often think that someone we used to love finding love indicates some form of loss, when maybe it just means they have found a story meant for them. "This is love's journey, at ease" means finding peace at the end of something, even if their heart finds a rightful place elsewhere.

“With someone else, the right embrace.” Is the line that really brings home this point. Seeing someone you love fall in love with someone else is one of the more difficult truths to accept in this life. Yet, the final stanza seeks to release ourselves from this burden. That even among the difficult truths, we can free ourselves from pain and liberate everyone involved. There is a sense of closure that occurs when you set someone free. You embrace what it means to move forward, and the act of letting go becomes a source of gain for your own heart. To me, this act of saying goodbye with grace is how we truly heal and move on.

THAT POINT OF ACCEPTANCE

A Journal Entry

The happiest day of our (own) lives

I went to my friend's wedding today, and it just hit me that one day, I'll get on one knee for someone, and it won't be you. You'll walk down the aisle, and I won't be there waiting for you. I guess it just sucks for us because we taught each other the type of love we couldn't give to each other in the end. We didn't meet each other; we crashed into each other. When we shared our past chapters, I never imagined that one day, we too would become a tale of the past. So I'm guessing you realized it first, as usual, that our story is not meant to end "that" way. For me, I guess I realized you were the lesson I didn't want to be. Neither of us are the type to lose, so I know you're gonna cross that finish line one day, and I think you know that I'm finding my own way, too.

I think there comes a moment in every separation where you realize you are a stranger in someone else's story. You might have been the main character at one point, but you're now playing a different role in their story than the one you had imagined. Perhaps some part of you still has them as the main character in your story, but eventually you have to let go of who you expected them to be — to live the life that's meant for you.

Part of this is extremely painful. There is no denying that, but there is also solace that can be found in it. By recognizing someone isn't your ending, you can also admit to yourself that you are deserving of a different ending (maybe one you never even thought possible).

It's grounding and freeing, realizing that you no longer have to play the narrative that you once thought was yours. It's a type of acceptance that isn't happy or sad, but just is. It's saying:

"I see that you're finding your way and I am as well".

I called it the happiest day of our (own) lives because it's meant to capture the idea that we can all find what we're looking for in the end. When you say goodbye to someone you love, there is a bittersweet nature to the ending, because it signifies the beginning of a new story as well.

Can we just be happy now?

A Poem

I can't keep pretending like we hate each other,
but I can't believe that were just magically going
to be together again.

But I do know this:
I'm done.

I'm done trying to convince you to love me,
I just don't have it in me anymore.

I'm done being angry at you for
not choosing me back.

I guess I've finally accepted that
If I want to be happy,
I have to let you be too.

**So, can we just be happy
now?**

CAN WE JUST BE HAPPY NOW? – A RESIGNATION AND ACCEPTANCE OF FINALITY

Writing this poem was a plea to myself. A recognition that I could no longer abandon myself due to my own selfish need to be loved by another. The first stanza opens with the idea that, in separation, we often crave authenticity. Amongst all the hurt and negative feelings, what we truly want is to be truthful. That our reluctance to be authentic really reflects our own refusal to accept the separation. The second stanza is an exclamation, a commitment to a resignation and an effort to no longer contribute to the unproductive patterns we so often have in heartbreak. The third stanza is an acknowledgement of how it feels during separation sometimes. That there comes a point where you realize how futile your efforts have been. **You realize that you could never love someone into loving you back.** It signals towards the idea that you can never really love without including yourself. The fourth stanza is an act of surrender. It's a conscious decision to put down the sword and stop fighting for something that doesn't want to be fought for to begin with. We're always angry that love doesn't work out, but why? This resentment only holds us back, and if we truly wish to be liberated, we have to let go of it. The fifth stanza is an acceptance of mutual happiness. Letting someone else be happy is a willingness to let yourself be as well. Holding

onto a specific outcome only holds you back from finding the happiness that you, too, deserve. The final stanza is a final plea to myself to really find closure and transition from the pain. It's an invitation to myself to move forward, whether separately or together with the other person. The piece is an expression of what it feels like to be stuck in heartbreak and what you have to do to finally choose liberation.

RELINQUISH THE ILLUSION OF BECOMING - HOW TO BE(COME) ENOUGH

How can you become enough?

You can't.

That's not meant to discourage you. It's meant to say that you already are.

Imagine for a second, that you are building a puzzle:

You have all the pieces you need, but you look over at someone else's puzzle, and try to help them out by putting in your own pieces, and throwing away your other pieces. You and the other person try to complete the puzzle together, but are unable to ever create the final product together. This is how many of us believe love works. We think that if we throw away enough of ourselves, or share enough pieces of ourselves, we will magically create a finished puzzle with someone else.

With you, it's the same. You can't become enough because you already are.

The reason you feel incomplete isn't because you lost someone who completes you. No one can complete you, at least not in the way that you think.

Another person may help you rediscover the parts of yourself you have discarded, but even then, they do not complete you; they complete(d) you.

You can never complete someone else either. You can only hold the space for them to recognize that they already are complete. If you have a tendency/need to try to save others, it is important you recognize this. You will always toss away parts of yourself, thinking that if you just give enough, they would feel complete. **But the pieces of you will never satisfy the parts of themselves they have thrown away.**

When you recognize that you have no need to become, you just have to walk backwards and pick up some pieces you left behind — you recognize that everything outside of yourself is merely a reflection of your own internal puzzle.

You need a relationship? What has the relationship with yourself been like?

You require everything to be in control? What is the relationship with your deepest shadows?

The external is only a sign of what we need to examine inward. It is the greatest mirror to ever exist. So if you think you need to become enough, it is a sign that you need to look inward. To reclaim the parts of yourself you have discarded.

Each time you read a book trying to be enough, or take a “self improvement journey” you essentially tell yourself

you aren't enough to begin with. You don't need any books, you don't need to be fixed. All you have to do is remember that you already are enough.

**There is nuance here, as books, therapy, and coaching are all helpful tools to help you heal better, however the intention behind them is important. It's how you approach the healing and the belief system behind it.*

BE WILLING TO SHOW UP FOR YOURSELF THE WAY YOU EXPECT OTHERS TO.

When people are deeply hurt, they often try to fix others, heal others, and show up in a way that neglects their own inner child. Think about this analogy for a second.

Some (many) people have a bad relationship with their parents, but sometimes there's a weird phenomenon that occurs where their parents are the "nicest" most "perfect" people to their friends, and seemingly everyone else, but it doesn't feel that way with them.

The parents abandon their own kids' wellbeing by extending themselves to others. If you take an honest audit, you've been doing the exact same thing. By trying to love everyone else and give it your all, you have simultaneously abandoned your own child. **By helping others, you have forgotten about your own needs.** There is nothing wrong with helping others, or loving others, but when it comes at the expense of yourself, it is no longer healthy.

No one in this world is worth abandoning yourself for.

Rather than seeking this love from another person, show up for yourself. Stop trying to expect others to love you the way you love. At the very least, love yourself that way. Maybe you spend hours listening to other people's problems.

How long have you spent journaling and listening to your own thoughts and problems with love? Maybe you love making gifts for others. How much time and investment have you put into giving yourself those gifts? Maybe you love to do things for other people, trying out experiences and doing acts of service for them. How many times have you done that for yourself?

If you're being honest with yourself, you will recognize that you have been abandoning yourself in the hopes that if you abandon yourself enough, maybe someone will recognize it, and love you for it. This is emotional self abuse. Wanting to be loved is not wrong; it's human, but abandoning yourself to be loved is unacceptable. At the very least, show up, love, and care for yourself the way you wish someone else could. If you think **"I wish I had someone like me in my life"** or **"I wish someone could be as kind as me"** that is your inner child SCREAMING at you, to show up, to love yourself on a deeper level, and to be everything they need you to be. It's not about making someone else love you, but rather, just recognizing that you already are lovable (because you are — sit with this).

WHAT WE GET WRONG ABOUT LOVE, AND HOW IT'S ACTUALLY THE OPPOSITE.

I think we often think that love is some magical thing that keeps us tied to someone that we could never live without. But this is not love; in fact, it is attachment. Obviously, and realistically, it's almost impossible to be in love with someone whilst simultaneously being unattached, so we often create an association between these two things. However, correlation is not causation. Just because you love someone deeply, and you're attached to them deeply, does not mean that love is attachment itself.

Love isn't something that can hurt you. Only attachment can. Pay close attention to how you feel about your heartbreak. What you may come to realize is that the part that hurts is the fact that what you want is different from what is or what will be. It is your attachment to the outcome that is painful.

To me, when you truly love someone, you never stop. But you can detach from them. This is the ultimate gift you give yourself and to them as well. Once you loosen your grip on them, you either discover how deep your love is or whether it was only your attachment to them to begin with. Love is free, it's not something we need from others. It's all around us.

This is an opportunity to truly explore your heart and your care for another person. Did you just love them because you were together? Or was there something that goes deeper?

Do you appreciate who they are, regardless of who you are to them? As sad as this statement may be, most people don't truly find love until they lose someone. Because love is unattachment, and we can normally only detach once the connection has "ended". But when you are truly detached, this is where you can explore your heart and yourself, on a much deeper level.

Permit yourself to explore the depths of your heart, the depths of your attachment, and, when you're ready, the grace of setting them free. As long as you're trapped in the idea of needing them to be something outside of what they are, it is your attachment, not your love.

Sometimes loving someone means loving all that they are, even if that is someone who doesn't love you back. It's accepting everything they are, including the fact that they may not feel the same. It goes beyond your needs and is an appreciation beyond who they are to you, but rather just who they are. Understand that love isn't about how attached you are to someone, it isn't about needing someone so much that you can't live without them. This is a lie we have told ourselves to strengthen our own insecurities. Once you can recognize that love is never about owning another person or being attached to them in the first place, letting go and moving on is no longer framed as giving up or losing. In fact, it's the opposite. It's an act of love, an act of surrender, and the final stage of acceptance.

Let go because you love them, not because you don't. Say goodbye because they're already gone. Love is unattachment in its purest form; it's the opportunity to open ourselves up to everything in front of us, rather than tie ourselves back to everything that used to be. Love doesn't keep you attached to someone, it's the thing that will set you free.

HOW TO STOP MISSING THEM

Long story short, you don't. It's important to ask yourself what story you're telling yourself that requires you to stop missing them to begin with.

Do a brief thought experiment with me. If you have ever lost a loved one, how do you react when you see something that reminds you of them?

Do you beat yourself up for caring and still feeling, even in their absence?

or, are you kind and compassionate, understanding that the fact you can remember their presence even in their absence is actually a beautiful thing?

Treat your heartbreak as if you were grieving the loss of a loved one. Because you are.

Realize that grief is only your love persevering, and it's testament to how lasting and how beautiful love can be. When you miss someone, the part that "hurts" is the parts of yourself closing off, refusing your love for them. When you have dealt with death before, you will realize you never really "forget" the person. You just learn how to build a life in their

absence. You don't stop caring, but you learn to live in honor of the life they once lived.

When you catch yourself missing your SP, be gentle, patient, and kind. Because you are experiencing the grief of someone who held a tremendous space in your life. Your mind can't make sense of it because they are still "out there" living. But this is a completely different person from the person you were in love with.

If you really want to "stop missing them", allow yourself to. It's such an ironic truth because once you allow yourself to miss them is when you really don't miss them anymore because you have accepted their absence.

If you have healed before, you know there will come a time where you may actually miss missing them. Cherish it, hold it, and be with it. **It's your love to begin with.** Don't beat yourself up for loving. When you're ready, and accept that they are gone, missing them becomes a passing thought, something that can make you smile during a busy day.

I'm going to stop fighting.

A Poem

Not that I'm giving up on love,
or that I'm becoming jaded,
but I'm coming to realize what
our love isn't.

I realized that he's better than me.
Not because he's better than me,
but because he's better for you.

and that's more important. I realized,
that's something I could never fight against.

I'M GOING TO STOP FIGHTING - CEASING THE STRUGGLE

"I'm going to stop fighting" is a challenge or play on the idea that love is something you should fight for. We so often say that if you love someone, you should fight for them and that moving on is giving up. I disagree with this sentiment, as sometimes love just isn't meant to be. Choosing to put the sword down is a conscious action to relinquish the struggle with letting go of love. Fighting for a love that's over isn't romantic; it's hurtful and self abusive. Realizing so isn't being jaded; it's coming to terms with the truth in front of you. The second stanza further emphasizes the surrender by embracing the idea that their new partner is more suited for them. It's a recognition of the limitations my love has for them. It's a claim of self awareness that my SP's happiness is more important than my need to hold on to them. Because when you fight against this, you are really objecting to your SP's happiness. Surrendering to this isn't being jaded; it's to suggest that despite your personal desires, certain aspects of love are beyond your control. **Sometimes love isn't something you fight for; sometimes love is something you let go of.** The conscious decision to stop fighting signifies an act of emotional liberation. A willingness to detach from a situation that has caused you so much internal conflict.

DEC 30, 2021 -MY LAST JOURNAL ENTRY TO YOU

A Journal Entry

I think this may be my last journal entry to you :) This has been a crazy year, and I'm finishing up my final assignment that my coach gave me. I think im really, finally, complete in this experience :)

Spoilers: I was not complete in the experience. But I think that's why this is important to share. It was, in fact, my last journal entry addressed to her, but I was not done with my healing. What I learned, however, is that healing is not an outcome, it's a process. One that requires reiteration, rebirth, and constant repetition.

It's never about "just getting over it". It's about getting over it again, and again, falling down and getting back up. **Healing is never about finishing, it's about choosing to continue.** For someone you've attached very deeply to, you may need to do this a countless amount of times. The number itself is unimportant. What is important, however, is that you choose to move forward, regardless. It is important to note, however, that if you find yourself trapped in a pattern for a long time, perhaps something is not working and you need something beyond yourself to break free. I truly do believe that letting go should have no due

date, however, seeking help from others only makes it easier, and if you care for yourself, you may benefit from asking why you would want it to be harder. A big part of the reason I have struggled with letting go is of my own admission due to my inability to ask for help. But around this journal entry is when I began to work with a coach and things really started to shift for me.

If there is shame around holding on, or letting go, asking for help becomes a burden, a detriment. You only find it harder to ask for help. This is why speaking to a professional should always be considered (with nuance, you have to find the right person). But if there's one thing to take away, it's that healing should be a continuous process, not something you achieve, and then you're done with it.

Healing isn't linear.

Different paths

A Poem

We grew apart in different directions
so now we both know in our hearts
that we are on different paths.
Some part of me wonders
if maybe we went through that growth together,
whether we would have continued on the path forward
together.

DIFFERENT PATHS - ACKNOWLEDGEMENT OF DOUBT IN THE FACE OF SEPARATION

Different paths is a contemplation of divergence that we so often face when it comes to love, heartbreak, and separation. Because just because you accept something is over doesn't mean you don't wonder. As you're healing and moving on, you might find that you do, in fact, still wonder what could have been different. Sometimes the end of a connection sets you and the other person on different paths. You just grow in different directions, outgrowing each other as a result. There is an organic element to this separation, or divergence. The line "we both know in our hearts that we are on different paths" implies that there is a mutual understanding in separation. That you share a recognition that you have both evolved in different directions. Yet, there may still exist a part of you that is curious, maybe even regretful. What if you had grown together rather than apart? "Some part of me wonders" is an address to this lingering speculation, the part of ourselves that wants to go back. Moving on and healing isn't perfect, and looking back is expected. But the important part is to acknowledge this doubt and still choose to move forward. The idea of this contemplation is a juxtaposition of unity and separation. That even amidst separation, you may sometimes feel yourself connected to the other person. The poem is left open-ended, without providing an answer

to the question. The ambiguity is provided so the reader can decide whether they will choose to move forward in spite of the doubt and nostalgia. This contemplation of “what if?” is always something we go through during heartbreak. We often contemplate the crossroads and pivotal moments of our heartbreaks, yet we are still provided with the choice to move forward. Diverging from a deep connection is complex, and will involve doubts and contemplations of what may have been if things were different. The idea of this piece is to acknowledge that doubt, and make the choice to move forward, anyway.

What I'd do for love

A Poem

I'd do anything for us
including letting go of you.

WHAT I'D DO FOR LOVE - WHAT WE CAN CHOOSE

“What I’d do for love” is a commentary on the willingness to sacrifice for a love greater than yourself. It’s a commitment to the idea that love isn’t something we actually possess, but something beyond our own individual conceptions. The use of “anything for us” indicates that every connection is actually a team effort. A unit with a shared purpose, even if that purpose may supersede the needs of an individual. It’s an acknowledgement, that in certain situations, the best course of action is to let go. The willingness to let go of something beyond yourself is an act of surrender. It’s choosing to believe that love is more than something we hold on to and that sometimes the greatest acts of love involve making choices for the greater good (of everyone involved). The idea of the poem is to challenge the boundaries and limits we so often put in the name of love. It asks ourselves when we should hold on, when to let go, and what it truly means to prioritize love. There is a duality — an expression of love that recognizes a need for separation. We often only think of love in the context of falling in (love) but never falling out (of love). Sometimes the choice is in your ability to say goodbye and let go of something you want with every ounce of your being to hold onto.

This ones for you

A Poem

If you couldn't love me at my best,
then there's nothing I could do to make you love me.

I understand that now fully,
and wish you the best in your journey in life.
Our journeys are just beginning, but ill always
remember the time we ran side by side.

THIS ONE'S FOR YOU - WISHING THEM WELL IN SEPARATION

The opening line of this poem, "If you couldn't love me at my best" is an acknowledgement of the futility of trying to convince someone to love you. It acknowledges the discrepancy or mismatch in their ability to reciprocate love. Once you can come to this understanding, you can really wish them the best. Because they are no longer someone you seek to end up with. The poem is meant to suggest a sense of clarity that comes at some point during your healing journey. That eventually you come to understand that you just aren't meant to be. It marks a point of personal growth and acceptance that goes beyond what you used to wish for. "Our journeys are just beginning" is a recognition that life goes on. That despite this chapter ending, we are all embarking on new stories. The concluding line, "but I'll always remember the time we ran side by side" introduces an element of nostalgia. Sometimes we look back fondly, and despite the separation, we will cherish memories of a love that once was. The poem is meant to be reflective and contemplative. It's meant to be a representation of the peace we can feel saying goodbye, but also to hold space for any slightly bittersweet feelings we may have as well.

HOLDING SPACE IN FAREWELL. HOW TO ALLOW YOURSELF TO FEEL WHEN SAYING GOODBYE.

Holding space for yourself during heartbreak means allowing the parts of yourself to feel what they need to feel. Not judging yourself, but allowing yourself. If there is a part of yourself that hates your ex (SP), perhaps it just needs permission to be seen and to be validated in its pain. **Do not deny yourself the opportunity to be human.**

Validate your feelings, but not your thoughts. Every feeling comes with a story. If you hate your ex, maybe it's because they are ... and they did ... to you. But all of this is your mind trying to rationalize your feelings. Just allow yourself to feel. Allow it to be without attaching a story to it. Allow it to flow through you and just be. **This is the ultimate gift of heartbreak; the opportunity to feel and to let go.**

If you feel broken, then let yourself be. Hold yourself in this and don't judge yourself for it. There is something to be found in these feelings. This isn't easy, and we often feel shame around feeling certain ways about certain things. Especially heartbreak. Whether it's shame around still being hurt, or being hurt in the first place, we often feel on multiple levels, i.e., *we feel a certain way about how we feel*. Instead of; *just feeling how we feel*. Emotions are like any other form of energy, they are not meant to be static; they

are transient. They are meant to flow, but we put blockages on them, because of how we feel about them (our feelings about our feelings).

A common example is feeling shame about feeling heartbreak. Maybe we think it's been too long or that there isn't really a reason to be hurt anymore. But this appraisal of our own feelings is ridiculous. Because if you are still heartbroken, it means that you are. But if you would like to move forward from it, you have to accept it with love. **You cannot shame yourself into becoming a better, more healed person.**

You may need to know your heart deeper, you may need to meet the depths of yourself. Meet these parts of yourself with love and accept them unconditionally. The person who needs this the most, is you. That's what holding space is all about. It's about feeling on the first level. Freeing yourself from the shame that normally comes with feeling and removing the burden you have for being human. Ironically, the moment you stop judging your feelings you have for a SP is when you truly start moving on. When it doesn't matter that you miss them, or that they cross your mind, this is when you can truly move on, because it's no longer about them.

Goodbyes, contrary to what most people believe, are never about erasing a person's existence. Because at one point in time, this person was a part of you. Erasing them is equivalent to erasing a part of yourself. Holding space in farewell means understanding that **goodbyes aren't about forgetting; they're about creating a space in their absence.** When you allow them to be absent in your life, you accept what comes along with it. Whether it's pain, heartbreak, or a deep yearning for their presence, you welcome this experience

with open arms, because you accept that it's only human. This is what it means to allow yourself to feel.

This isn't some argument towards wallowing in your pain; continuing to miss them and cry about them forever, as a necessary part of saying goodbye, is letting go itself. The point is that sometimes we can't really get to this point till we accept that they are gone. As you start to allow yourself to feel and open your heart again, notice your willingness (or resistance) to these feelings. What does letting go of them really mean? Are you looking forward to what's next? Or are you scared of what's to come?

Saying goodbye (especially to someone who meant so much to us) is scary for this reason. It's accepting that they are, in fact, gone — and feeling what comes with that. Then grieving the future we had imagined with them in it. It's saying goodbye to a version of ourselves we had hoped to become and welcoming a version of ourselves we may not be ready to meet.

Open yourself up to this, all of it. That's how you feel when you're saying goodbye. That's how you move forward. It's never about forgetting, it's about moving forward in spite of what's happened. It's not denial, it's rebellion, an act of defiance, choosing to move forward when everything is telling you that this is the end.

I CAN FINALLY UNDERSTAND FINALES.

An unsent message

Because although our story is over, we're both gonna keep moving forward. Although the story ends, the characters keep moving forward, living their lives, but we as the viewer are no longer privy to their story any longer. I've come to accept that I'm no longer a character in your life, but rather a viewer, and just because our story ends here, doesn't mean either of us will stop moving forward. I used to think that finales were endings, and I hate endings. but I've come to learn that it's just the beginning.

"I can finally understand finales" was a piece I wrote about coming to terms with closure and moving on. I hate the ending of stories. For a long time, this was a big struggle of mine. Because once the story was over, that was it. But what I failed to realize is that more happens beyond what we can see. In a separation, both individuals are protagonists in their own narratives. Sometimes our stories with others end because we are no longer meant to be a character in their lives. This shift was a signifying a transition and a shift in the dynamics of that connection with this person. The emphasis that, although one particular story may be over, we each continue (individually) is a positive and optimistic assertion. That this ending isn't really an ending. The final line is a shift in my thinking where I recognize this fact. It's an

acceptance that something is over, but life will go on. We will continue to persist through life as individuals and experience more of our own highs and lows. The piece is a hopeful address to closure. That you can accept the end of something and still be hopeful of what's to come.

THE HARD PART OF HEARTBREAK

An unsent message

I think the hard part isn't reaching out. Because that's what you said to me, right? That some texts are better left unsent, some I miss you's unheard, and that some things are better left unshared. I think the heartbreaking part isn't the sad moments, or the lonely moments, either. It's when you're happy living your own life, without a thought in the world of each other, and then it hits, the full weight of what once was, is now merely a ghost, a memory, or an echo of something that once defined everything you are. The scary part of love is realizing that it can end one day. Because for a moment, you remember how great it was, how happy it made you. You smile, and then you let it go. Maybe it was a smile, a scent, or a soft giggle. Something brings you back, just for a moment. And I think it's in these moments we are reminded of how powerful love truly is, that something so absent, and so distant, could have such an imprint on who we are. And so, we find ourselves in the bittersweet realization that we no longer where we once used to be. It's a constant reminder that saying goodbye is never about forgetting, but choosing to move forward even when we do remember. But that's the duality of love, and of life. That we have to be willing to accept that things may end, for it to begin. You can only find love again if you open yourself up to the fact it may end again one day.

WHAT “GETTING” OVER SOMEONE MEANS (TO ME)

I truly believe in the sentiment of “killing them with love” or loving someone so much that you get over them. To me, this means holding so much love and space for them that you are no longer attached to them. It’s loving them so much that you realize that loving them without them loving you back just doesn’t make sense. It’s accepting them beyond what they are to you and accepting them for their **existence**. Whether their existence is in a way that your mind wants or in a way that you don’t want, you accept them for all that they are.

It’s loving someone more than just how they make you feel, or their proximity to you, but rather just their whole existence. There may be some parts of yourself that will always “want” them on some level. The part about this that hurts is your attachment to the story behind it. You judge yourself for feeling as if you weren’t allowed to feel for someone you’ve lost. Why can’t you just let yourself be? Do you feel pathetic? **Let yourself**. You feel wronged and broken? **Let yourself**. This is the ultimate form of freedom. When you finally stop fighting against what is and just love yourself for who you are.

This might mean missing them at times, or even having them cross your mind. Be patient with this, allow it to be and don’t judge yourself for it. Rather, watch your mind

and understand that you, in fact, did care about this person a lot, and that this isn't something to be ashamed of.

Because when you choose this, you will eventually realize that you are actually choosing yourself in the long run. **That you don't need to get over them; you just will.** Because loving someone without loving yourself is not actually possible. This is the ironic realization of "getting over them": it's choosing love, and then realizing that to truly choose love, you have to let go of them in the end.

You can never shame yourself into healing, moving on or "getting over them". You can only love yourself into this.

This is a process. It will take multiple attempts, and you may inevitably go back to what was comfortable. But each time you learn something new, and you accept that although you may have "failed" in your mind, **the only failures are the ones we choose not to move on from.** When you choose to move on, no matter what, you are telling yourself that you are worth healing. Getting over someone is really just getting back into choosing ourselves.

FINDING YOUR CANON EVENT TO GET OVER THEM

One of the most important things during a heartbreak is experiencing “that” event that finalizes the ending of the experience. The thing that finally makes you understand that it is, in fact, truly over. This doesn’t necessarily mean it needs to involve them, but there always is a moment that allows you to “move on”. It doesn’t come from “doing” anything, but rather is a result of making a conscious decision to commit to moving on.

The reason why most people don’t move on is because, on some deep level, there is a reason for them holding on. Until you can recognize you are holding on (and allowing yourself), it will be very challenging to commit to moving on (because you don’t actually want to). This realization that you actually want to hold on may occur when you randomly run into them and their new partner, or when you finally realize you no longer want to keep yourself suffering.

To truly move on and let go of them, you have to allow yourself to do so. **Do not force your heart, but create space for yourself to move on when you are ready.** When you close off your heart, you tell yourself that you are not permitted to be human and that somehow you should be punished for loving and trusting someone. Do not punish

yourself as a reaction to someone else's actions.

When I first went through my heartbreak, I would constantly avoid certain places to avoid running into my SP. I was scared. If I'm reflecting honestly, it probably would have just broken me more to see her again. But as I healed more, I still found myself avoiding places where I might find her. I had entire places and activities ruined by happy memories and imagined futures. This just isn't fair. I realized that eventually I had to reclaim some of these places to really move forward. I started going back to these places, and as uncomfortable as it was, it was necessary for me to heal.

Eventually, I ran into her and her boyfriend. Time stopped. My heart fluttered, like it was the first day of being broken all over again (I literally wanted to throw up). But I held space for myself through the experience and allowed myself to just be. Once I got through it, I accepted things for how they were. The situation I had been running from all this time was actually the thing I needed to finally move on. I thought seeing her happy with someone else would kill me, but instead, it was the only thing that could really help me move forward. Was it pleasant? No. I felt like I was dying. But some part of me had to die, for me to move forward.

Allowing space for yourself means that during your healing journey, you will have to grieve parts of yourself and allow yourself to transmute parts of yourself. Trusting the process meant allowing myself to be a mess when I ran into her and allowing myself to be broken. Holding myself in all of that raw vulnerability and accepting it. This was an unavoidable step to truly heal and move forward.

The lesson learned here is that certain things, although uncomfortable and at times even anxiety inducing (there is a lot of nuance here) may be necessary for you to

move forward. This was my “canon event” the thing that finally allowed me to realize that I was in fact still allowing myself to hold on. Our default setting is homeostasis; staying the same. So when we find ourselves in heartbreak and it becomes our default, breaking out of that becomes uncomfortable too. Remind yourself that it will be uncomfortable, and that’s part of the process.

Train yourself to move forward, regardless. Don’t deny yourself the experience, but don’t dwell on it either. You have to move forward for the sake of yourself. Healing is a continuous process of taking a step forward and hesitating to take the next step out of fear or discomfort. Trust that this is part of the process, and take a step anyway.

Memories. Just that.

A Poem

I think I'll always hold a special place in my heart for us,
but, I've come to understand them for what they are:

Memories.

I don't wanna stomp on what was sacred, so

I'll leave those memories as they are.

I won't let any of the love go wasted and carry these lessons
forward.

MEMORIES. JUST THAT - A CONTEMPLATION OF WHAT ONCE WAS.

Sometimes moving on means reflecting on what once was. Even if that means remembering a part of ourselves, many of us try to forget. The opening line acknowledges that looking back will often be nostalgic, and each relationship has a unique mark on your heart. The line's "but I've come to understand them for what they are: memories" is the shift in perspective that often occurs during healing. Because at one point, the memories were everything to you. They're the reason you hold on, and the reason you can't move forward. But when you recognize they are just that — fragments of the past — you realize that holding onto them isn't really honoring them for what they are. The line "I don't wanna stomp on what was sacred" illustrates the desire to preserve the sanctity of memories and to leave them as such. It's a respectful acknowledgment of the significance a certain connection held at the time. The choice to "leave those memories as they are" is a decision to not alter or distort the memories (as we often do in separation). It's an act of preservation, allowing them to exist as moments frozen in time. Yet the final line is a commitment to "not let any of the love go wasted" by moving forward with honor and acceptance. Its intention is to suggest that we have the choice to carry forward the positive aspects of a relationship.

The poem is meant to encapsulate a sense of respect for the past, complemented by the honor of moving forward. It's acknowledging the role a connection may have played without dwelling on it. The balance between these two things is often the nuance we need to find closure and move forward.

ENDINGS ARE ACTUALLY BEGINNINGS. IF YOU LET THEM BE.

Every ending is truly a new beginning. An ending is just another opportunity to start again. To me, having three heartbreaks means having four opportunities to love. You can only recognize this if you stop defining love in terms of its outcome. Be willing to start over, to be at rock bottom, but to keep on moving. This is what it means to let endings be beginnings. This isn't the end. This is where it really starts.

You tell yourself *"it was a failure, I loved this much, and did this much and it still didn't work out"* but maybe the point isn't for it to "work out" but to love to begin with. there's the age-old adage that says:

"It is better to have loved and lost, than to have never loved in the first place" -Arthur Henry Hallum

In fact, the part that hurts during heartbreak is your inability to permit yourself to love in the first place. Your mind, ego or some part of you disagrees with your love. As a result, you close your heart off from love. This is what truly creates suffering.

Stop defining your infinite love through a small human experience. You, your love, and everything that you are is so much greater than that. Whether your love lasted

a year, a month or even a day, you always have the choice to embrace it for what it was. If any person in this world can find love, **that is a gift.**

When you no longer need to be in love, you can realize that any experience of it is the point it. Its ending is only an opportunity to open yourself up again. What would it look like if we measured ourselves with how deep we could love? How open we could make our hearts regardless of our external outcomes? What if loving was the point of it all? Loving life, loving people, and being open is just being human.

Your love is a gift. You have every right to take it from the world, but just know that the only person who will suffer is you. The only person you betray is yourself. The only person you withdraw from is yourself. **No person in this world can ever take away your ability to love.** When you realize you can't love someone into loving you back, you realize it's not about the other person. It's about how deeply you can open yourself up to it, irregardless of what happens. This is the power of your heart and what you can truly accomplish if you love. Your ability to love was never contingent upon their presence; it was always within you. Their absence doesn't magically remove that part of yourself. **Something ending isn't a result that can take away your love; only you have the ability to do that.** It's only once we stop aiming our attacks back at ourselves that we can recognize this. A relationship ending isn't an argument to care less, but an opportunity to come back into ourselves. Finding peace in the ending of something is how we develop forward momentum. Endings are beginnings, if you let them be. You can never choose to go back, but you can choose to keep going.

Endings are beginnings?

A Poem

Because it may be where our story ends,
but it's also where each of our own begins.

This isn't an ending.
It's a beginning.

Because if there's anything I know about you,
It's that you always win in the end.

So when we cross the finish line one day,
I hope we can look back fondly,
and remember that we both got to play
a role in each other's stories.

ENDINGS ARE BEGINNINGS - A CONSIDERATION OF A DIFFERENT PERSPECTIVE

I titled the poem with a question mark as a deliberate consideration. Maybe it's important for us to question our beliefs about certain stories. That sometimes what we may believe to be the end, is really the start of something new. I illustrate the idea of this duality in the first stanza, that although your connection with another may be coming to an end, it's where each individual's story really begins. The second stanza seeks to reframe the traditional notion of the end of a connection. Instead of viewing it solely as a conclusion, we can see it as the start of something new. The stanza "if there's anything I know about you, it's that you always win in the end" is meant to honor the character she once played in my story. She is the type of person who always picks herself back up. To me, this was inspiring and something I really learned from. I learned through witnessing her that we all have the opportunity to win in the end, and pick ourselves back up in the process. The final stanza is a metaphor that represents our idealized version of a "happy ending". That we often define some sort of happy ending when it comes to a connection. Yet, it acknowledges that the connection that we once shared no longer exists. "So when we cross the finish line one day" conveys a sense of acceptance that we aren't meant to find a happy ending together,

but that we can (hopefully) look back with fondness and appreciation. The “finish line” is symbolic. It’s a moment of achievement and completion that we all seek in our lives, and in the context of love, it’s often our “happy ending”. By associating it with looking back and remembering, its intention is to highlight that we are currently on a journey, and that it’s all part of the process. It’s a shift towards a separation being a transition rather than a definite conclusion. It’s a precursor to each individual journey, with an emphasis that there is more for us to look forward to.

HOW TO MOVE ON IF THEY'RE HAPPY WITH SOMEONE ELSE AND YOU'RE STILL HOLDING ON.

I do think that no piece of information is universal, and everyone should discern whether something will serve them. In this particular case, I think it's very relevant, so discern whether this is right for you.

If they're happy with someone else/moved on, you may be stuck suffering. But if you love them so much, why does it hurt so badly? Don't we want the ones we love to be happy?

If you take an honest audit, it's because a part of you is still hoping for some future together. You cannot believe that this is the life you are meant to live (without them). It feels weird to suffer seeing someone you love so much be happy.

Some people say letting go doesn't mean it can't work out later. But I personally disagree (this is not for everyone!), I think it's a really beautiful perspective, but personally I could never heal if I'm wishing for some future. I cannot believe in the right person, wrong time, because I would wait till the end of time just for the right time. Even if there's a 1 in a billion chance of something, I would gratefully wait it out, and I would gamble the rest of my life away just for another chance (and if you're like this, because not everyone

is, then this message is important for you).

The reason it hurts is that they're living a life you want so badly (or so you believe). Part of healing and finally moving on is surrender. Acceptance. That the door is closed for good. You do this by finally accepting that you are not their happy ending, but they still deserve one. Be patient with yourself, because you're letting go of a future version of yourself as well. You have to accept that they aren't the right person wrong time, they're the wrong person at the right time. You had to meet them for a reason. Even if you can't see that reason now, you will understand it one day.

Remind yourself that letting go is the greatest act of love you could ever perform. One day you're going to meet someone who's gonna help you understand why it didn't work out with your SP.

HOW TO ANSWER QUESTIONS THAT YOUR HEART/MIND HAS WITH COMPASSION:

Why did the relationship end?

The mind will come up with any random story, even at the cost of your own wellbeing. Reflecting on what went wrong can be healthy, but overly doing it can lead to rumination. Allow yourself to be open to the idea that it just wasn't meant to be. Every single reason you can come up with will be secondary to this. It just wasn't meant to be. Full stop.

What could I have done differently?

Ask yourself why you're asking this question in the first place. If you are asking because you want to do better for your next relationship, then ask yourself, **"What CAN I do differently going into this new relationship?"** Take the power away from the past. But if you're asking what you could've done to change the outcome, perhaps you might need to ask yourself, **"What if you couldn't have done anything differently?"** What if your love was everything, enough, and more, and it just wasn't meant to be?

How can I cope with the pain of the breakup?

You already are. If you can ask, that means that you are. The question you are really asking is when will this suffering end? But instead, ask yourself: Who is the person feeling the pain to begin with? Who is the being that poses this question in the first place? Recognize that your essence is infinite, and you always have the space to hold your “identity” in its pain.

Will I never find love again?

When was love something that you ever had to find? It’s always been within you. It’s something you decided to give. So yes, you can always find love again, as long as you open yourself up and allow yourself to. Love is never dependent on the other person. It’s up to you whether you open yourself up to it or not.

Should I stay friends with my ex?

No human relationship can be summarized with a yes or no answer. But generally, the question you should be asking is “**why do you want to be friends with your ex in the first place?**” Are you trying to avoid the process of letting go? On some level, do you still need them in your life? There are no wrong answers, but answering these questions is pivotal to recognize where you’re coming from. If you happen to find yourself in a situation where you and your ex can find each other again, that is beautiful. But just because you can, doesn’t mean that you should. If you are lucky enough to completely detach and then find each other again, then count your blessings. But if not, just be grateful that you got to share an experience with them.

How can I stop feeling so lonely?

Loneliness is a belief system, not a feeling. It's telling yourself that where you are, what you're experiencing is the only thing that there is. I'll give you an example. Spending time alone on a Friday night while you were with your SP might not seem so lonely because you believe that it's just one night (for example) and that you do "have someone". But after a breakup, that same Friday night may be the loneliest night of your life, but the only thing that has changed is your belief system. So rather than fighting it, ask yourself what you need, how you can be there for yourself. How you can love yourself deeper. It's not about the feeling, but how you treat yourself in the face of the feeling.

Will I ever trust someone again?

Trust is a leap of faith. It's not actually about someone else. The question is, **can you trust yourself again?** When you are hurt by someone you trusted deeply, a part of yourself feels guilt for trusting them, and another part of you feels anger towards the part of yourself that trusted them as well. But at the end of the day, the trust was something that you gave to the other person. Part of healing this wound is forgiving yourself for trusting, allowing yourself to be hurt, and then holding space for those feelings to just be. Trust is always a leap of faith. The reason why we "stop trusting" people is because we convince ourselves that we have seen enough, that we understand every single outcome, and that no matter what happens, we are doomed to a certain outcome. You just have to assure yourself that you have it in you to pick yourself back up regardless of what happens. This is what it

means to live unapologetically and authentically. You tell the world that regardless of what the outcome is, you will be you. You will care about and love what you love and care about (not make it about everyone else). You're not ignoring your fear, you're recognizing it's there and still acting in spite of it. This is what it means to act from self love. Because when you act irregardless of your fears, you tell the innermost parts of yourself, that no matter what happens, you got yourself. That you can weather any storm, any heartbreak, and you will always come out on top in the end.

How do I deal with reminders of the relationship?

A great question to ask yourself is why you want to “deal” with the reminders of your SP. The framing here is that being reminded of your SP is a bad thing. However, there is some nuance here. At the beginning of your healing journey, too many reminders of them may hinder your process, but later in the journey, eliminating all reminders means discarding parts of yourself. The key to the healing process is balance. If you are highly emotional, it's very likely that you cannot actually act from a place of balance. Don't be in such a rush to “deal” with the reminders of your SP, because as you heal, you may come to find that you actually miss these reminders. Cherish missing them, embrace it, and hold space for it to be, because that too, ends one day. Your pain is a response to everything that isn't, not everything that is.

Should I reach out to my ex?

No.

Okay, obviously, I want to add some nuance here, but the relationship ended for a reason. If you were the one who ended it, reaching out will only hurt them more, and nothing will change. The only time you should reach out to an ex is if you have every intention of apologizing and trying again (A large amount of nuance is required here). But if they broke up with you, there really is no reason to reach out. You can't convince them into loving you back, and if you do convince them to get back with you out of pity, whether it's tomorrow or next year, eventually one of you is going to realize you aren't meant to be together, anyway.

How can I move on from the past?

The moment you stop trying to "move on" is the day you have moved on. Because as long as you try to "move on", you essentially tell yourself that you're not there yet. That you still need to do something, figure something out, or say something. But the healing process is a process, not an outcome. Once you accept that they're gone, accept that you love them, accept that it hurts, and be okay with not being okay, is when you really heal. **Healing isn't about fixing yourself; it's about realizing you weren't ever broken to begin with.** Create space for yourself to just be. You are the being that exists within the "human being".

What if my ex moves on before I do?

If you are in your healing process, you should not know whether they move on or not. But if somehow you come across this information, then realize that letting go of a person is letting go of the future ideal of who you wanted them to be. This means that the person your SP is now isn't the same person you once knew. The version of your SP that you knew has died, passed away, and is no longer the person that exists in this world. Allow this stranger to live their best life. They aren't your SP. Let them live, and let your SP rest in peace. Grieve your loss, and build an understanding that this "other person" moving on, is just another person in this world finding love, and that's something you can be grateful for (the nuance here isn't to dissociate and be delusional but to accept that people change, this is a new version of your SP not **literally** another person).

ESCAPING HYPER INDEPENDENCE, HOW TO PUT THE SWORD DOWN.

Part of the healing process includes being hypervigilant and being ready to defend yourself from any threat that comes your way. This might mean being overly eager to spend time alone, and overzealous when it comes to cutting people off. You shouldn't feel wrong for this. It is not wrong to be untrusting during a time of war. During a dark night of your soul, you have to fight to survive. But as with all things, it is not meant to last. Coming out of the hyper independence phase is scary, because it means admitting you are ready to be at peace again. When you've been fighting for so long, remembering peace can be extremely difficult. When you recognize that you have the ability to put the sword down and tend to your garden, be willing to. It will be scary; this is a fact. Start small. Start by trusting someone to do something small. Be willing to allow someone to let you down. Allow yourself to be offended — and hold space for it anyway. This is the path to relinquishing enemies. It is the ultimate form of self love. Creating so much safety that you can allow yourself to be at peace.

This is the ultimate phase of your healing. The end goal isn't to become so independent that we can no longer connect with others; it's to be able to connect with others even after all that has happened. Often what

holds people back is the fear of going back, and repeating old patterns of codependency. We often think the only solution to codependence is some extreme reaction of hyper independence. But if we are better alone, then there wouldn't be a point to community. Humans are built for connection. This is a fact. The intention isn't to remove ourselves from it or to avoid the feelings that come with it, but rather to no longer be so attached to it.

Moving from hyper independence requires making the realization that trusting again, working with others again will mean opening yourself up to the possibility of being hurt again. But because you have healed, you know that you could handle the outcome, regardless of what it is.

LESSONS IN LIBERATION: LETTING GO IS A GIFT TO ALL.

The most liberating thing you can do for yourself is to let go. Let go of who you need them to be, let go of your need to be with them, let go of who you expect yourself to be, and free yourself from the story of what you need to be lovable. **Letting go isn't akin to losing; it's a liberation from pain for everyone involved.**

When you ponder this deeply, if your energy is tied to someone else, you are actually on some level holding them back. Whether this is with the burden of your expectation or your need for them, keeping your energy tied to them holds them back. If they are no longer in your life, you are also holding yourself back by anchoring yourself to something that no longer holds space in your life. By cutting your attachment to them, you free them of expectation, you free yourself of loss, and you embrace a better future. You are telling yourself that you are deserving, and that love is something meant for you, even if you can't see it at the moment. Oftentimes, the reason we hold on is that we believe we can only feel love in the presence of this person. To some degree, they give us permission to love ourselves. Instead of depending on them, take ownership and just love yourself anyway.

Healing is a continuous choice of holding on, and letting go, until you realize setting them free is the greatest gift you could give them, and yourself. So if you find yourself falling back for them, do not fret. This is normal, and what will inevitably lead you to finally letting go. It's not just about them, or not just about you. It's a choice that you have to face to find peace again. It might take you a few tries, but that's what letting go is. It's letting go and then holding on again. It's trying to stand back up, only to fall back down.

Because, in the end, letting go is the gift of freedom. Freeing them from who you need them to be and freeing yourself from your need for them. This is an act of liberation beyond yourself. It ripples into their lives as well (even if it doesn't seem so). It's creating an environment for everyone to win.

FINDING YOURSELF IN HEARTBREAK, WHO ARE YOU AFTER SAYING GOODBYE?

The process of self (re)discovery is one of the most important things we have to persist through during heartbreak, and it's also one of the gifts of loss. When we lose someone we love on a deep level, they reveal to us what we truly cherish and seek in our own lives. Maybe they created adventure in our lives, revealing to ourselves that we need adventure. Maybe they were extremely kind to us, revealing that we need to be kinder to ourselves. Because it's not about them, love is always a mirror, showing something about ourselves.

You are always provided with the choice to frame your loss in a certain way. Whether it's something that will serve you, help you love, grow and function on a deeper level, is always up to you. Loss is never about the other person. It's always about how you hold yourself in their absence. Do you beat yourself up for love not working? **Do you discard your beliefs of love as if you were punishing something outside of yourself?** If you lost everything, why would it make sense to further your pain by disconnecting yourself from love?

When you “**give up on love**”, the only person who feels it, is you. The pain of heartbreak is your heart closing off. It is self betrayal on the highest level. It is telling yourself, in some capacity, that you don't deserve love because of everything that you have experienced. But, you are wrong.

In fact, in spite of and because of everything you have experienced, you can love on a deeper level. You can love so deeply that you can also feel grief on this level as well. Don't punish yourself for loving deeply.

“the container with which you use to experience pain and heartbreak is the very same with which you use to experience love and joy”

The pain you feel now is only a testament to how much you can love, how deeply you can feel, and how beautiful your heart truly is. It's not about whether things worked out, or happened in the way that you wanted. It's about allowing yourself to feel in SPITE of all these things. Keep your heart open, never close it. This is the gift you have to give yourself. Loving yourself doesn't mean going cold and closing your heart off. It's loving yourself so deeply, you open yourself up to the possibility of being hurt. You give yourself permission to care. You come from courage, knowing that you can pick yourself up regardless of what happens.

When people speak of finding themselves after heartbreak, they often talk of the improvements the heartbreak added to their lives. They may begin to take extra care of themselves by working out, dieting, or some other form of self care. They point towards the breakup as being the reason for their “glow up”. But the reason post breakup glow ups happen is because within the relationship, there was some level of neglect to begin with.

People often wait till a relationship ends before starting to work and care about themselves. As this is often the status quo, it reveals to us that we often abandon ourselves for the love of another person. Once you recognize

this, you can stop making it about them. Maybe they weren't the reason you didn't take care of yourself, but you were (nuance is important here).

Start taking care of yourself because you need to. Because you haven't been. It's not about proving to them that you're better, or showing them what they're missing. This is coming to terms with their absence. Say goodbye with grace.

Strangers.

A Poem

Isn't it crazy that you don't know me?
And that I don't know you?

And I don't say that to be cruel, but the
version of me that you knew was buried with
the version of you that loved him.

STRANGERS – A REFLECTION OF CHANGE

Strangers is a piece to reflect upon the moment that many of us are far too familiar with. It's a consideration that even after knowing someone so deeply, they too could one day become a stranger. That regardless of how deep the connection was, that it could one day just be a tale of the past. Every one of us will experience this one day. Because the truth is, people change, and people grow. Eventually, your SP, and you, for that matter, will grow into completely different people. The opening lines are a consideration of this change. That someone you knew so well is now a stranger. It's baffling to contemplate sometimes. It's an admission of the distance that has been created between two individuals despite once having shared a deep connection. The second stanza is a challenge to the idea that being strangers is a bad thing (as we so often make it out to be). **Claiming you and someone whom you once shared a connection with are now strangers isn't meant to be harmful; it's meant to be accepted.** The word "buried" was used to imply that growing and moving on involves letting go of a part of yourself that once was. It's grieving the past versions of yourself, and the past versions of them as well. It's a representation of the closure we sometimes find, accepting the reality of a changing connection. It's a recognition of the need to move forward. Realizing an unfamiliarity with your SP is something you have to go through eventually, and it's part of the process of letting go and moving on.

THE GHOSTS AND ECHOES OF A LOVE THAT ONCE WAS.

Relationships, heartbreak, and love have echoes and vibrations that we carry with us throughout the rest of our lives. These echoes sometimes haunt us as ghosts. They're a constant reminder that we could never go back to the way things were, no matter how hard we try. They're a reminder that we are where we are now, and not where we used to be. How you treat yourself during this process is also how you will find yourself in the next relationship you choose.

Impatience with yourself may mean impatience with your future partner (FP). Self attack may be projected onto your FP. When you can recognize this, you realize that being kind, and being open is really just serving yourself and your future on the highest level.

So when you are confronted by the echoes of the past, or haunted by the ghosts of once was, rejoice, this is your opportunity to open yourself up to love again. It is a reminder to your heart of how impactful and beautiful love can be, that it can transcend even time. Find joy and peace in the memories. Maybe they're even bittersweet. Cherish that too. Because one day, if you truly do find happiness with another person, these bittersweet memories will be just that; memories.

Because that's the hard truth to swallow. That we

all move on, eventually. That love in all of its greatness eventually ends one day. That from one perspective, love actually failed, as all things do. The echoes and ghosts are a reminder of this, that it does in fact end. These reminders aren't an excuse to hold on to a past that once was, but rather an opportunity to move forward. A checkpoint in your healing journey that enables you to stop and ponder for a moment. Allow yourself to remember, and then to accept that it is all gone. They are ghosts for a reason; they are echoes because they are no longer here.

A love that once was, will always be, just that. When you're reminded of who they used to be to you, this isn't some cosmic sign that you should go back. You can't. It's a reminder to accept that they are gone, that it is the past, and you're here now, in the present. This is how you stop being haunted. You just keep accepting it. Over and over again. Until one day, you realize that the ghosts and echoes of the past are no longer such a big deal. That although they once shook up your world, you can now accept them for what they are. You choose to move forward in spite of the fact you still remember.

HOW TO DO THE INNER WORK

A lot of people say healing is hard, breaking the cycle is hard, and doing the inner work is hard. If you think this way, know that your feelings are valid. But staying broken, being trapped in a cycle, and repeating toxic patterns is just as hard. Either way, you have to decide which one you will commit to.

Showing up for yourself is hard. It sometimes means disagreeing with the world. Maybe everything in your life has shown you that you're unlovable. Are you willing to go against this evidence and still love yourself, anyway? Yes, it is hard to believe something when everything goes against it, but that's why most of us are trapped in cycles. Are you willing to do the work when you really don't want to? To be kind to yourself when you're upset? It will take everything you have (and more) to heal yourself. But in the end, it will all be worth it.

You can be happy again. You can find your smile again. You can reconnect with your inner child. You can fall in love again. You can believe in love again. Everything you've ever wanted is possible.

Pay attention to how you feel as you read these statements. What comes up for you? Are you feeling excited because

you know it to be true, or are you feeling resistance because you don't truly believe in these statements? Focus on that resistance, breathe into it, and accept it as a part of yourself that has been **severely hurt**. Love it, give it compassion and kindness, and tell that part of yourself it will be okay. This is how you do the inner work and start to heal yourself.

HOW TO GET OVER SOMEONE IF YOU ARE DELUSIONAL (I AM)

If you are a fellow delusional person, you must know by this point that all you need to keep going is a liked story (so real) or a runaway fairy tale idea to keep yourself attached. Rather than beating yourself up for being a delusional person, recognize where you're coming from. Essentially, the story you are "living" is solving some problem in your narrative. Whether you're attached to a "tragic hero" story or an "underdog" story, there is some story you are telling yourself that is causing you to be delusional.

On some level, you know this, which is why it's so easy to joke about being "delusional" in the first place (most people who are actually medically delusional are not aware of it). All you need to do to get out of a delusional loop is commit to a reality. For me, this reality is also another story that I tell myself. Committing to a different reality may mean telling yourself that your SP is actually an alien sent to study humans, and the breakup was just the end of their academic expedition. The story isn't itself actually important, but rather the act of committing to something that isn't the status quo story. You are willingly forgoing this fantasy for another one that doesn't affect you in a negative way. Being delusional isn't necessarily a bad thing. If used correctly, you can use it to do and become whatever you choose (with

nuance). When you recognize this, you no longer antagonize this part of yourself, but accept it for what it is, permitting yourself to actually be who you are.

So the takeaway here isn't to restrict yourself from living fantasies or telling yourself stories, but to take an honest audit of when they are really holding you back. You need to develop the nuance to know when you are actually causing yourself harm (and you do know). Whether you are still holding on to a crush, or something more serious, like an ex, there is something that may be slightly out of your awareness, causing you to hold on.

Take a second to evaluate this. What is the fantasy or fairy tale that is causing you to hold on? Do you think that dating this person or getting this person back will magically fix something in your life? Be honest, you need to for yourself. Once you recognize your delusion isn't your identity but rather a symptom of something deeper, you no longer take it personally.

Ironically, getting over someone is almost never about them. It's about getting over the stories and fairy tales we attach ourselves to. **The funny part is that getting over them is really just getting over ourselves.**

HOW JUDGEMENTS IN YOUR MIND KEEP YOU “STUCK” ON YOUR SP.

I think one of the main reasons why people can get stuck on a person is because of the labeling judgements in their mind. For example, if a person were to come across an attractive person, they can freely accept that this person is attractive without their self esteem being affected. But if you take the very same situation with their SP, they begin to feel insecure because their SP is attractive. Take a step back and recognize this is a judgment in your mind. The hard part of getting over someone is recognizing that what made them special was your choice to put them in that position.

When I was young, we would always make these cards for Father's Day and Mother's Day, where we would write “you're the #1 dad/mom in the world”, and this confused me. Because if everyone in the class had the number one dad, how could my dad be number one as well? The reason why people are special to us is that we choose to see them in this light. This isn't wrong, but understand that it's one of the fundamental building blocks of relationships.

When you can come from this place, you always have the choice to take back your power from this person. This isn't to say that they are not individually special as a person, but that they are special in a way that is unattached from what you want them to be. It's recognizing that the reason

why they were a “perfect” compliment to you is because you allowed them to be.

The reason why people say they will never find a love as great again is because they close their heart off and decide they will never let themselves love like that ever again. It's a difficult fact to accept, but the reason why we hold such strong attachments to people is because we choose to do so. Recognizing this isn't cause to blame, but rather gives you the opportunity to take responsibility. To a certain extent, if you're stuck on someone, it means that you are choosing to hold on to them for some reason. Don't beat yourself up for this, as your reason is probably as valid as any other. But take responsibility for it, and don't victimize yourself.

Hold the part of you that needs to hold on to them, and love that part with everything you've got. Maybe the story you've told yourself is that your SP made you happy. What you're really saying is that you don't inherently deserve to be happy without them. Moving on means questioning these beliefs. Are you ready to accept that you are lovable? That you deserve to be happy? That you don't have to hold on to pain anymore?

If you are very stuck in your pain story, believing otherwise is very difficult. Remind yourself. Open yourself up, take it one step at a time. The reason why you are stuck is that you have some inherent belief system about what it means to love them. You have framed your suffering as part of a greater plan, a greater story. Be honest with yourself; create love and compassion for yourself to recognize you are doing this. It's not judgemental. It's warm, open, and accepting. You recognize your hurt for how it is, but decide that you will no longer tolerate it moving forward. The cycle of pain ends with yourself.

To break a cycle, you have to be willing to feel in the opposite direction. If you're lonely? Assure yourself with your presence. **If you feel unlovable?** Be unrelenting in your self compassion and never stop reminding yourself that you are lovable. **You feel like you will never find love again?** Comfort that part of yourself, but doubt it. Believe in something greater, and be willing to be wrong. What if you do find love again? What if you find more happiness than you could ever imagine? What if it turns out better than you could have ever thought?

Allow your mind to be wrong. Allow your assumptions to be assumptions and reassure yourself otherwise. Move forward with confidence and courage, and remind yourself that even if you can't feel it, even if it feels like it will take forever, that you will always be there for yourself. No matter what it takes. Unrelenting, unwavering, and indomitable. This is the power of yourself. You have the capacity to love yourself beyond anything that you could ever receive from another person (this isn't an excuse for hyper independence). Be willing to hold yourself in your discomfort. Love yourself at your breaking point. Love yourself no matter what. This is what you have to do to get unstuck.

THE STOP METHOD. BREAKING OUT OF A PATTERN USING MINDFULNESS.

This is a common tool used in Cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT) or Dialectical Behavior Therapy (DBT). It's a great tool to stop overthinking, and it's meant to take cognitive control between a stimulus and a conditioned or automatic response. When you're stuck in a pattern, whether it's spiraling thoughts or some physical response like anxiety, recognize that you are in control. Remind your mind and body who is in charge. If you find yourself spiraling, it's as simple as stomping your foot on the ground, imagining a stop sign, and yelling out "STOP" verbally.

It's meant to reground yourself in your body. If you are feeling resistance to doing this seemingly "cringe" thing, just do it. Try it and see what the outcome is. The point of it is to "cringe" — by acting in such a manner you are actually breaking the cycle of thinking and emotional spiraling. Sometimes this is all you need to break out of a negative thought pattern/loop.

In the context of heartbreak, we often find ourselves in emotional patterns and thought loops, just going along for the ride without any control whatsoever. The reason why it's helpful to use the STOP method is because it gives you back some level of agency. However, this is only a tool/skill and not some magical cure for anxiety. It's important to note

that some feelings are meant to pass through you, and some thought patterns are not.

The distinction here is that certain feelings need to be felt, but not every thought pattern needs to be played out. As you navigate the emotions of heartbreak, it will take a level of discretion and mindfulness to decide when something is self destructive or helpful to you.

HOW SELF ATTACK DESTROYS PEOPLE AFTER HEARTBREAK

The thing that's heartbreaking about separation isn't the separation itself. It isn't the toxic relationships that exes have or the loss of something invaluable. The soul crushing thing about heartbreak is the way that people treat themselves in the face of it. Whether they give up on love because they make it about their SP or develop belief systems contrary to their needs, **people often treat themselves worse than any ex could ever treat them.**

They beat themselves down, berate their hearts, and constantly tell themselves they are not enough. It is truly heartbreaking to watch this process occur. They hold onto something that is not meant for them, because they don't believe that they could find something better. They tell themselves a negative story and develop it into their belief system. If you catch yourself doing this, it's the first step. **You have to admit that you, in fact, are currently at the top of your list of people who have hurt you.** You have to be willing to let go. It's scary. It's terrifying. Let go of the idea that you're not lovable, let go of your tragic story, and open yourself up to the idea that you deserve to be happy. Are you ready to accept the fact that you are lovable? That you are special? That a breakup doesn't actually define you; only you choose whether it does or not? That at the end of the day it's

never actually about the other person, but how you see the situation in the end?

Closing yourself off to love “because you gave everything, and it didn’t work out” is just telling yourself that things will never work out for you. It’s the equivalent of a child telling their parents their dreams, and the parents immediately crushing their dreams on the spot, telling them it could never be done. When you tell yourself it’s never going to work out, you are essentially telling your inner child that you are unable to create space for their dreams. If you look inward honestly, there is a part of you that yearns for love to be real, for you to be lovable and accepted. It’s truly heartbreaking that people discard this part of themselves (I have before). If there isn’t space for your inner child’s greatest dreams in this world, then you have to do everything in your power to make space for it. It’s in your imperative and your very being. At the very least, don’t crush your own dreams; don’t berate yourself for wishing for better. It just means you have to be willing to go for it, even if it seems impossible. **It is loving yourself unconditionally; it is allowing yourself to try again. Please, give yourself this gift.** Please allow yourself to try again. Your inner child is depending on you. This most tender, vulnerable part of yourself needs you to give everything for them and to try when you can’t. This time when you love, recognize that it’s not for the outcome. It’s creating space for your inner child to dream, to believe in something greater. Even if it doesn’t work out, that’s okay, at the very least, and always, you can love that part of yourself.

Loving yourself when “no one else” does is terrifying. Speaking your truth when the world says otherwise is insurmountable. Loving in the face of everything else will always seem impossible. It’s not about someone else. It’s

about your relationship with yourself. How are you meeting yourself in the face of all of it? How far are you willing to go for yourself? You will always have the choice to abandon yourself in the face of adversity and in the face of pain. You can always “change”, and become cold and careless to “get ahead”, but you will only harm your innermost self at the end of the day. You will harm the part of yourself that believed in something greater, that wished for an outcome different from the status quo.

Giving up on the possibilities is the greatest act of self betrayal. You need to come to recognize this. Yes, the heartbreak was unbearable, and no one deserves to feel the way that you did, but continuing to perpetuate this pain within yourself is self betrayal. If you truly believe in love, if you truly love yourself, find it again. Find it within yourself, find your spark again, find love all around you, and be willing to be yourself unapologetically. Moving on, making them jealous, or taking revenge is irrelevant. How you treat yourself is everything. **It doesn't matter how the world treated you or what happened to you; you never have the right to abuse yourself.** It doesn't matter how badly the world hurts you, hurting yourself should never be an option.

HOW TO STOP CATASTROPHIZING - SURRENDER TO THE FACT YOU'RE HUMAN, YOU'RE NOT GOD

One reason why heartbreak can be such an impossible thing to navigate is because, as humans, we can only see within our perception. We can only believe things with proof or evidence when life doesn't work that way. A person who goes from rags to riches will never have proof that they can be successful till they get there. A person who believes they will never find love will never have proof until they are loved.

After a heartbreak, we do this thing where we convince ourselves that we aren't lovable, that we will never find it again. The question isn't whether it's true or not (it's not), but whether you have the courage to find out, anyway. Maybe you're wrong. What if you are wrong? (you are), you will find it again, and you can be happier than you could ever imagine. Stop trying to claim that you are smarter than all of existence and that this one particular outcome has decided and shaped your entire life. Be willing to question it.

Start by opening up to the idea that maybe your mind is playing tricks on you. Maybe you're not seeing everything that there is, and maybe you're framing it in a certain way that's holding you back. Just slowly open yourself up to the idea that some of your negative assumptions may be wrong. You may never see the proof before believing something, so you have to be willing to find out. You have to be willing to

take the leap of faith. It's saying: **I don't know whether I am lovable or unlovable, but I am willing to find out. Until then, I will believe that I am.** Stop thinking you're smart enough to predict everyone's minds, that you can understand everything and how the entire world works. Just surrender to the fact that it's unknown, and maybe you have to find out. This is how you accept that, although things are the way they are, there is a possibility of change. You just haven't seen it all yet. You haven't figured it all out, and there is more than just what you can perceive. Your perception is limited to the experience you have had, not all experience itself. When it comes to heartbreak, a few heartbreaks aren't some universal indication that you aren't lovable.

Admit that you don't know everything, you can't. For all you know, the heartbreak happened for some reason you may never know the reason for. This is how you surrender to the fact that you're human. It's admitting that certain things are out of your control. Because when you relinquish control over the things that aren't, you take control of those things that are.

HOW TO ACTUALLY HEAL, AND BREAK TRAUMA CYCLES.

1. Change your mind box.

Your mind replays a bunch of sound bites from things you experience in your life. Whether it's your ex telling you that you weren't enough, or your parents telling you that you're too much, or someone on social media telling you how you're supposed to live, there's probably a lot of noise in your head. At any time, you can record over these voices.

Start small. Walk for 10 minutes every day, and listen to a positive voice, rather than the negative default one. This is why some people find affirmations very helpful.

2. Renegotiate your relationship with fear and discomfort.

Every single one of us is in a relationship with fear and discomfort. You can't avoid it, it's part of being human. But you are also the one who decides the terms of this relationship. You get to change the kind of relationship you have with fear and discomfort.

If you don't want fear to rule over your life, then allow yourself to be scared. If you don't want discomfort to hold you back, then allow yourself to be uncomfortable.

This might mean trying things that terrify you. It might mean experiencing things that you might initially think are impossible.

3. This is part of renegotiating with discomfort, but cold plunges and breathwork.

When you consistently face discomfort, you essentially tell yourself you have what it takes to overcome painful and stressful situations. That you don't have to find yourself trapped in a cycle, because you are the one choosing your direction to begin with. A very helpful tool to face this discomfort is through cold plunges and breathwork/meditation. Just try it and stick with it for a few months (trust me).

4. Work with some kind of accountability system (generally friends don't count), a coach, therapist, or community

The reason why friends don't normally count as accountability is because we often go to friends for comfort, only to feel slighted when given solutions. It's hard to build an accountability system with friends (not impossible, just harder). But when you have a professional, intentional relationship with a coach, therapist, or community, it has a more clear and defined purpose, and someone can better hold us accountable.

5. Build a habit to move you forward. Physical exercise, reading - lower the bar.

One of the reasons many people find it hard to heal and break trauma cycles is because the amount of work seems taxing and insurmountable. To overcome this, lower the bar. Stop making healing an impossible task. Maybe you need to read 1 page a day to move forward, or you need to walk for 5 minutes. Lower the bar and do something good for yourself.

HOW TO LET GO:

By this point, I'm sure you know the answer is that you don't. Letting go isn't something you do one time, but something you do continuously throughout the experience of your healing journey (your time here on earth). Letting go is a decision to move forward, to stay committed to your intention regardless of what happens. It's opening yourself up to missing them, to feeling broken, to being human. You are accepting that you are not a product of your past situation, but that you get to decide who you are going to be. It means opening yourself up to the idea that their story isn't your story to be in.

When you can accept that fact, you also admit to yourself that you have something else coming for you as well. Understanding that someone else being happy doesn't have to take away from you is the most liberating human experience of all.

We are all living our own stories.

When you are triggered and something comes up, this is only an opportunity for you to hold space for it. To permit yourself to be human is the greatest opportunity of all. Breathe into it, and just accept it for what it is.

Letting go is a process, not an outcome. You will be tested with situations again and again, and it may feel like you are not going anywhere. **This is what healing can feel like sometimes. It's a process of continuous falling down, and getting back up again.**

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

This book began as my own therapy project that was initially just a tool for me to process what happened.

I wouldn't have been able to get to this point if it wasn't for my amazing coach and mentor, Andrea. It was the work with her that really solidified many of the lessons I wrote about in this book. Sometimes when you're lost, you just need a single person to believe in you and remind you that you can move forward. When I met Andrea I was quite lost, and couldn't conceive how it would ever be possible for me to move forward. Working with her allowed me to stay accountable in my healing process and simultaneously have someone to rally for me when it felt like I personally couldn't.

My best friend Jenny, who put up with all of my late night rants and aimless ramblings. She was a pivotal part of helping me find myself when I was beyond lost. She's been a friend who always knows what to say, even if I don't really wanna hear it at the time. She's a friend that always inspires me to be the best version of myself (especially when I don't want to).

My great friend Selena, who was there the many times I needed a pick me up and a reassuring voice, and all the other family and friends who have supported me along

this journey.

Obviously, I would have never gotten here if I hadn't gone through the heartbreak itself. To the person who will not be named, I am extremely grateful I got to experience this. Going through the experience was hard beyond any comprehension I could have had going into it, yet it was simultaneously one of the greatest experiences of my life. Sometimes lessons come at a price, and this one will always be one of the most expensive lessons I've had to pay for.

thank you.

THIS IS GOODBYE

The final unsent letter

*Hey *~! It's been like forever baba. So just to start off, damn that was hard (dat sbiet hurted LMAO). How have you been? I know it's redundant to ask, because I think I know you well enough to answer, but is your love everything you were looking for?*

I'm glad.

You know it's funny, because there was a period of time where it killed me to realize you had found a love that ours could never be (I honestly had a panic attack when I ran into you guys BAHAAH). Remember when I said "even if you fall in love with someone else, I'd be happy that at least you found love"? I promised that no matter how much it hurt, that I'd survive, and I'd thrive, and that regardless of what happened moving forward, I would live my best life. That promise has been kept (with many attempts). I really am thriving, but I do still miss you sometimes (barely tho LMAO JK). The thought just passes by, and it's a nice reminder of a love that was just never meant to be. It's so funny I used to think you were my soulmate, but I sorta realized you're more like my soul rival (AS IN IT'S ON SITE jkjk). You completed me, past tense. The universe never intended for us to have a lasting place in each other's lives, yet I had to meet you to find myself. You were just the lesson I never wanted to be.

I guess we both were. You had to lose me to love someone else, and I had to lose you to love myself (what a crazy price we had to pay right??). So yeah, you “completed” me. Before meeting you I really hadn’t met anyone as competitive as me. With you, I had to either lose, or to let us both win (cuz ik you don’t lose LMAO). I’m sure you know me though, and that I wasn’t going to lose either, so I chose for both of us to win. I think that was the lesson for this love. It was a love I could never beat. When I told you I love you more, I didn’t know I was actually talking about the heartbreak I was going to face, my need to be with you, or the darkest parts of myself. It seems futile now, that I tried so hard to force a love that just wasn’t meant to be (tbh sry I was kinda delusional, you were right.. as usual..). I see now that you’re meant to be with him. It sounds almost fantastical to me (it’s the delulu fr) that I ever imagined a life other than the one right in front of me. I guess it just makes SO MUCH sense now. That we are happy, and you were never my enemy; I just wasn’t the right one for you — and I see that now. You didn’t choose someone else over me, you chose your person. In a world where it’s so hard to find love, at the very least, I’m really glad that you did ♡•. You were never my sad ending; you were just not my ending. Don’t get me wrong though; I’m glad I got to play a role in your story, even if it wasn’t meant to be a lasting one — and for the record, I’m glad you did too. I think it was beautiful and poetic how we met and how we ended as well. Nothing makes sense in my heart more than what already is, and I really am grateful we got here. Do I have any regrets? Yeah, for sure. That time you made me sit through that 1 hour and 11 minute worst movie of all time (you know which one I’m talking about), that will always be my greatest regret (LMAOO). All jokes aside though, I think even though we ended, even though things turned out the way they did, I don’t regret it. I think I’ve come to realize

that neither of us could really do anything to change what had to happen. If we look at where our lives are now, it really seems futile to have ever imagined a different outcome. It truly was nice while it lasted, and is a story that will be remembered for a lifetime. So one day, when you walk down the aisle, and complete the great love story that's yours, I hope you remember that "I am glad to see you win". How could I claim to be on the side of love if I can't even support it in someone I love? (right?) We've grown so far in different directions now that we just don't make sense. If I'm being honest, I don't think we ever did. Looking back, there was a time where I would rewrite the stars just to find my way back to you, but I now realize I wouldn't change anything. Not because you're "not worth it" or I deserve "better" (you're pretty awesome), but because I realized you're not who I'm meant to find. Everyone always MISUNDERSTANDS THIS LINE (but I'm sure you would get it) — I'm not gonna find someone better than you, but I'll find someone better for me. I am genuinely so glad everything happened the way it did, and I hope you know that there was nothing you could have done differently to have changed the outcomes of what happened (and neither could I). I know you tried your best and put your entire heart into that connection, and I will never think otherwise. I'm glad we didn't work out :) and I really am so happy for the both of us.

With all of that being said, I think I finally understand everything you said back then, and everything that you felt. I know I said that our connection was short, but it really wasn't. I think the moments we spent together were infinite, because I always loved you as if it was my last day on earth, and never held anything back. From my perspective, I got to love you for a lifetime, and that will always be enough. You will always be more than enough, which is why I always say I'm just so glad you exist. Because at this point, that's all I can really ask for, that you

continue existing, and that you just be out there. Words can't do it justice when I say it's just you. That's all I'll ever need, and you will always be more than enough to me.

You really are living proof that love is never wasted. I now say goodbye with a full and complete heart. Thank you for this experience.

I know we are better for it.

Genuinely with love, Goodbye •~•

I love this version of myself that you brought out.